

Contested urbanisms:

The politics of heritage and housing in Jakarta's kampungs

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March 2025

*Submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements of the Degree of Doctor of Philosophy in the
Department of Geography*

Thesis title:

Contested urbanisms:

The politics of heritage and housing in Jakarta's kampungs

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Declaration

I hereby declare that the work presented in this thesis has not been submitted for any other degree or professional qualification, and that it is the result of my own independent work.

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Abstract

Do heritage-making projects resist or advance gentrification in Southeast Asia? Like other Global South cities, contested urbanisms chequer Jakarta's postcolonial urban landscape. Competing ideas about urban development manifest in various ways of seeing and producing the city, as demonstrated by evictions, revitalisation projects, and informal housing. Increased evictions of urban villages (*urban kampungs*) between 2013 and 2018 in Jakarta saw growing grassroots heritage movements as part of a spectrum of resistance to top-down urban management by state and private sector actors who also stake their claims on what 'heritage' is.

These tensions amongst the political projects of various actors led me to ask: how do heritage-making projects of/by urban villages affect housing conditions in Jakarta, with reference to gentrification-led displacement? Using ethnographic methods and thematic analysis, I delve into the constructions of heritage, the impact of heritage-making on housing security for residents, and the broader political impact of heritage-making from above and below in Jakarta's *Kota Tua* and two of its kampungs, Luar Batang and Pekojan.

I argue that the dominant heritage constructions in Kota Tua demonstrate a top-down logic that emphasises infrastructure and the built environment with strong private sector presence, which impact the kampungs in varied ways. Findings showed that top-down heritage-making demonstrates higher likelihood of driving gentrification through the commodification of space, prioritising capital and material values. Residents and their advocates employ heritage-making from below in various forms to reclaim their place in the city as they face various forms of displacement, with unanticipated consequences. The processes of heritage-making from above and below reveal the connections and disjunctures between different authorities which subaltern actors work through, producing new politics that contest or entrench existing conditions. The findings contribute to the theorising of the politics of gentrification in heritage and urban studies, and a deeper understanding of Jakarta's Old Town.

Acknowledgements

I look back at my first proposals and am overcome with immense gratitude to everyone who made this happen. To all in Jakarta, London, Singapore, and the spaces in between, who assembled the enduring threads for this tapestry of a journey, thank you.

I could not have asked for better supervisors than Lisa Tilley and Melissa Butcher. Lisa's warm and kind acceptance from the get-go brought me to Birkbeck Politics, and to Melissa in Geography. That we began this journey in the same college during a pandemic across different time zones and found ourselves each in different places at the end, is a testament to their generosity, grace, and patience throughout the whole process. Their trust and empathy which held space for the messy, intersecting spheres of life made my doctoral experience a humane and empowering one. I always came away from our meetings energised, and with renewed resolve for the meandering roads ahead. Mara Nogueira and Rita Padawangi were engaged examiners whose constructive comments and feedback helped shape the final version of this thesis.

I am indebted to many in Jakarta, both in the *kampung* and *kampus*. Much gratitude to participants from Kota Tua, in particular Luar Batang and Pekojan, with special mentions to Daeng Mansur, and Pak Usman. Much respect to kampung residents who taught me what it is like to be in this world as a wayfarer. Hearing their voices anew through the recordings, and getting occasional updates carried me through the arduous parts of writing up. The memory of coming home with bottles of water after a day in the kampung reminds me of their hospitality, but also their struggles. Annisa, Halimah, and Sulaiman were companions in the field who informed and challenged my perspectives and made fieldwork less lonely. Much thanks to Pak Kemas, Bu Herlily, and Arum at Universitas Indonesia for their guidance, support, and the wonderful culinary experiences. Various individuals and organisations in Jakarta who work with the marginalised, the urban poor, and kampung communities - your projects and conviction inspire me.

I am grateful for the fellow sufferers who were sent my way at each stage of the process. Diyanah, Hazirah, Jinwen, Meiyun, and Latipah, have been there to commiserate and motivate. In the field and at postgraduate conferences and workshops, I had the great chance of learning from the knowledge and experience of fellow researchers, and practitioners.

Pre-PhD, LKYCIC in Singapore was a formative time. Sharon Siddique, who modelled and nurtured intellectual curiosity and kindness, insisted that I did not give up on applying for a PhD. Chan Heng Chee taught me what discipline and determination look like. Both were chiefly responsible for growing my interest in urban studies and Indonesia. Sree and the RAs have provided enduring mentorship and friendships that transcended our shared time there.

The ISEAS-Yusof Ishak Institute PhD Scholarship gave me indispensable financial support, and the freedom to pursue my doctoral research. Much appreciation also goes to the Birkbeck Politics and Geography departments, Graduate Research School and Library staff, SOAS Development Studies folks, Suffa and SMSO networks, Sew4Pal comrades, and Russell Square sojourners. I am lucky to have a few good friends who occasionally remind me to emerge from the 'cave'.

This thesis is dedicated to my parents, my sister and her little family, who suffered from my work and have supported me in more ways than I can fathom, especially during the last 4.5 tough years.

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List of abbreviations

DPP	Priority Destinations (Destinasi Pariwisata Prioritas)
JEFORAH	Jakarta Endowment for Art and Heritage
JOTRC	Jakarta Old Town Revitalization Corporation (PT Pembangunan Kota Tua Jakarta or Konsorsium Kota Tua Jakarta)
KSPN	National Strategic Tourism Areas (Kawasan Strategis Pariwisata Nasional)
Pokdarwis	Tourism Awareness Group (Kelompok Sadar Wisata)
PSN	National Strategic Project (Proyek Strategis Nasional)
RDTR	Detailed Spatial Plan (Rencana Detail Tata Ruang)
RT	Neighbourhood Association (Rukun Tetangga)
RTRW	Regional Spatial Plan (Rencana Tata Ruang Wilayah)
RW	Residents'/Citizens' Association (Rukun Warga)
TACB	Cultural Heritage Expert Team (Tim Ahli Cagar Budaya)
TSP	Heritage Review Board (Tim Sidang Pemugaran)
UDGL	Urban Design Guidelines (Rencana Tata Bangunan dan Lingkungan)
UPK Kota Tua	Kota Tua Management Unit (Unit Pengelola Kawasan Kota Tua)
UMKM	Micro, small, and medium-sized businesses (Usaha Mikro, Kecil, dan Menengah)

Chapter 1. Introduction

1.1. Contested urbanisms: The politics of heritage and housing in Jakarta's kampungs

Jakarta, situated on the island of Java, is the capital and largest city of Indonesia. Formally known as DKI Jakarta (*Daerah Khusus Ibukota Jakarta* – Special Capital Region of Jakarta), it is one of the megacities in the world, with a population in excess of 11 million in 2024 (World Population Review, 2024). Like other Global South cities, contested urbanisms chequer Jakarta's postcolonial urban landscape. Competing ideas about urban development manifest in various ways of seeing and producing the city, from above and below, as demonstrated by evictions, displacement, revitalisation projects, flood mitigation, and informal housing. Increased evictions of urban kampungs (urban villages, or self-built urban settlements) between 2013 and 2018 in Jakarta saw growing grassroots heritage movements as part of a spectrum of resistance to top-down urban management (Siagian et al., 2023). Yet heritage claims are used not only by marginalized groups to protect their homes, livelihoods and cultural practices. State and other public and private actors also stake their claims on what 'heritage' is and shape historical narratives for their own purposes. For example, a consortium of private sector and state actors put forward a UNESCO nomination (2015-2018) for Jakarta's Old Town (*Kota Tua*), without much public consultation from surrounding communities and residents. Heritage-making¹ under these conditions presents tensions amongst and within the political projects of the various actors.

A key driver of contemporary urban transformation such as in the aforementioned examples has been termed neoliberal urbanism, linked closely with gentrification.² Under these conditions, the puzzle which motivates my thesis is whether heritage-making projects resist or advance gentrification in Jakarta. Specifically, I ask: how do heritage-making projects of/by urban villages affect housing conditions in Jakarta, with reference to gentrification-led

¹ I define heritage-making as a varied and unfinished process of meaning-making and constructing the past in the present which different actors use for various future ends (see Chapter 2).

² Neoliberal urbanism (see Chapter 1) has been defined as a condition where cities become the focus of policies and practices which espouse "the belief that open, competitive, and 'unregulated' markets, liberated from state interference and the actions of social collectivities, represent the optimal mechanism for socioeconomic development" (Theodore et al., 2011, pp. 15, 24). Gentrification (see Chapter 2) is defined in this thesis as "the commodification of space accompanying land use changes in such a way that it produces indirect/direct/symbolic displacement of existing users and owners by more affluent groups" (Shin et al., 2016, p. 458 cited in Shin and López-Morales (2017)).

displacement? I delve into the constructions of heritage, the impact of heritage-making on housing security vis-à-vis displacement for kampung residents, and the broader political impact of heritage-making from below and above in Jakarta's Kota Tua and two of its kampungs, Luar Batang and Pekojan.

I argue that the dominant heritage constructions by key actors in Kota Tua demonstrate a top-down logic that emphasises infrastructure and the built environment, with a strong private sector presence, which impact the kampungs in varied ways. The research shows that top-down heritage-making demonstrates a higher likelihood of driving gentrification through the commodification of space, prioritising capital and material values with little consideration for low-income residents. Residents and their advocates employ heritage-making from below in various forms (buildings, traditions, and narratives) to reclaim their place in the city as they face various forms of displacement. Subaltern actors strive imperfectly to maintain their kampungs as spaces of living heritage, employing old and new mediums that democratise heritage-making through their attempts to reinforce and expand collective and community spaces and relations. These efforts have unanticipated consequences such as amplified precarity for some residents, and renewed politicisation of social differences that reflect the changing geographies of inequalities in Kota Tua and its neighbourhoods. The processes of heritage-making from above and below³ reveal contested ideas about urban development, and the connections and disjunctures between different authorities which subaltern actors work through, producing new power formations and politics that contest or entrench the existing order.

Following this, the second section presents an overview of the debates in contested urbanisms and gentrification, and how they play out in Jakarta, particularly in heritage protection. The third section outlines the research questions which arise from the case of Kota Tua and its kampungs, and the methodology to answer them. The fourth section gives a background to the

³ In this thesis, I use heritage-making from above and below interchangeably with top-down, state-led efforts, and people-led, subaltern heritage-making respectively, as relational categories which are not meant to perpetuate simplistic dichotomies. I am aware of the problematic uses of “subaltern”, and “from above” and “below”, and strive in this thesis to use them critically to trouble the binaries. While everyday people or residents may not necessarily consider themselves always marginalised, or they face differential marginalisation, interviews and ethnographic observations from this research informed my use of the term to demarcate the power asymmetries at play in Jakarta. I elaborate on the relation between the concepts in Chapter 3.

case study sites of Luar Batang and Pekojan. I outline the contribution and significance of this research in the fifth section, before finally providing the structure of this thesis.

1.2. Background

1.2.1 Gentrification, heritage, and urban studies

My research builds on key debates at the intersection of gentrification, heritage, and urban studies to examine the tensions and competing claims between political projects amongst and within different actors along different scales of politics (top-down, bottom-up, local-national-international). Gentrification studies is still nascent in the Indonesian context where heritage and housing issues are closely intertwined but seldom examined as such. While western-derived theories of gentrification and heritage are useful references, markers and politics of gentrification surface differently in postcolonial contexts of development such as Jakarta. Critical heritage studies have recently given more attention to heritage-making from below, examining actors and more precarious sites of living heritage beyond dominant heritage objects and discourses (Kouri, 2022; Muzaini & Minca, 2018). However, as I show in Chapters 4 and 6, the relations between heritage from above and below need to be further explored as they are not always mutually exclusive. In urban studies of the Global South, understandings of various forms of gentrification-led displacement of the urban village in cities such as Jakarta is emergent.

As will be seen in the following chapters, there are various features of neoliberal urbanism present in Kota Tua, such as the privatisation of public goods, the imposing of a particular spatial order, the push for ‘world class’ benchmarks, and the catering to affluent groups (e.g. upper middle-class citizens, and foreign tourists), under a market-driven urban development and state-society relations (Coombe & Weiss, 2015). These “mechanisms of neoliberal urbanization” (Theodore et al., 2011) are important to attend to for a better understanding of the contexts in which gentrification processes are embedded.

Neoliberal urbanism has been defined as the “urbanization of neoliberalism”, where cities become the focus of policies and practices which espouse “the belief that open, competitive, and ‘unregulated’ markets, liberated from state interference and the actions of social collectivities, represent the optimal mechanism for socioeconomic development” (Theodore et

al., 2011, pp. 15, 24). There have been voluminous works on neoliberalism and its applicability which are beyond the scope of this thesis. I highlight two main points on localisation and the limits of neoliberal explanations which are pertinent to the background of this research.

Abidin Kusno (2013, p. xxvii) argues that “the neoliberal ideology of urban development from the Suharto era [1966-1998] continues to influence the present”, where “neoliberal” is not “a singular unified concept” but one which is “localized”, which he references from Oliver Wolters’s conceptualisation. According to Kusno (2013, p. xviii), this localisation of the neoliberal ideology by Indonesians is called “*neolib*” which “is a term recognized locally as a tendency of the state to simultaneously create, temper, and harness capitalism in order to legitimize its rule even if this may involve extralegal, informal measures.” In this way, Kusno (2013, p. xviii) demonstrates “how the neoliberal ideology, which used to be dressed in nationalist terms such as ‘development,’ has been recast in popular discourse into such terms as ‘the global city,’ ‘green environment,’ and *perumahan rakyat* (housing for low-income people).”

Yet scholars have identified that there is a need to go beyond neoliberalism in the sense of the state-capital alliance to examine how different social groups (e.g. middle class) are able to shape urban policy in ways which are accessible to them (e.g. environment, heritage issues) that further entrench inequalities (Nogueira, 2020). For instance, Amanda Achmadi (2024) writes about the contest between the urban poor and upper-middle class Jakartans on the function and future of Kota Tua with the latter’s vision oftentimes shared by the Jakarta city government. Building on this, it is therefore worthwhile examining cases where it is not just middle-class actors who use heritage to reclaim space, and to what effect.

Jakarta has been described by many as a ‘big kampung’, referring to its historical development and ongoing realities where large pockets of the city still contain rural-like settlements and traditions in highly urbanised areas (Kusno, 2024, p. 35). As a city of migrants, Jakarta’s kampungs are often self-built settlements that continue to house the majority of its residents (Martinez & Masron, 2020; Siagian, 2024). Dominant negative stereotypes of Jakarta’s kampungs obscure the diversity and heterogeneity of these urban villages (Siagian, 2024, p. 180). These kampungs are embedded in various urbanisms described to be operating on the ground in the current context of Jakarta, such as “neoliberal global urbanism” (Herlambang et

al., 2018), “middling urbanism” (Kusno, 2020), and “subaltern cosmopolitanism” (Achmadi & Josey, 2022). Neoliberal global urbanism is described as the current phase of rescaled neoliberalising urbanism which Jakarta has undergone since 1988, characterised by “the recovery of major developers, renewed access to finance, including foreign capital, and the construction of ever-more spectacular integrated superblock developments” (Herlambang et al., 2018). In contrast with neoliberal global urbanism, the place of kampungs in the city is acknowledged as central in “middling urbanism” and “subaltern cosmopolitanism”, whether they are located in the centre or in suburbs. The first, ‘middling urbanism’, concerns the function of the kampung as an “intermediate” space for migrants, the city’s formal sector, the order and stability of the state, in non-linear processes which do not necessarily lead to linear urbanisation or suburbanisation trajectories. The second, ‘subaltern cosmopolitanism’, has been used to describe the bottom-up urbanism of kampungs which intersects with professional actors at the subnational and transnational level that “compensated the weakness of its imageability with the immense power of its social and cultural capital” (Achmadi & Josey, 2022, p. 616). These urbanisms play out in top-down and bottom-up processes which shape gentrification processes in overlapping, contrasting, and disjointed ways that defy simple binaries such as that of neoliberal urbanism versus subaltern urbanism and complicate state-society dynamics.

Gentrification and its effects have been well-documented in the academic literature, with physical, social, economic displacements much theorised in the Global North and more recently in other contexts such as Latin America, China, and India. This is less so for Southeast Asia even though gentrification is acknowledged as a global phenomenon (Kusumaningrum et al., 2020), and gentrification in the Indonesian context for instance is not new though the usage of the term is (Kusno, 2017). Ethnic, religious, gender and age effects, and especially their intersections, are also understudied in relation to gentrification.

Gentrification processes are impacted by and impact on heritage-making. Heritage-making has been well-studied in its official, authorised discourses and often neocolonial forms focusing on the temporal and material that ignore questions of identity and power (Smith, 2017). While heritage-making from below by ordinary urban residents has been gaining attention as I will show in the literature review, scholars have argued that such efforts are not necessarily exempt from contributing to gentrification processes (Arkaraprasertkul, 2018; Harvey, 2002; Herzfeld,

2015). This is important to note especially considering that in Asia heritage constitutes a major area of international participation and soft power flexing of states, corporate entities, and social elites (Wang et al., 2020, p. 2).

In the context of Indonesia and Jakarta, heritage in kampungs has been documented even though the scope remains at the level of existing material and tangible elements such as religious buildings, more than cultural practices or traditions (Padawangi et al., 2016). These also tend to focus on documenting the architectural aspects and how they relate to the socioeconomic contexts and dynamics. For instance, Shuji Funo et al. (2005) studied the kampung as house types, in particular traditional Betawi houses which had Dutch or Javanese elements, in the Luar Batang neighbourhood. They also observed that traditional houses require structural elements which have become costly while skilled craftsmen have become increasingly scarce, even if people wanted to keep to tradition (Funo et al., 2005, p. 134). These reasons possibly explain the concentration of more studies on the physical documentation of heritage kampungs.

There are various strategies being used in response to gentrification that have been classified in the literature as being either able to partake in its positive effects (such as economic opportunism) or deal with its negative effects (such as displacement because of increased competition) (Kusumaningrum et al., 2020). However, heritage-making as a strategy has thus far been insufficiently explained by this dichotomy, because it is not merely an economic process, but a political one which, I will argue, aims at tackling the political dimensions of gentrification - a process which thus far has received less attention than its economic dimensions. This aids in understanding why heritage-making has been chosen by some marginalised urban communities despite its complexities and pitfalls, but the question of how heritage-making advances or resists gentrification and its larger impact on society in particular Global South contexts remains inadequately addressed. The key to answering this question is also unpacking the conceptualisation of heritage and heritage-making as a political process at different scales which has so far somewhat been neglected in literature.

1.2.2 Heritage protection in Jakarta, Indonesia

Heritage protection as an idea has been evident in Jakarta since the 1970s with the then Jakarta governor Ali Sadikin. The latest national Heritage Protection Law Number 11 (2010) (*Undang-Undang Nomor 11 Tahun 2010 tentang Cagar Budaya*)⁴ lists five categories of material heritage: object, building, structure, site, and area. It also has various criteria for selection, including a minimum age of 50 years for objects, buildings, and structures (commonly cited, but neither a sufficient nor necessary condition), and having “important historic, scientific, educational, religious and/or cultural values”.⁵ Heritage protection status is granted by the district head at the city, provincial or national levels, based on the recommendation of a team of cultural heritage experts (*Tim Ahli Cagar Budaya – TACB*) appointed by the governor, without mandating public input in any part of the process, according to a heritage expert appointed by the Jakarta city government.⁶

Decentralisation measures in Indonesia since the early 2000s after the end of the 22-year authoritarian New Order regime have impacted the heritage scene in a dynamic way. Local governments have more autonomy to govern over various sectors in a way which is more attuned to local conditions. Decentralisation also allowed for the introduction of local and provincial elections (Negara & Hutchinson, 2021), even though national laws, capacity issues and increased bureaucracy continue to constrain local action. Distinct regional cultures and identities have been experiencing a resurgence, but inter-regional differences and inequalities are also becoming more apparent.

Current heritage discourses are informed by the spirit of Law No. 11 (2010) which espouses heritage preservation that encompasses “protection, development, and utilisation” (*pelindungan, pengembangan, pemanfaatan*) (Republic of Indonesia, 2010). However, the regional regulation, the Provincial Law Number 9 (1999) on the Conservation and Usage of Conservation Area and Listed Building, which is grounded in restoration (*pemugaran*) is still currently being used (Eryudhawan, 2017). It has not been revised to reflect the law change as there have been no new official guidelines at the time of writing. Therefore official heritage-making is still wedded to the restoration agenda from the 1990s. The lack of official guidelines entrenches the dominance of the current framework and slows down change as inter-ministerial

⁴ Translation follows what has been published by scholars of Indonesia, e.g. Purnawibawa and Rahardjo (2018).

⁵ Republic of Indonesia Law No. 11 (2010) about Heritage Protection (author’s translation).

⁶ All Indonesian quotes in this thesis are translated by the author, unless otherwise stated.

coordination on related policies have to rely on the last available guidelines to carry out their tasks (e.g. spatial planning), according to a heritage expert. This makes it more challenging to get legal and material support from the government for alternative forms of heritage-making by communities which go beyond restoration.

One heritage expert observed that in the designated heritage areas, the usage of outdated terms like *pemugaran* (restoration) has created anxiety among residents who believe that they would be restricted from doing anything to their buildings, illustrating a gap between “good ambitions” of heritage protection laws and community perceptions about them. This was corroborated by Kota Tua residents. Further, common perceptions about how heritage protection equates to nationalisation have seen people refuse heritage protection, or embrace these terms based on their own agenda. This is even though government management and treatment of heritage buildings or areas have been uneven across cases.

Even though Jakarta is the capital city of Indonesia where political and economic powers are currently concentrated, in terms of heritage issues it is arguably less developed than other smaller Indonesian cities due to overlapping urban development agendas. While heritage construction in the city faces terminology and recognition issues in which official definitions seem to dominate, Jakarta does not figure much in the heritage arena nationally. National heritage organisations such the Indonesia Heritage City Network (*Jaringan Kota Pusaka Indonesia - JKPI*) and Indonesian Heritage Trust (*Badan Pelestarian Pusaka Indonesia—BPPi*) are more visible in other regions and in smaller cities where heritage branding can be impactful, and contestation of definitions is more apparent and taken more seriously, according to a heritage expert. These organisations were also founded by heritage activists and professionals who recognised that “folk heritage”, the “ordinary” and non-monumental objects should also be acknowledged and protected, other than the five categories of material heritage in Law No. 11 (2010) (Wijayanto, 2016). Jakarta then provides a case study of how heritage protection and gentrification processes within mega, primary, and capital cities have their own dynamics and pressures.

Changes in city and national leadership because of elections and ministerial reorganisations are often disruptive because of discontinuities in policies and practices. At the city level, each Jakarta governor with a fixed five-year term has their own vision for urban development, while

the rest of the local government apparatus might be bound by regulations and guidelines which are slow to change. At the national level for instance, the reinstatement of the Ministry of Tourism and Creative Economy (Presidential Regulation Number 69 of 2019) from the Ministry of Tourism (2014-2019) has resulted in more attention to the tourism economy and consequently tourism-oriented heritage-making projects. Yet some continuities are less desirable when they entrench certain path dependencies. This is the case with personnel who were involved in early archaeological works who then went on to inform policymaking on wider heritage protection through the same archaeological lens, according to a heritage expert and a local government officer in conservation. This has contributed to the continuation of top-down heritage-making projects and practices which focus on control and management, while critical debates and discourse have shifted to beyond archaeological approaches which are deemed unsuitable for highly urbanised areas such as Jakarta. One government appointed heritage expert observed that because policies are so slow to change, innovation is coming from the “bottom-up” with their own views.

1.2.3 Jakarta’s Old Town (Kota Tua) and its kampungs

“Located at the mouth of the Ciliwung River in Java, the Old Town of Jakarta was established by the VOC [*Vereenigde Oostindische Compagnie* - Dutch East India Company] in 1619. Its 17th century town plan was completed in 1650. In 17th and 18th century VOC had largest volume of trade in the world, governed from Batavia. No colonial town built by VOC matched the grandeur and completeness (military, civil engineering, and urban elements) of Dutch town planning & architecture of Batavia.” (UNESCO World Heritage Centre, 2015)

The above is the opening description for Indonesia’s submission to the UNESCO World Heritage Centre in 2015, of the Old Town of Jakarta and the four outlying islands (Onrust, Kelor, Cipir and Bidadari). It attempts to showcase the uniqueness and value of Batavia to the world. However, if one were to ask visitors from the Southeast Asian region who come to Jakarta occasionally or even domestic tourists, there is a high likelihood that they would have not stepped foot into Jakarta’s Old Town (*Kota Tua Jakarta*) or even heard of it. If they have, they would have either come away with a mediocre experience of crumbling old buildings and lacklustre atmosphere, or they would have avoided the area from hearing about the lack of

adequate tourist infrastructure and unsafe surroundings. This is quite unlike the other Asian old towns which are usually a must-visit for tourists and a source of pride for locals. The common comparisons people make is with the historic old towns of George Town and Melaka in Malaysia which are in the UNESCO World Heritage List.⁷

Batavia, the capital of the VOC from 1619 and then the Dutch East Indies from 1799, was the old Latin name for a tribal group in the Netherlands which was “an important founding myth in the Dutch collective identity” and using the same name was integral to the Dutch territorial conquest of the region (Kehoe, 2015, p. 5). Prior to the arrival of the Dutch and their initial permitted establishment of a fortress, warehouses, and customs, the area was Jakarta’s oldest port named *Sunda Kelapa* under then Sunda Kingdom. Sunda Kelapa was latter attacked by Fatahillah, the leader of the surrounding Muslim kingdoms of Demak and Cirebon, who reportedly renamed it *Jayakarta*, a lively trading centre which the Dutch flattened in 1619 to found Batavia (Gultom, 2018). The Dutch colonial government instituted a “binary” system for administration and district allocation which differentiated “Europeans” from “natives”, and a separate category of “foreign orientals” for mainly Arabs and Chinese (Kusno, 2024, pp. 31–32). Ethnic zoning for the non-Europeans was done by the Dutch through spatial division based on ethnic affiliation, religion, occupation, among other characteristics, and the respective community leader or chief would be in charge of their own *kampung* unit, with little to no support from the colonial state (Kusno, 2024).

The port city expanded southwards in the early 19th century as the northern coast became untenable to live in: buildings deteriorated, canals became stagnant, and disease spread (Kehoe, 2015). The legacy of the expansion has impressed a deep sense of the northern area, which then became known as Old Town (*Oud Batavia*), as being left behind. It was only in the early 1970s, long after the Japanese Occupation (1942-1945), the struggle for Indonesian independence (1945-1949), and the period of democratic transition and political instability (Abeyasekere, 1990), that Kota Tua had the attention of the city government once again (Sastramidjaja, 2014), but such attention came and went depending on the priorities of each sitting governor.

⁷ “World Heritage is the designation for places on Earth that are of outstanding universal value to humanity and as such, have been inscribed on the World Heritage List to be protected for future generations to appreciate and enjoy” (UNESCO, n.d.-b). The List is decided by the World Heritage Committee which is constituted of voluntary State Parties to the World Heritage Convention for a six-year term.

Unlike much of the more tourist-friendly old towns of Southeast Asia, Jakarta's Kota Tua stands out as it has not reached the same levels of disparity that is often observed between a gentrified historic old town and its immediate surroundings. Within a ten to fifteen minute walking radius from Fatahillah Square, which is formally considered the centre of Kota Tua, in any direction we can find one of the many variegated residential neighbourhoods in the area (Figure 1.1). These include Kampung Bandan and Roa Malaka (within the city wall), Kampung Luar Batang, Pekojan, and Pecinan (outside the city wall). Beyond these historic neighbourhoods which date back to the 1600s and 1700s, there are more recent residential neighbourhoods amongst them in various states of liveability and precarity in the Taman Sari, Tambora, and Penjaringan districts which make up Kota Tua. The inhabitants, just like the contours and densities of the kampungs, evolve over time to reflect the various businesses, industries and opportunities which cluster around and at the intersections of Kota Tua, as will be evident in Chapter 4 and 5.

Walking outside the inner square was quite challenging until recently, since the area is at the crossroads of major city roads to the airport, the port, and to the Greater Jakarta region (Figure 1.2), and therefore suffers from heavy traffic. However, in February 2021, the Low Emission Zone (LEZ) was piloted in Kota Tua to improve air quality in the area, which was thought to improve visitor experience and protection of the heritage buildings in the area (Istanto et al., 2023). This was part of the latest revitalisation programme for Kota Tua.⁸ Nevertheless the surroundings of Kota Tua continue to experience a changing landscape as various state, private, and citizen projects populate the city.

⁸ Revitalisation (*revitalisasi*) is commonly used in the Indonesian context to refer to various renewal, redevelopment, and regeneration projects, often derived from cultural heritage conservation laws and practices. See Achmadi (2024) various revitalisation efforts across governor regimes.

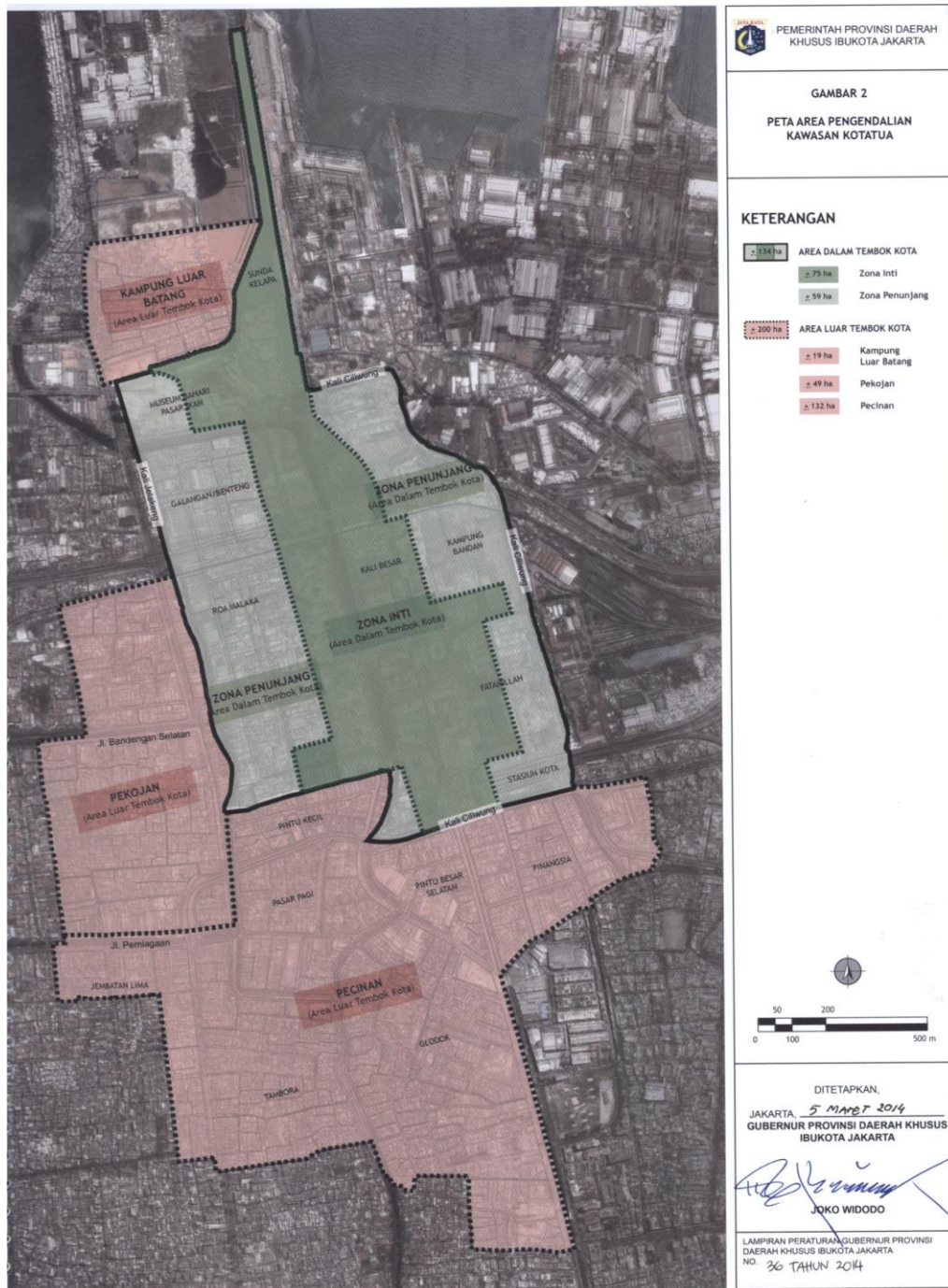


Figure 1.1 Map of the various zones in Kota Tua Area (Source: DKI Jakarta government, 2014)



Figure 1.2 Map of Greater Jakarta region (Source: <https://jakarta.bpk.go.id/peta-wilayah-jakarta/>)

There are various actors directly and indirectly involved in heritage-making projects of Jakarta's Old Town (*Kota Tua*) and its neighbourhoods (*kampungs*). At the granular, everyday level, residents contribute in various ways to the creation, preservation, and evolution of material and intangible elements that constitute the cultural, political and social fabric of their dwellings. They do so sometimes individually, and at times through the vehicle of informal and formal resident associations and interest communities⁹ (*paguyuban*) that concern themselves with the heritage of their communities. In the context of Jakarta, Indonesia, grassroots¹⁰ and more formalised community organisations have long existed and serve different important functions in the everyday life of residents. Such organisations contribute to areas such as social welfare and health service provision, that also influence heritage-making efforts to varying

⁹ This includes bicycling groups (*onthel-onthel*) and heritage trail groups which are present in the Old Town, as well as Pekoja Kota Tua Heritage (PKTH), Sunda Kelapa Heritage (SKH), and Sohib Langgar Tinggi (SLT).

¹⁰ This includes the *Lembaga Swadaya Masyarakat (LSM)* which is a volunteer-based, non-profit, non-governmental organisation (NGO) set up by individuals or a group that serves public interests.

degrees. Since 2012, *Pokdarwis* (Tourism Awareness Groups - *Kelompok Sadar Wisata*) is a community-level institution created by the Ministry of Tourism for each province in Indonesia, with the ones in Jakarta as the latest additions at the time of writing. Each group consists of various elements of the “pentahelix” model which includes community representatives, small and medium businesses, media, academics, and the government.¹¹ Increasingly advocacy and expert groups¹², research institutions and universities, non-governmental organisations as well as private sector actors¹³ also feature in this heritage-making landscape as they advise, collaborate, legitimise, organise, and promote various supporting and at times contrary agendas. These organisations will feature throughout the thesis as examples of agents of heritage-making from below.

This complex urban landscape is enmeshed within existing government structures which span from the lowest administrative unit at the neighbourhood, to the sub-district, district, city and provincial as well as national levels. In various parts of DKI Jakarta, heterogeneous rural-like settlements (urban villages or *kampung*s) are still a common though fast disappearing feature of the urban landscape. Each neighbourhood consists of a varied number of neighbourhood associations (*Rukun Tetangga – RT*) and citizen associations (*Rukun Warga – RW*) managing its social, security and administrative affairs. In Jakarta’s case, the heads of these neighbourhood-level institutions are usually elected by the residents and live amongst them, unlike at the sub-district (*Kelurahan*), district (*Kecamatan*) and mayoral (*Walikota*) positions which are filled by appointed civil servants who usually reside elsewhere. Jakarta is headed by a governor and a vice governor, and has its own regional parliament (*Dewan Perwakilan Rakyat Daerah Provinsi DKI Jakarta – DPRD DKI Jakarta*). This administrative structure is important to understand for its formal bureaucratic procedures, and how it shapes informal practices and power in everyday life, as will be evident in Chapters 4, 5, and 6.

Since the 2010s, there has been increasing attention on heritage in Jakarta, specifically Kota Tua, following its submission for nomination to the UNESCO World Heritage List, with

¹¹ Cited in various interviews.

¹² Tim Sidang Pemugaran (TSP) and Tim Ahli Cagar Budaya (TACB) are groups of experts at the city, provincial and national levels, tasked with researching and recommending heritage protection according to the relevant guidelines. Pusat Konservasi Cagar Budaya (PCKB) is a conservation department under the Ministry of Culture.

¹³ This includes state-owned enterprises (*Badan Usaha Milik Negara – BUMN*) who own a majority of the buildings in Kota Tua, and the Jakarta Old Town Revitalization Corporation (JOTRC), a private entity set up to realise the economic potential of Kota Tua.

revitalisation plans of the city administration which drew heavily upon the private sector for management and funding. A 2014 master plan for the Kota Tua area to “conserve and revitalize the historic city center” followed the start of another process of revitalization when the Kota Tua Revitalization Program was initiated in 2005 (United Cities and Local Governments (UCLG), 2017, p. 11). In terms of heritage zoning, while there are pockets in Jakarta which are known as heritage areas, Kota Tua is a major area where there is a district plan (*Rencana Induk Kawasan Kota Tua*) based on the Governor’s Decree (36/2014). The plan sets out the inner control zone as the limits of the Kota Tua Heritage Zone, which excludes most of the surrounding historical kampungs (Padawangi et al., 2016). In Kota Tua, about one third of the land-use has been residential since 2011 (Robertson et al., 2014, p. 12) yet most of the dominant heritage concerns have focused on individual colonial buildings.

In addition, a proposal was put together by a consortium of private and state-owned enterprises for Kota Tua to be nominated as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2015, but this was unsuccessful because it was deemed to be lacking “integrity and authenticity” (Wardhani & Dewan, 2015; Wijaya, 2018). The consortium consisted of the city government, a state-owned trading company (PT Perusahaan Perdagangan Indonesia (PPI)), the Jakarta Old Town Revitalization Corporation (JOTRC), and the Jakarta Endowment for Arts and Heritage (Jeforah) (Margi, 2015). This would have entailed a revitalization programme which targeted 27 main buildings in the area which were in dire condition, casting into sharp relief the familiar tension between development and heritage preservation (Wardhani, 2015). This tension bore out in the eventual 2018 report from the International Council on Monuments and Sites (ICOMOS) which highlighted concerns about future development projects which would alter the area’s character and the few relevant historical artefacts left intact despite the consortium’s proposal to focus on the Dutch colonial period (Wijaya, 2018).

Academic works and heritage conservation practices have tended to focus on the colonial historical buildings and places as cultural heritage sites which render Kota Tua worth conserving and developing for the city’s economic and cultural capital through tourism (Achmadi, 2024; Nugteren, 2020; Robertson et al., 2014; Vermeulen, 2024). However there are also sizable pockets of diverse residential communities within and around the area, some of which have been the result of the Dutch colonial system of segregation which dictated where and how ‘Europeans’ and ‘non-Europeans’ lived (Cowherd, 2021), as mentioned earlier in this

section. At times citizens' concerns are taken into account, but often as an afterthought or for relocation purposes, even though the trend of including local communities and not only experts and the government in the conservation of cultural heritage is on the rise (Fitri et al., 2015). This has resulted in much scepticism regarding participatory and inclusive approaches in official cultural heritage conservation which often have not translated into more resources from the local government to materialise the expressed wishes of the local communities.

Around the same time as the increasing attention on Kota Tua, urban observers and kampung residents began drawing more attention to the value of Jakarta's urban kampungs that make these unique, amidst the rapid development of modern high-rise buildings and the continued forced evictions of kampungs in various parts of the city. Urban planners, activists, and academics have argued for the kampung's continued existence in the city to which it contributes uniqueness and diversity beyond housing a majority of its residents, and therefore needs to be incorporated into urban planning more seriously (The Jakarta Post, 2015). There is still the dominant thinking that urban villages are informal settlements and slums which are not fit to be considered as heritage and valuable as collective knowledge of living in the city (Chandran, 2019). This is evident from the demolitions and evictions which have become familiar government policy, ostensibly to deal with perennial issues such as congestion, flooding and land subsidence, though state rhetoric around urban villages seems to be changing in recent years.

There has been a turn in discourses around urban spaces in Indonesia towards protecting and developing rather than removing kampungs (Octifanny & Norvyani, 2021). This can be seen from the various types of kampung development (sometimes 'improvement') programmes at different scales (e.g. community groups, neighbourhoods) and levels (e.g. city, regional, national), with a mix of top-down and more organic efforts. One such citywide programme has been the "Thematic Kampung Program" beginning in 2013 where each kampung is rebranded to give it a distinct identity such as Fisherman Kampung in Muara Angka (North Jakarta), Backpacker Kampung in Jaksa Street (Central Jakarta), often without much participation from local residents (Adianto, 2017, p. II–10). There have however been very few mentions in scholarly work on Jakarta's kampungs in this category, though similar cases in other Indonesian cities like Semarang have been studied (Suliyati & Yulianti, 2021). There is also little explanation in the city's planning document about this concept except the added adjective of

“super kampung” to describe a thematic kampung (Bappeda DKI Jakarta Government, 2013, p. 281). Melani Budianta (2019, p. 242) suggests that with the thematic kampung project, the term “kampung” is used to rename both rural and urban villages as a way to “evoke a sense of community and belonging which might be eroded in the process of urban transformation”. At this point it is unclear whether such kampung development programmes are the beginning of a different policy towards kampung or more of the same practices as before but with a higher risk of gentrification. This is because, during kampung improvement or development programmes, the state retains control on capital flows with a larger assemblage of actors involved in the material and social upkeep of the urban villages.

In Kota Tua, such thematic ideas have also been tested out and proposed in top-down and bottom-up approaches, in line with the rich heritage that layers the old town and the competing interests of various stakeholders. Ideas range from walking tours revisiting the Arab Kampung (*Pekojan*), Chinatown (*Pecinan*), “Nostalgia of Batavia City Walls” (Upk Kotatua [@kotatua.jkt], n.d.), the “12 Coastal Tourist Destinations” which includes Kampung Luar Batang, and various others that the Pokdarwis community groups have been asked to propose for their respective areas. However, these have been insufficient in addressing the question of evictions and gentrification-led displacement of kampungs, especially those cases which are not immediately obvious. Kusno (2020, p. 961) writes, “The kampung is central and yet peripheral at the same time. It is simultaneously in and out of place. It is geographically in the ‘middle’ of the city, yet it is seen and unseen at the same time”. The growing grassroots heritage movements in Jakarta can be seen in this light, in attempts to bring the kampung back to the forefront of attention, to make visible again that which has been made invisible by rapid urbanisation, urban redevelopment, and displacement processes. Different groups use various ways which involve different modes of remembering and forgetting, valuing and knowledge production, in seeking some permanence in uncertain and fast-changing times.

The encroachment of private development upon, and evictions from, kampung lands in Jakarta have seen different communities engage in heritage-making to resist gentrification-led displacement. This requires navigating various concurrent pressures, such as ambiguous legal status of housing, lack of access to basic services, state and private developers’ interest in the area, and adjacent official heritage projects which are often part of a bigger urban renewal plan. All of these influences result in different types of heritage-making and paths of development

for urban villages. With the increasing use of heritage as a strategy to remain in place, such as in Kampung Luar Batang and Kampung Pekojan, more recognition has been given to kampungs by politicians and the public. However the divided attitudes towards their place in the city remain as many of them are unable to maintain their surroundings which fall into disrepair (sometimes by design) and labelled as “slums” as the city races towards global aspirations. The responsibility put on residents to maintain and manage their residential areas as homes and heritage sites are often not commensurate with the resources and support provided by the state. This gap between increasing attention and inadequate support only partly illustrates the myriad tensions that urban kampung residents and advocates contend with in using heritage-making as a strategy in response to displacement processes. These themes will be elaborated in Chapters 4 and 5.

1.3. Research questions

The background and key debates outlined here have shaped the main research questions on process, outcome, and impact of heritage-making on housing conditions in Jakarta. To understand whether heritage-making projects resist or advance gentrification in Jakarta, I look at the case of Kota Tua and its neighbourhoods where multiple heritage-making and displacement processes are taking place. In this thesis, I raise the question: how do heritage-making projects of/by urban villages affect housing conditions in Jakarta, with reference to gentrification-led displacement? The analysis will show how heritage has been constructed, in particular as a process of “heritage-making”, how heritage-making affects displacement for kampung residents, and the broader impact of heritage-making from above and below on state-society politics in Jakarta’s *Kota Tua* and two of its kampungs, Luar Batang and Pekojan. The detailed approach and operationalisation of the research questions are developed in Chapter 3. To answer these questions, I employed a comparative case study approach of the two sites described in the following section, relying on ethnographic methods and thematic analysis.

1.4. The case study sites of Luar Batang and Pekojan

The choice of kampungs as sites was informed by prior research and contacts, while I also conducted pilot interviews to assess the state of the field. Listed as a “tourism village” (*desa wisata*) on the “Wonderful Indonesia” website under the Ministry of Tourism and Creative Economy are “Luar Batang” and “Kampung Arab Pekojan Kota Tua Batavia Jakarta”, although

their profiles are still incomplete (Kementerian Pariwisata dan Ekonomi Kreatif, n.d.-a, n.d.-b). They are two neighbourhoods located on the north and west side of the Old Town, respectively (Figure 1.1). They used to be a part of the then five historical districts in the 1975 delineation of Kota Tua, but they are currently located in the “Area Outside the City Wall of Kota Tua” (DKI Jakarta Government, 2014). The official geographical area of Kota Tua also shrank from 846 hectares in 1975 to 334 hectares in 2014 through gubernatorial decrees.

The UNESCO World Heritage nomination dossier submitted in 2015 was titled “The Old Town of Jakarta (formerly old Batavia) and 4 Outlying Islands (Onrust, Kelor, Cipir dan [sic] Bidadari)” (UNESCO World Heritage Centre, 2015). The Luar Batang mosque is included in one of the four major areas in Kota Tua which are part of the nominated area, while two mosques in Pekojan (Langgar Tinggi and Annawier) were merely mentioned as part of houses of worship which have “very Dutch colonial characteristics” (UNESCO World Heritage Centre, 2015). China Town or Glodok is included in the nominated area as a whole, but there is no mention of Pekojan. Therefore there are varied delineations and interests surrounding the neighbourhoods and their role in heritage-making.

In a 2016 UNESCO Jakarta report on Kota Tua, both Luar Batang and Pekojan were identified as being prone to gentrification in various forms (Padawangi et al., 2016). Pekojan was reported to have increasing density and dwindling traditional cultural activities. Luar Batang was reported to have new apartment buildings nearby, and a coveted land market where land ownership can be ambivalent and land tenure insecure. These were identified as markers of gentrification, and were interpreted as threatening the preservation of cultural heritage of and within the kampungs.



Figure 1.3 Map of northern Jakarta, with Luar Batang (north) and Pekojan (west) highlighted in yellow (Source: OpenStreetMap, 2025, with author's highlights)

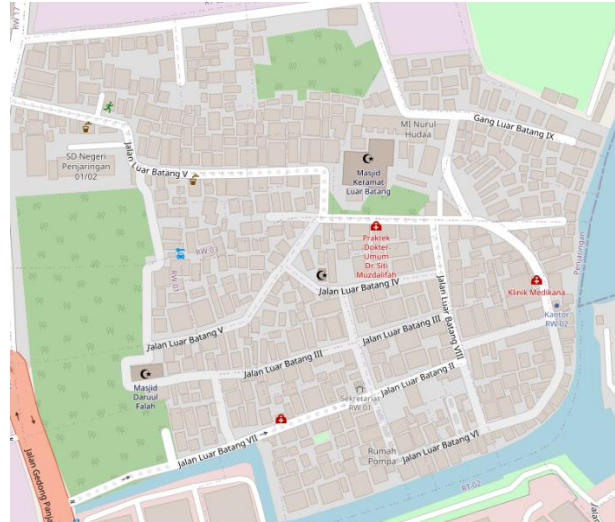


Figure 1.4 Map of Luar Batang (Source: OpenStreetMap, 2025)

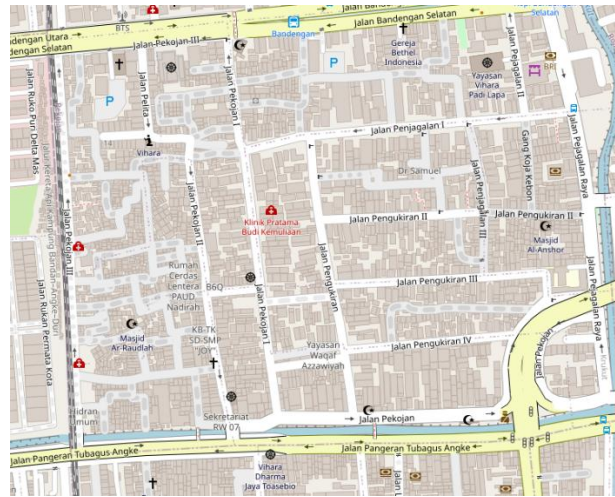


Figure 1.5 Map of Pekojan (Source: OpenStreetMap, 2025)

Luar Batang is a kampung situated in Penjaringan District, North Jakarta (Figure 1.3 and Figure 1.4). As of 2024, based on a publicly available government database, its population across three neighbourhood units (RW) is about 12,500 people, with Muslims making up about 90 percent, and the remaining are Buddhists, Christians, Catholics, Hindus, and Confucianists (Produk RW, 2024). While residents are ethnically diverse, the majority are from the Bugis ethnic group (Ashadi et al., 2018). It is one of the most affected kampungs by the ecological problems of rising sea levels, land subsidence, and flooding, which has been exacerbated by reclamation works along the wider northern Java coast documented since the 1960s (Padawangi, 2019b).

This is because the eastern edge of the kampung faces the estuary of the Ciliwung river which separates the kampung from the Sunda Kelapa port opposite. There is a seawall along this edge where once there was none and residents could see and access the water body directly.

Considered the oldest settlement in Jakarta, its population has evolved over time, in terms of ethnicities, occupation, residency status. Owing to its location, Luar Batang was known as a coastal kampung being near the harbour (Figure 1.6), attracting workers in the fishing and shipping industry to stay there, as well other workers labouring over the various Dutch colonial construction projects in the area (Puspitasari, Djunaedi, Sudaryono, et al., 2012). On one of the visitor information boards in the mosque compound as seen in Figure 1.7, Luar Batang is described with an extra paragraph in English which is not in the Indonesian version on the same board as:

the oldest settlement in Jakarta. Since before the 12th century, this settlement was born to meet the needs of a place to live close to the place of work, namely the Sunda Kelapa Harbor. Along with the dense activity at this port, various ethnic groups began to live together in Kampung Luar Batang and began to root *various stories of historical and spiritual travels*.¹⁴

The spiritual part is in relation to the tomb of Habib Husein bin Abu Bakar Alaydrus which is situated at the heart of the kampung, within the Luar Batang Mosque (*Masjid Luar Batang*) compound. The revered shrine (*keramat*) of the important Islamic religious figure who migrated to Batavia from Hadhramaut in early 18th century invites domestic and foreign visitors from all over the world, particularly from neighbouring countries. There are various legends surrounding his life and afterlife that continue to form an important part of heritage-making of Luar Batang (Sevea, 2022). The mosque compound has been granted the national level heritage status (*cagar budaya*) since 1988 (Pusat Data dan Teknologi Informasi Kemendikbudristek (Ministry of Culture), n.d.), and it has undergone periodic renovations and revitalisation. It has its own heritage-making projects, while the government has had various plans to turn it into a themed tourist destination (Padawangi et al., 2016).

¹⁴ The emphasis in italics are mine, and indicates an extra detail which is not covered in the Indonesian version.



Figure 1.6 Entrance gate to Luar Batang, with the words "Masjid Luar Batang 12 Jalur Destinasi Wisata Pesisir" (12 Coastal Tourist Destinations) (Source: Author, 2018)

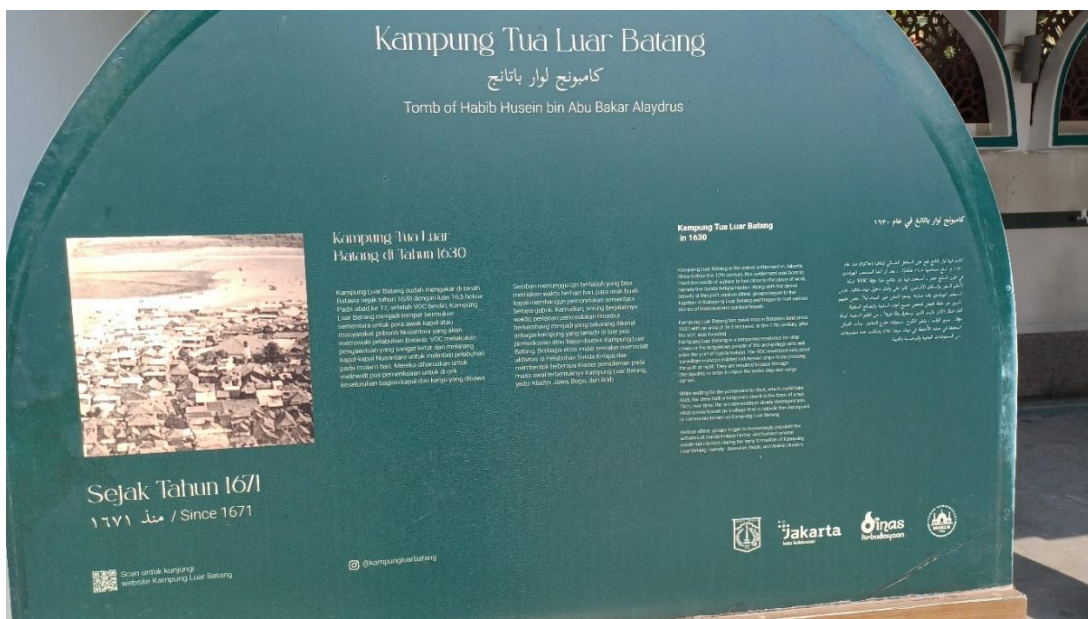


Figure 1.7 Brief history of Old Kampung Luar Batang (Kampung Tua Luar Batang) in Indonesian, English, and Arabic inside the mosque compound near the entrance (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 1.8 Commonplace calendar in a temple showing Javanese, Chinese (Lunar), and Arab (Islamic) dates, Pekojan (Source: Author, 2023)

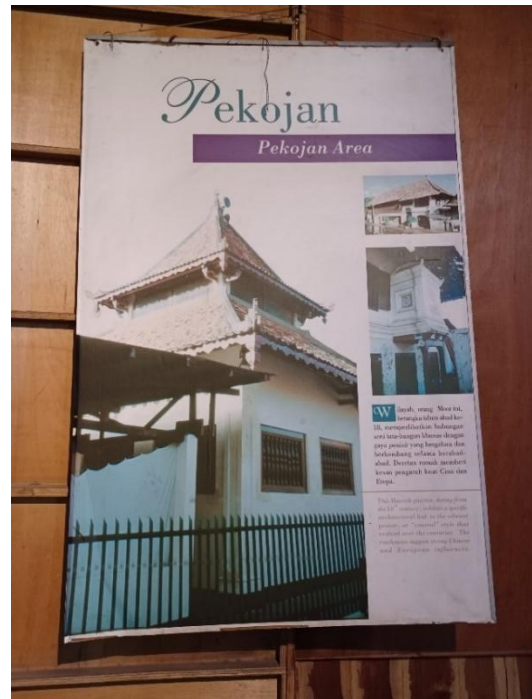


Figure 1.9 Single poster among maritime exhibits at the Bahari museum (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 1.10 Various 'for sale' or 'for rent' posters on buildings in Pekojan (Source: Author, 2023)

Pekojan, meanwhile, has been known by various names since its existence – the Moorish Quarter, the Arab Quarter, the Muslim Quarter (De Jonge, 2001). It is a neighbourhood in Tambora District, West Jakarta (Figure 1.3 and Figure 1.5). When the Dutch colonial government took over from the bankrupt Dutch East India Company (VOC) almost two centuries later, in 1800, they instituted the pass and quarter systems which crystallised what was hitherto a voluntary clustering of co-religionists into the ‘Arab quarter’ and set restrictions

on the movement of people (Cowherd, 2021; De Jonge, 2001). As of 2024, it has a total population of about 27,000 people across 12 RWs, where Muslims make up about 52 percent, Buddhists about 24 percent, Christians about 17 percent, Catholics about 5 percent, and the remaining are Confucianists and Hindus (Produk RW, 2024). While it is less exposed to rising sea levels than Luar Batang, as it is further inland, it still faces flooding and land subsidence issues as the Krukut river runs along its perimeters. Households, religious buildings and businesses have made adaptations such as raising the ground floor or elevating roads (Achmad & Kurniawan, 2021).

Its multicultural population derived from the various trader communities and indigenous populations has evolved over time, in terms of ethnicities, occupation, and residency status, according to local and external political economic changes (Kurniawan et al., 2020). The calendar hanging in a temple showing the Javanese, Chinese, and Arab dates alongside each other in Figure 1.8 reflects some of the multiculturalism inherent in Pekojan. There are historically significant mosques which reflect the various Muslim communities (such as the early Indian migrants) which have settled there and evolved (De Jonge, 2001). There are also historical temples and buildings with Chinese architectural characteristics in Pekojan, arguably some of the very few left in Jakarta after the May 1998 riots which targeted Chinese communities (Phillia & Sihombing, 2023; Wiryomartono, 2020, p. 120). Over the years, with the increasing number of new migrants amidst a shrinking Arab community (Ellisa, 2007), Pekojan has maintained its reputation as a unique and harmonious multicultural area in Kota Tua while also showing some tensions about the changing demography of the neighbourhood.

In a poster in a nondescript corner of the Maritime Museum (*Museum Bahari*) as seen in Figure 1.9, Pekojan is described in the translated English text as:

This Moorish quarter, dating from the 18th century, exhibits a specific architectural link to the vibrant pesisir, or “coastal” style that evolved over the centuries. The rowhouses suggest strong Chinese and European influences.

While many of these rowhouses (*rumah petak*)¹⁵ remain in varying conditions, what is becoming more common in Pekojaan is the sight of newer and nondescript buildings as seen in Figure 1.10. Various posters for sale and for rent plastered over the gates have mushroomed over the last few years, signalling a shift in the property market. By putting these two kampungs in Kota Tua in a comparative framework, I aim to build on existing works on single case studies of these two sites, and to bring their relations to each other and Kota Tua to the fore of theorisation on heritage and urban housing.

1.5. Contribution and significance of research

The findings of this research contribute to the theorising of heritage and housing politics, at the intersection of gentrification, critical heritage, and urban studies in the context of a postcolonial Global South city. Specifically, the distinct contribution is to the nuances of gentrification-led displacement and heritage-making processes which address a gap in literature by taking into account how ethnicity, religion, age, and gender impact on heritage-making and gentrification at the neighbourhood scale. These nuances demonstrate the complexities within the category of the ‘subaltern’ and amongst kampungs, which further complicate the top-down and bottom-up binary. By centering the case of Jakarta’s *Kota Tua* and its kampungs, this research also contributes to the documentation and analysis of Indonesian cases which are still lacking in comparative urban research. Methodologically, the knowledge production about heritage and housing dynamics in *Kota Tua* by the shared process of interviews, conversations, documentation, and learning from interviewees and others through online and offline contexts contribute to a growing repertoire of information that can ground and support local urban policy, planning, and governance. These findings are significant as they recast top-down and bottom-up approaches as useful heuristics for analysis. However, in reality, actors located along different scales of politics are enmeshed or detached from each other in uneven and changing ways. These unstable relations shed light on the struggles and agency of the subaltern communities to shape their own urban development.

1.6. Thesis structure

¹⁵ The rowhouses can range from about four to six metres in width, and up to forty metres in length (Ellisa, 2007).

This thesis is structured as follows. The next chapter (Chapter 2) reviews the key debates in gentrification, heritage, and urban housing with a focus on Southeast Asia. I define the terms gentrification, heritage-making, and urban village before going into the key approaches to understanding these phenomena. Here I survey the literature on planetary gentrification, the roles of actors and interests, and alternatives to gentrification; the temporal, material, and process-centred approaches to heritage; and housing in Global South cities. This review of the literature then allows me to further the political analyses later in the thesis to uncover heritage-making processes that resist or advance gentrification-led displacement.

Chapter 3 records the methodological approach of this research. I first present the postcolonial and comparative case study approaches which inform my research epistemology and methods. Using kampungs as sites, I employ qualitative methods such as hybrid semi-structured interviews, ethnographic observations recorded in my field notes and diary, and textual and visual data collection. I analyse the data through memos and manual coding, before moving to NVivo to manage the larger dataset. Finally, I reflect on the ethical considerations and my positionality as a doctoral researcher from a British institution, originating from one Southeast Asian country and conducting research in another.

Chapters 4, 5, and 6 explore each research prompt in turn. The first two focus on analysing the thematic findings on heritage-making and gentrification-led displacement respectively, while the third presents a more comparative discussion. Chapter 4 addresses the main research question by examining the constructions, uses, and ways of heritage-making by various actors in Kota Tua and the two kampungs, Luar Batang and Pekojan. By looking at different types of heritage-making, from above and below, it provides the context for the following two chapters where I examine them in relation to gentrification and state-society politics. Heritage-making in Kota Tua is dominated by top-down constructions of heritage that emphasise the built environment, manifesting in signages, discourses, and colonial buildings. Subaltern heritage-making in the kampungs, which continue to elude state and private sector plans, focus on religious heritage-making, in different ways and in relation to the changing conditions within and around the neighbourhoods. The methods of heritage-making employed by the different actors range from oral traditions of storytelling, sensory experiences, and increasing use of social media, as well as renewed interest in producing books about the kampungs for public

consumption. Each medium used in these contexts has its own embedded inequalities and potentialities.

Chapter 5 proceeds with the second part of the research which delves into the impacts of the heritage-making process on housing security for the residents in these two kampungs. I describe the state of housing in Kota Tua's neighbourhoods where there are acute pressures of living in this historic part of Jakarta, given the neoliberal housing policies and practices, political ecological issues, and displacement threats. There has been an unintended spotlight on kampungs with the various Kota Tua revitalisations. The revitalisations have not been as impactful in improving housing conditions, but nevertheless have some impact as residential life and Kota Tua are closely intertwined. High-profile evictions garner much attention, while the various forms of displacement in older kampungs less so. I detail how the struggles for heritage intersect with the struggles for housing in complementary and conflicting ways for subaltern actors, by examining subaltern contestations and changing geographies of inequalities within and across kampungs.

Chapter 6 examines the third and final part of the research question on the broader impact of heritage-making by analysing the efforts of various actors on state-society politics in Jakarta. By tracing the political processes at various scales and how they bear upon each other, I detail the contested urbanisms from above and below in the ways of seeing and producing the city in a number of ways. First, I examine the top-down paradigms and practices with overlapping and disjointed outcomes. Second, I analyse private sector enterprise and state support which show the latter's gaps but also its neoliberal interventions. Third, I look at bottom-up challenges and the agency involved in prioritising between heritage conservation and housing pressures. I consider these challenges amidst increasing expectations of self-reliance and the ambivalent consequences of constructions of difference, as well as defining a heritage "community". The second half of the chapter appraises heritage-making as a form of politics from below, with contestations across ethno-religious, class, gendered and generational lines. It shows that going beyond traditional political strategies is not unproblematic or uncontentious, and that the construction of differences affords challenges to the current order in different, at times quite surprising, ways.

Finally, Chapter 7 concludes the thesis by returning to the research question and summarising the arguments. I present the main research findings organised along three lines of inquiry on process, outcome, and impact. I argue that heritage-making in Kota Tua is complex and contested, shaped by external and internal factors. Top-down constructions by government and private sector actors are met with heritage-making from below by kampung communities under varying conditions. Heritage-making can be a bulwark against displacement through the realisation of the kampungs' value and importance, as well as the agency of subaltern communities, though not without unanticipated consequences. I evaluate the contribution, significance and implications of these findings, before reflecting on the limitations of this study and recommendations for further research.

Chapter 2. Literature Review: Gentrification, heritage, and urban housing in the Global South

2.1. Introduction

In this chapter, I outline key debates on gentrification, heritage, and urban housing with a focus on Southeast Asia. These debates are relevant to the overarching research question of this PhD: how do heritage-making projects of/by urban villages affect housing conditions in Jakarta, with reference to gentrification-led displacement? Situating my thesis in the urbanisms- and heritage-from-below bodies of work, I aim to understand how heritage has been constructed, in particular as a process (“heritage-making”) in relation to gentrification-led displacement, its outcomes for housing security, and the broader impact of this process on state-society politics in the urban context at various scales.

The key debates in gentrification studies, critical heritage studies, and urban studies in urban contexts point to gentrification as under-theorised in Southeast Asian contexts where the conditions of class formation, urbanisation process, and postcolonial society vary, and heritage preservation is often contested and intertwined with rapid urban development. However, I argue that these debates are limited in explaining the political intersections of the heritage and housing processes which frequently occur in the Global South cities. Therefore I build on existing works to further the analysis of these intersections to understand the heritage-gentrification relationship in Jakarta, specifically Kota Tua, by drawing out the dynamics of gentrification processes which have been understudied. I propose the urban village as an important heritage-making site in postcolonial Southeast Asian cities where the complex interplay of capital, state, and society can be observed.

Following this, the second section introduces key debates in gentrification studies including planetary gentrification, actors and interests, gentrification in other forms, and alternatives to gentrification. The third section presents key approaches in critical heritage studies including the temporal, material, and process-centred aspects of heritage. The fourth section discusses the intersections between gentrification and heritage-making. In the fifth section, I examine how housing in cities in the Global South, particularly the urban village, has become

increasingly politicised within debates surrounding gentrification and heritage-making, before finally situating these debates in Jakarta's context.

2.2. Urban redevelopment and gentrification

Gentrification as a concept has been much debated and its usefulness questioned by scholars and practitioners, yet it has endured. Loretta Lees (2019, p. 6) traces the many definitions back to Ruth Glass's pioneering use of the term in 1964, which Lees restated as "a small scale, neighbourhood based process" of "middle/upper class people moving into a solidly working class, inner city neighbourhood", usually resulting in the "rehabilitation of properties, an increase in property values, and the displacement of the working classes". Gentrification has since encompassed various other forms such as being a large-scale phenomenon which is state- and developer-led (Watt, 2013), to "planetary gentrification" where spaces of exclusion are being created everywhere globally and not only in or originating from the West (Lees et al., 2016). Often these occur in the name of economic progress and urban development but result in greater inequality and segregation (Lees, 2019). Lees (2019) argues that displacement remains central to the different manifestations of gentrification, while Hyun Bang Shin and Ernesto López-Morales (2018) argue that it should continue to be about "the class remaking of urban space". They, among others, have argued for provincialising gentrification which is to acknowledge its plural forms across different scales from the neighbourhood to the metropolitan and timeframes beyond Anglo-American cases. Through tracing the epistemology of comparative gentrification studies, they argue that gentrification mutates and is present in varied contexts (Shin & López-Morales, 2018).

What makes gentrification, as defined thus far through affluence, and also more commonly associated with class, arguably less applicable in other contexts is the way class is constituted and its dynamics in each society, given that it intersects with other social cleavages (such as ethnicity, race, age, and gender) differently. Ironically however, with a more globalised circulation of capital and ideas due to advancements in technology and social media platforms, it is also arguable that places are becoming more similar, more "homogenised" through gentrification in some ways than ever before (Saha, 2022; Wang, 2016). Furthermore, there is an emergent decolonial scholarship which argues that class is inadequate for explaining "where, when and how gentrification unfolds" (Rucks-Ahidiana, 2021) and may even obscure embedded sources of inequality such as racial hierarchies. Acknowledging this will allow "new

geographies of gentrification [to] contribute to the understanding of the global regularities of class restructuring processes intertwined with unresolved colonial histories and racial fault lines” (Annunziata & Rivas-Alonso, 2018, p. 393). The implication is that identifying gentrification in different contexts is an important contribution to analysing embedded inequalities and legacies in more tangible ways.

To approach the research questions, I use a working definition to connect the different contexts in which gentrification has been observed, which helps to illuminate the similarities and differences between those contexts. A broad definition crafted by scholars drawing from various comparative gentrification studies is worded as follows: “the commodification of space accompanying land use changes in such a way that it produces indirect/direct/symbolic displacement of existing users and owners by more affluent groups” (Shin et al., 2016, p. 458 cited in Shin and López-Morales (2017)). The underlying assumption of this usage is that gentrification has varied manifestations in different places which are not themselves isolated phenomena and easily generalisable (Lees, 2019), but are interconnected, directly or indirectly, by global flows of capital and ideas, even if the term has not been used or recognised locally (Shin & López-Morales, 2018).

This includes cases where terms such as urban redevelopment and revitalisation are used instead (Shin & López-Morales, 2018). Therefore Shin and López-Morales as well as other scholars in comparative gentrification studies (Ley & Teo, 2020), advocate for a broad definition, with the dual purpose of scholarly analysis and political empowerment of local grassroots and residents who find themselves facing displacement by more affluent and powerful groups. This challenges a dominant global urban theory view within gentrification studies that a broad definition, though with the intention of being inclusive and widening the scope of the phenomenon, may not be able to engage with the meaningful differences of varied contexts in which such urban change occurs.

To explore the relationship between heritage and gentrification in the housing context, I first examine how gentrification processes and their effects have been conceptualised, and to understand the relations between gentrification, heritage and housing. The current key approaches have been shaped by concerns about planetary urbanisation and gentrification

beyond the Global North, the changing role of the state and middle-class gentrifiers, the various manifestations of gentrification, and alternatives to gentrification.

2.2.1 Planetary gentrification

Planetary urbanisation has become a much-debated descriptor of the widespread and uneven urban change taking place globally, with much of the urban population growth concentrated in cities of the Global South. However, the localised context in which urbanisation takes place gives rise to certain processes of capital accumulation and spatial fixes, which can yield particular gentrification processes and effects that warrant attention (Lees et al., 2016).

The spectrum of urban gentrification cases is not easy to determine and compare because it is not only about different cities across geographies, such as Global North and Global South, that have different political economies which experience gentrification, but also about when gentrification occurs. More recent cases of gentrification seem to be occurring at a much faster pace than earlier documented cases (Lees et al., 2016). Scholars writing on gentrification have highlighted the questions of how the state uses its planning power and how the state-society relationship is impacted by where the money for urban (re)development comes from (Shin & López-Morales, 2018). In different political systems, the planning powers of the state can vary greatly, and when combined with the origins of capital, the process and outcomes of gentrification can be unexpected.

This debate about the specificities of gentrification has led to scholars calling for the decentring of knowledge production from the Anglo-American sphere which dominated the origins of gentrification studies by examining the conditions under which such knowledge is produced (Roy, 2011; Watson, 2009). This is to better historicise the pluralistic process across space and time (Bernt, 2016). Decentring also includes addressing the “diffusionist logic of gentrification” (which informed earlier work in the gentrification literature), where its processes and blueprints emanate outwards or downwards from the Global North to South, by placing gentrifications taking place globally “on a level analytical plain” (Lees et al., 2016).

Matthias Bernt (2016, p. 642) recommends future research to go beyond the already abundant single case studies and edited volumes which attempt comparative approaches, towards “a

genuinely comparative research design which allows examining how established theories work in different environments”. His observation rings true in the context of Southeast Asia, where little comparative research has been done on gentrification (Ley & Teo, 2020).

However, such different environments should not only be used to test established theories; instead, they should also be given the chance to “refine starting points” (Bernt, 2016). This is especially so given that while seemingly similar gentrification processes may be happening in different places, they do so under different conditions even within Global South and North cases, which can result in varied or similar effects. These conditions include the relations between state and society, the genesis and nature of the middle class, the pace of the process, and the simultaneity of the urbanisation and gentrification processes in the Global South which gentrification in the North for the most part did not have to contend with (Lees et al., 2016). Bagoes Wiryomartono (2020, p. 29) writes about the origins of gentrification in the Southeast Asian context, particularly Indonesia, in the “patron-client relationship” that divides society along elites versus commoner lines which has been present since “ancient times”, although the manifestation may have changed from palaces to superblocks and gated communities. The lack of examination on the process and the hyperfocus on the narrowly defined manifestations have resulted in the oversight on the gentrification processes occurring elsewhere.

As postcolonial approaches which push for decentring knowledge production and centering specificities have begun reshaping the field, scholars remain divided on whether gentrification as a concept is useful outside the Global North. Critics maintain that the concept is not useful in places other than the Global North to which it is specific (Ghertner, 2015), while its defenders argue that the concept is analytically and politically important in the face of rising instances of urban injustices worldwide (Slater, 2017). However, in saying that gentrification does not apply to non-Western cases, Bernt (2016, p. 641) argues that Ghertner inadvertently contributes to a Eurocentric perspective wherein universality can only apply to Europe with all other cases being a collection of particularities. For the second camp, Bernt argues that theorisations based on Anglo-American cases which assume economic factors (especially capital accumulation) as the determining variables of gentrification and other contextual factors (culture, history, politics) as the dependents are also problematic as they do not meaningfully engage with the differences of other cases beyond acknowledging them (López-Morales,

2015). Even in Anglo-American cases economic determinism has been found to obscure factors such as racialisation that contribute to gentrification in the first place (Rucks-Ahidiana, 2021).

These critiques are important when discussing gentrification and heritage-making in postcolonial Southeast Asia where contextual factors are not mere differences to be acknowledged but to be analysed. Factors such as ethnicity and religion, which continue to dominate the politics of postcolonial states and its urban planning and development (Muzaini & Minca, 2018; S.-L. Wang et al., 2020), are more than just dependent variables. They also mediate the gentrification processes in the Global South where social cleavages are historically formed differently from the North. As Shin and López-Morales (2018) note, “in post-colonial states, ethnic-religious tensions often become the sources of retribution against the marginalised, resulting in mega-displacement to set redevelopment and gentrification in motion”. Here redevelopment and gentrification can be the outcomes of politicised differences which often have their roots in colonial societies. But in other cases, it is not just about retribution as gentrification becomes a way to fulfil aspirations and navigate urban change through religious revivalism, as seen in parts of Jakarta where religious gentrification is being driven by middle class Muslims aspiring for more ‘Islamic’ urban settings (Hew, 2019).

Given that the analytical and political value of the term remains important globally, there are several limitations to these approaches. Much of the debate on gentrification as a concept and its scope has taken place in urban studies and closely related disciplines such as geography and sociology. This is to be expected given the urban, spatial, and class focuses of gentrification studies thus far. Yet even with the push towards broadening the concept to include more cases beyond the West and to study their different trajectories, less has been said about addressing disciplinary boundaries and contributions to gentrification studies. Bernt (2016, p. 642) recommends that future progress on gentrification research can be achieved by “actively applying concepts from not yet prominent fields like housing studies, institutional economics or political science”. This includes his recommendation that an analysis of the state needs to be more central in gentrification research, as well as going beyond commodification of land and housing (e.g. rent gap theories) to understand other non-commodified or decommodified forms of land and housing in relation to this process of urban change. The call for more state-centred studies in gentrification has been addressed by other works on gentrification (such as Lees et al., 2016; Ley & Teo, 2020). However, I argue that even though the role of the state has

been increasingly recognised, as I will elaborate in the next section, it is often treated as a unitary actor and its contested nature remains under conceptualised in gentrification studies.

2.2.2 Actors and interests: beyond binaries

Several scholars are unequivocal in their view that the state and elites are central to real estate investment, considering the large scale of projects which inevitably requires favourable policies, eliminating opposition, and getting public buy-in on new urban ideals for the city, and that more studies are needed to unravel their roles (Bernt, 2016; Lees, 2019; Lees et al., 2016). In the Global South, as in the Global North, the relationship between the state and private developers can be very close, with both state and state-led gentrification evident. However, in cases across the Global South there are added dimensions to the “entrepreneurial state” which courts transnational capital with its attendant effects (Eslava & Pahuja, 2020; Lees et al., 2016). This is partly the result of a post-WWII international order that dictated development across the Global South, coupled with postcolonial states’ pursuit of local and national projects which are reflective of their political, ideological and economic aims as they engage in aspirational city/state-making (e.g., smart city, sustainable city, World Heritage city).

However, the state is not monolithic and has competing goals over time that cannot be easily reconciled. State-led or state-supported gentrification may conflict with other state objectives such as ensuring enough workers and migrants to support the economy of the city by keeping rents low in some urban villages, while facing competition for labour and talent from rapidly urbanising areas elsewhere (Wang, 2016, p. 169). This underscores a key tension between neoliberal urbanism with its tendencies towards the displacement of the poor and a neoliberal urban economy which feeds off undervalued labour. In addition to this, scholars such as Rosemary J. Coombe and Lindsay M. Weiss (2015) have highlighted the “neoliberal restructuring” of the state where the state has not receded from heritage management but reorganised its power into new bodies, agencies, and partnerships. Hence various state objectives and assemblages manifest in a not so straightforward urbanism at the top which needs further examination.

While the role of state, elites, and developers as the main proponents of gentrification have been recognised, Shin and López-Morales (2018) cautioned against thinking that they are the

only ones responsible for engendering displacement. Those who stand to gain from such displacement are also complicit, be they the property-owning middle classes, transnational property investors (Koh, 2019), and even community actors who accept the state's legitimacy to steer urban development in this manner. This is given the relatively less negative press gentrification receives in non-Western contexts due to its association with progress and redevelopment (Ley & Teo, 2020). Lynn Meskell (2019) also highlights a recent development in the literature on the politics of spatial cleansing where there is a shifting of the "gaze on people like ourselves": "activists, intellectuals, professionals, and academics who are also politically motivated and deeply enmeshed". This professional and intellectual class, 'experts' included, can also be agents of gentrification in cities across the world.

There are other actors who can act as counterweight to state power, whether it is to advance gentrification more in their favour or to resist it altogether. David Wang (2016) describes the evolution of the "urban village company"¹⁶ in Chinese cities such as Shenzhen which have been crucial not just to the economic but also political development of former villages which have been absorbed into the city. These companies have also become a formidable force in terms of negotiating with real estate developers to maintain and strengthen their practical and symbolic presence in the city, in the face of gentrification. The birth and transformation of a "parallel administrative structure" (Wang, 2016, p. 106) in the form of the urban village company is an important and demonstrative phenomenon in a non-Western context, especially in dealing with the encroachment of gentrification and the gap in literature on residents' efforts to self-govern and present political alternatives against gentrification (Wang, 2016, p. 133). This is important as it also links to broader questions of power and political structures at different scales, as well as linking to how heritage-making and gentrification processes feature in these dynamics. Sandra Annunziata and Clara Rivas-Alonso (2018) argue that to understand the fuller spectrum of resistance to gentrification, scale is important, in particular looking at the different practices in the "micro-politics of everyday life".

Therefore while the state has been identified as a key actor in the literature, what is less clear is who makes up the state and its agents, where do their powers lie and what are the variations

¹⁶ A joint-stock company which represents the residents' collective economic interests, in the absence of the previous system of village governance which has been rendered obsolete as the village becomes absorbed into the city's jurisdiction (Wang 2016).

across time (e.g. political cycles) and scale (e.g. local and national government). At the same time, there have been arguments that the state, together with the private sector and transnational actors which it courts, is causing gentrification more than individual gentrifiers from the middle classes. Hence the question of how politics is changing looms as the contestations and collaborations among and within state and society actors defy simple binaries.

2.2.3 Gentrification by any other name and dimensions of displacement

Overall, the types of interaction, whether conflictual or supportive, between state, capital and society lead to the different types of gentrification and displacement processes. These different forms of gentrification may exist without being explicitly termed as such, with more ‘neutral-sounding’ urban policies such as rehabilitation, redevelopment, regeneration, renewal and “best practices” from ‘exemplary’ cities exported and circulated globally (Lees et al., 2016; Ley & Teo, 2020). In Asia, urban (re)developments in the name of sustainability and green environments (Kusno, 2011) in popular and policy discourses of recent years have been known to contribute to urban gentrification when they have caused displacement of its residents, especially the low-income, to build new high-rise residential complexes or gated communities with green spaces, climate-resilient and smart technologies (Datta, 2019; Meerow, 2017).

Gentrification in the name of sustainability can also happen when existing local sustainable infrastructure and cultures are not evaluated as meeting externally derived and decontextualised guidelines. For example, Antariksa Surjono and M Ridhoni (2017) argue that Indonesian urban kampongs¹⁷ (sic) have been unfairly labelled as slums and are overlooked as having sustainable development qualities, with the preference of many urban planners and designers for “western modern concept and design” which are accepted as sustainable development standards, but which may not be suited to the local context. The dual tasks of ensuring that traditional housing forms such as the kampung are not left to disintegrate whether by chance or design into slums while also keeping their gentrification in check are important in mitigating the risk of segregation and isolation of urban spaces (Lees, 2019). However, Lees et al (2016) also highlight that these two processes are not mutually exclusive since “slum gentrification” can

¹⁷ Usually ‘kampung’ is used in Indonesian or Malay to refer to neighbourhoods either in the urban area (at times as ‘urban kampung’) or villages in the rural area, while ‘kampong’ has been identified as derived from the Dutch spelling “kampong”, though in many cases they tend to be used interchangeably (see for instance Colombijn & Kusno, 2017; Mulyasari et al., 2017).

also happen because of the potential for capital speculation in these devalued spaces, and they argue for the need to introduce gentrification vocabulary (e.g. capital circulation, investments, erasure of the past, formalisation of housing and labour markets). These examples show that there is still much to be uncovered about the presence and nature of gentrification in various neoliberal projects in urban contexts such as Jakarta.

2.2.4 Alternatives and resistance to gentrification

There is a growing search for alternatives to gentrification in literature as scholars look towards different approaches and solutions. Lees et al (2016) argue that alternatives to gentrification are much overdue and need close attention from policymakers and planners, adding that alternatives are also lacking in academic discussions which have thus far focused on diagnosing the phenomenon. Bernt (2016) argues that learning from cases which are contextually different could shed light on the possibilities of anti-gentrification practices and policies which can be more clearly seen “for the politics and cultures of some may allow what will be blocked in others”. In this vein, there is much that a comparative study of gentrification processes and outcomes can contribute to anti-gentrification thinking and efforts.

The search for alternatives to gentrification thus far has also propagated a false choice between gentrification and decline, and while ideas such as decommodification and urban commons have been gaining ground, Janet Steele (2018, p. 471) argues that they are inadequate when they focus on specific parts of the built environment without adequately considering the “connection between *people*, *place* and *power*”. She advocates for self-renovating neighbourhoods to counter gentrification-led displacement, which emphasise “who does it (SELF), the way they do it (RENOVATING) and the scale and target of their ambition (NEIGHBOURHOOD)” (Steele, 2018, p. 471). With the collective “self” that exercises agency to craft and maintain the neighbourhood, which is “a web of relationships but it is also the fine-grain physical collection of functioning spaces and buildings” (Steele, 2018, p. 475), she differentiates between the “social preservationists” (a concept she borrows from Brown-Saracino, 2004) and the “gentrifiers”. The former are engaged in efforts that “aim to preserve actual authentic residents, and the potential for similar residents to live there in future”, while the latter are more interested in historic preservation which focuses on managing the aesthetics without much concern for the effects on residents (Steele, 2018, p. 473). The point of

differentiating between these two broad groups of social actors in a neighbourhood was to highlight how anti-displacement consciousness can be collectively enacted, across identity markers (such as residency status, age, class, gender, and ethnicity), to overcome the false choice between gentrification and decline which leads to displacement. This is crucial, considering the “affective displacement”, a “sense of ‘otherness’, of no longer belonging, generated within classed and intercultural interactions,” that people experience as a result of being differentially impacted by gentrification processes beyond changes in the built environment (Butcher & Dickens, 2016, p. 3).

Such approaches to alternative development which highlight the differentiation between residents also bring to the forefront the question of participation and gentrification in urban development. Participatory urban development at various levels has gained prominence in policy and practice worldwide, not least in Southeast Asian cities. The Kampung Improvement Programme in Indonesia, which started in 1968 with the World Bank’s support, has often been cited as one of the first successful government initiatives involving residents to improve infrastructure in the city, in particular the built environment in their neighbourhoods (Kusno, 2017). The Asian Coalition for Housing Rights (ACHR) was started in 1988 and it has been actively supporting participatory development across many cities in Asia, with a focus on upgrading of urban poor settlements (World Bank Group, 2014). However, the results of participatory development have been mixed, as existing conditions influence who can participate and whose participation matters. Nevertheless, Lees et al (2016) argue that successful resistance to gentrification can happen when communities comprehend and manage gentrification influences, as well as produce new knowledge with which the city as a political site can be reclaimed from dominant gentrification agendas. Here I turn to heritage and its contested role in gentrification.

2.3. Critical heritage studies and heritage-making

Heritage as a term is arguably more commonly used in daily life than gentrification, but also harder to define, as the voluminous research that has been done for a longer period on heritage shows. Debates in heritage studies began to be more serious in the mid-1980s, at least in the English-speaking world (Smith, 2011) but they continued to be (European)expert-, present- and tourism-centred, instead of process-centred, which better considers questions of identity, power

and authority (Harvey, 2001). While the term remains contested, there is a growing realisation that heritage is not only about material objects and places (origins, artefacts, built environment) which are often peripheral to dominant concerns in politics and everyday life. It is also about “a cultural process or embodied performance, which occurs at a number of different levels and contexts” (Smith, 2011) – the institutional, community, individual – which necessitates knowledge and care for something to be affected by it. Laurajane Smith’s (2017) authoritative definition of heritage which departs from previous heritage definitions is less about origins or objects to be managed or planned for than about the current use, nature, and value of heritage. Following this, inquiry into knowledge and concerns in the case of the different urban actors is important to get an informed picture of what and how heritage is valued in each context, since heritage as cultural power has social, political and economic consequences for everyday life.

There is also increasing attention on “living heritage” which refers to both specific cultural practices and legacies, as well as ways of living. Marina Kouri (2022), in her study on Yangon, writes that framing informal settlements as important to the city’s living heritage adds another argument against their displacement as it is simultaneously a strategy with which “to engage with different stakeholders”, and “to encourage urban poor communities to re-evaluate their own practices and environments and recognise their value from a heritage point of view”. This reframing, though not a guaranteed immediate solution to the housing and gentrification issues, allows for other important aspects to be given attention: “memories, practices, bits of knowledge, livelihoods, networks, friendships” which are also needed to sustain communities in the long run (Kouri, 2022).

However, these aspects are also contestable as communities are not internally homogenous and social differentiation (such as ethnicity, religion, class, age, gender) and their intersections often feature in these contestations. I define heritage-making here as a varied and unfinished process of meaning-making and constructing the past in the present which different actors use for various future ends (adapted from Harvey’s (2001) and Smith’s (2011) formulations). This process mirrors what Sharon Zukin (2010, p. xiii) describes as the possibility of authenticity, “a cultural form of power over space”, to be used by any group to claim their space in the city, not just the dominant actors. The argument Zukin makes about how our definitions of authenticity reflect “our own anxieties about how places change”, in that when we say something is inauthentic, we are saying something about our own struggle with how the

meanings of space and time are changing (2010, pp. 220–221). This means that heritage-making processes and outcomes, much of which draw on notions of “authenticity”, also reflect whose anxieties matter and how they matter, whether between or within communities. Feras Hammami et al. (2022, p. 8) argue that heritage-making necessarily involves constructing “self and the Other”, and while internal-external differentiations are more apparent, intra-community differences can also be a source of contestation and displacement (Ahmad, 2022).

Furthermore, the question of gentrification-led displacement looms here because of the possibility of commodifying these aspects of living heritage and informal housing. In this light, I employ “heritage-making” to underscore the varied, continuing, unfinished processes by which heritage is being (re)conceptualised and executed, especially under challenging conditions such as eviction and threats of displacement. The term “heritage-making”, unlike “heritage”, has been less contested and widely used in heritage studies to refer to the construction and production of heritage, which can include a variety of processes such as “re-narrativisation, commercialisation and reworking memories” (Wu, 2023). The ‘doing’ of “heritage” which is a “verb” as characterised by Harvey (2001) hence implies the unfinished process of heritage-making” which is inherently political (Hsiao et al., 2017). By using “heritage-making” to describe the process of doing heritage, I also take into account the complexities of translation given that “heritage” as a term has different meanings, connotations, and usage in each language. For instance, in Indonesian, Lauren Yapp (2020a, p. 179) observes that there are various terms (*pusaka*, *cagar budaya*, *warisan budaya*) to refer to specific tangible or intangible structures, objects, or practices, yet increasingly the untranslated usage of “heritage” by various heritage actors has become a preferred choice because of its “newness and relative emptiness” not yet fully captured by existing Indonesian terms.

As shown in the scholarly literature thus far, gentrification is an issue which heritage-making conjures, therefore critical insights from heritage studies can help to uncover gentrification processes and alternatives in different contexts. Here I outline three key approaches to understanding heritage: temporal, material, and processual.

2.3.1 Temporal aspects of heritage

David Lowenthal's *The Past is a Foreign Country* began a period when scholars started to study heritage more seriously, at least in the English-speaking world (Smith, 2011). However, David C. Harvey (2001) states that heritage studies have neglected their own history on what constitutes heritage concerns across different time periods. Heritage studies tended to encompass recent issues, a “present-centredness” embodied in “cultural, leisure and tourism studies” to the exclusion of other types of heritage across a broader temporal scope.

In a highly cited article, Harvey (2001) historicises heritage “as a process or a human condition”, which is affected by changes in technology and colonial experiences throughout time and space. For example, he traces the use of ideas of heritage and national identity from 17th century England and how far that has continued to be practised in more recent times under changing conditions. By treating heritage as social process, he emphasises that heritage practices have a historical development which needs to be analysed to situate such practices in their sociopolitical context. Using this approach would allow observers to place heritage-making practices “within the context of political agendas and wider conceptions of popular memory contemporary to the time” (Harvey, 2001, p. 334) and to better understand the types of processes there are. To use a process-centred conception would allow heritage research to partake in larger debates in society about the “production of identity, power and authority” (Harvey, 2001), which are important constituents and effects of heritage. This definition expands and removes the exclusivity contained within the domain of experts and the tourism sector concerned about present and often commercial purposes of heritage.

In the case of Indonesian cities, Yapp (2020b, p. 145) draws up a complex picture of a “‘heritage rush’, with an array of government, private and community actors suddenly, in the space of only the last five to ten years, scrambling to preserve and promote aging buildings and neighbourhoods as heritage sites.” While some of these efforts have been about preserving minority communities, she argues that the wider trend is overly focused on the “built environment of the colonial period” especially those which are distinctively Dutch (Yapp, 2020b, p. 145). The latter are meant for both domestic and overseas tourists, and whose efforts to attain international standards of heritage conservation are driven by local elites with foreign experts playing an important role (Nugteren, 2020). The drive to preserve colonial heritage without considering more carefully its complex history and contested legacies arguably reproduces the authorised heritage discourse (AHD) with the aim of economic gain for a select

group, with detrimental effects to those displaced and excluded from this capitalisation, such as current residents who live in historic sites and workers, many of whom are informal.

2.3.2 The material, immaterial and everyday heritage

Heritage studies scholars have gone beyond studying the material to include the intangible, and, more recently, how to also (re)interpret the material. Borrowing from the definitions of United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) on cultural heritage, here I use material to refer to monuments and objects, and intangible to mean traditions and living expressions inherited and transmitted to the next generation (UNESCO, n.d.-a). Smith (2011) in her larger body of work for which she became well-known for the phrase “all heritage is intangible”, re-theorises heritage away from the dominant approaches in the authorised heritage discourse (AHD). Works in the field of AHD have been criticised for defining heritage from mainly European contexts, dominated by experts mainly in archaeology and architecture, and hence the focus on material objects and places deemed to have historical value (Smith, 2017). Smith (2011) centres the fact that the heritage value of something changes over time, as a consequence of people’s actions, and it includes some groups of people (e.g., practitioners, professionals, government) as much as it excludes (e.g. local communities). Hence the important question of identity and power has been often ignored under AHD.

The influential critical heritage studies perspective Smith espouses views heritage as a practice/performance, with affect and emotion integral to the process of meaning making. Objects of “heritage” still matter, but as “cultural tools that facilitate the process of heritage-making, a process that requires both remembering and forgetting” by different groups of people (Smith, 2017, p. 20). In the question of which and whose heritage matters, the range has expanded from being focused on elite, high-culture, ‘civilised world’, institutionalised types of heritage, to increased attention and push to include the memory and traditions of everyday life of the marginalised and more traditional societies (Harvey, 2001; Nora, 1989; Smith, 2011), including in the domain of housing where heritage-making in various forms takes place. This is aligned with critical currents in political and urban studies about the importance of centring everyday practices to address pressing living concerns of people amidst urban inequalities and challenges (Meskell, 2021). Recognising that there are different levels of meaning making and

various actors (state, middle-class, working class) carrying out heritage-making allows for the analysis of different forms of competing power, resources, values, and aspirations.

However, the increasing attention to ‘everyday’ heritage may do little to alleviate displacement threats. Michael Herzfeld (2015) succinctly summarises the problematic intersection between heritage and housing: the poor cannot inhabit areas the powerful and privileged have designated as ‘historic’ or ‘collective heritage’. Yet at the same time, there persists a legalism which distinguishes ‘historic sites’ and ‘residential neighbourhoods’, and facilitates structural violence such as “spatial cleansing” and gentrification of poorer areas whose land values have increased (Herzfeld, 2015). In this way, the link between money, power and control over knowledge of what constitutes heritage is maintained in society, leading Herzfeld (2015) to argue that “[T]he problem for those threatened by such developments is that, as long as others control wealth and political access, they also control knowledge—that is, they define what is acceptable as knowledge about heritage and they withhold recognition from everything else.” The question of who determines what is recognised as knowledge or historical truth is important to consider when thinking about how the heritage-making of urban residents navigate or negotiate the control over knowledge, and hence the valuation of heritage. For instance, Hawken (2017) observes that the cultural knowledge and assets of local urban communities hold within them ways which can address inadequate urban development, but this is not something top-down and elite approaches have been proficient at valuing and doing, or willing to do so.

Heritage-making as a strategy for housing security is not without its own set of issues, as inequalities and self-interested resident practices and power hierarchies exist (Leitner & Sheppard, 2021). Belén Castro-Fernández et al. (2021) in their study of a Spanish town highlighted the double-edged sword of certain types of heritage-making which tend to invite mass tourism, preventing the heritage identity from being an “endogenous” creation, and puts the meaning making and sense of place of residents at risk. The questions of whose power gets preserved, strengthened, and whose erasure happens in the process, as well as the political culture of organisation and organising need to be examined (Wang, 2016). Questions about who the “guardians of memory” are and how intergenerational transmission or disruption of culture and memories take place, as well as the role of newcomers are also critical to

understanding the process of heritage-making in a neighbourhood (Castro-Fernández et al., 2021).

2.3.3 Heritage as process

As intangible heritage becomes a common vocabulary amongst scholars and practitioners, heritage as process becomes increasingly important to examine, given that it is fraught with contestations and unpredictable outcomes, including possibilities for change. This is especially the case in contexts where such concepts have been transplanted, without much consideration of or adaptation to existing conditions. Xue Wang and Nobuo Aoki (2019, p. 166) bring out the “incompatibility between intangible heritage value and productive real-estate value, which is commonly encountered in countries undergoing fast-paced economic restructuring” from the perspective of various stakeholders such as local government and developers. This is also while residents are concerned about housing needs over urban conservation which they increasingly are expected to be taking charge of (Meskell, 2019).

Even though Harvey (2001) is drawing mostly from the western European context to support his arguments regarding heritage as a historically contingent social process, they are applicable elsewhere (Muzaini & Minca, 2018). Seeing how heritage as process plays out in other parts of the world can be productive in critically appraising Harvey’s and similar arguments in other less studied contexts which have much to contribute to the theorisation of heritage. This is because drivers of change, such as technological developments and postcolonial experiences, *inter alia* (Harvey, 2001), shape heritage constructions and practices differently depending on the context. Scholars of heritage in Asia recognise that heritage as a process and discourse in the region has been very much affected by colonial legacies and their postcolonial reckoning (Muzaini & Minca, 2018; Smith, 2017, p. 20; Yapp, 2020b). They also highlight that there is a shortage of studies examining these aspects, considering “how cultural and heritage management represents a major area of international cooperation as well as a powerful instrument of ‘soft power’ by states, corporate forces and social elites” (Wang et al., 2020, p. 2) which compounds unequal relations among these various actors. This brings us to Harvey’s (2001) proposition for heritage to be analysed as process which is embedded in current practices and concerns to make sense of the questions of identity and power, and the competing production of knowledge.

More recently, heritage scholars have attempted to understand the role of digital technologies in mapping and restoring the cultural knowledge and assets of communities (Castro-Fernández et al., 2021). These raise questions of new opportunities and challenges communities might face in the digitalisation and datafication of their knowledge; of who produces and owns the knowledge; and of whether these help advance or impede their politics. Expressed attempts to ‘localise’ urban redevelopment, while being aware of the merits and disadvantages of the transnational circulation of policy ideas and expertise (De Cesari & Dimova, 2019), can be overtaken by the allure of technology and further entrench existing power relations. Monica Degen et al. (2017) examine the use of computer-generated images (CGIs) as a digital visualisation technology by a London-based architecture office to reproduce local heritage in the case of Doha through complex processes of consideration and negotiation. The authors assess that the outcome still reproduced non-local, western-centric sensibilities of experiencing and using public spaces. Yet accessibility to technology and public platforms has also fostered a “collective knowledge production” which “has taken the form of open platforms, blogs, websites, public lectures, art and media work, all done with the specific goal of framing counter narratives, and/or a critical and ironic understanding of gentrification” (Annunziata & Rivas-Alonso, 2018, p. 402). These examples lend support to Harvey’s (2001) argument for the need to frame heritage as a historically contingent process to understand the changing facets of power and politics in the local context. Critical heritage studies have taken this up in going beyond the once dominant temporal and material approaches to conceptualising heritage. There is more attention on the everyday, with the recognition that micro politics enacted in heritage-making needs to be examined.

2.4. The intersections of gentrification and heritage-making

Some researchers have suggested that gentrification is an inevitable outcome in heritage-making processes, particularly in the context of neoliberal urbanism (Arkaraprasertkul, 2018; Socali & Cinà, 2020; Van Noorloos et al., 2020). This is even the case when “self-gentrification” is used as an intervention by the poor to get ahead of the structural violence by means of heritage. As Herzfeld (2015) argues, these efforts tend to end up resonating with dominant discourses or official policy once they become successful, unless they are able to draw boundaries “around their own traditionalizing”. However, this thesis sets out to explore

if that is the case in Global South cities like Jakarta. Heritage-making, an indeterminate process through which people navigate abstract concepts such as community and nation (Smith, 2017) in concrete spaces such as an urban village, can help shed light on how people manage urban housing challenges such as gentrification-led displacement.

In a study on how gentrification and capitalist ideals are subverted by affected residents, Non Arkaraprasertkul (2018) documents how local working-class residents in the Shanghai alleyway houses use heritage to counter displacement pressures in a rapidly urbanising area that is becoming unaffordable to them. Positing this as a “gentrification from within” given that the value of these neighbourhoods eventually increased partly through their actions, he illustrates how the residents collectively constructed a narrative of the different types of heritage (historical, colonial, old) which would appeal to middle class sensibilities and tourists, as well as to the authorities. Relatedly, Louise Green and Noëleen Murray (2012, p. 17 citing de Certeau) write about “habitability” as “an effect of narratives that create openings in the increasingly uniform surface of the city, permitting differentiated experiences, nodes of possibility not anticipated by the city planners” – openings which can counter displacement in its different forms. Playing to the state’s interest in historic preservation and not outright opposition to top-down urban renewal programmes was also attributed to the fact that they understood the “limits of their political participation” and wanted to get the best outcome possible, even if it meant compensation for being evicted eventually (Arkaraprasertkul, 2016).

This highlights the utility of examining how residents come to understand their political power (or lack thereof) and how that shapes their strategies. However, “gentrification from within” is not a process without detrimental consequences to the community such as internal displacement, loss of authentic living spaces, and the marketing of cultural uniqueness which risks over-commodification (Harvey, 2002). What Arkaraprasertkul’s (2018) study also surfaced is the idea of heritage-making through using valuable and local knowledge to construct and disseminate an authentic and marketable collective narrative as a form of political participation within certain confines. The political dimensions of this type of heritage-making in a residential neighbourhood can be further explored to understand its processes and impacts, especially how it relates to the different scales of politics within and beyond the neighbourhood. As Annunziata and Rivas-Alonso (2018) argue, working through scales can allow for a clearer view of different practices of resistance to gentrification.

Thus far, a few main points of convergence emerge regarding the limitations of existing gentrification and heritage studies. First, in both literatures, factors such as ethnicity, religion, gender and age are recognised as important, but they have received less attention even though these factors inform people's values and uses of space which mediate gentrification and heritage-making processes. Second, there is much recognition in both literatures that there needs to be more plural theoretical debates to consider the multiplicities of knowledge production, including the call for 'theorising back', even if the critique is that the 'West' is still the point of reference (Lees et al., 2016; Smith, 2017). Third and relatedly, knowledge – its sources, production, and use – is key in gentrification and heritage-making processes. This is interesting because 'gentrifiers', as explained in the literature thus far, tend to valorise certain structures and objects for historic preservation through technical management. In contrast, heritage-making from below focuses on everyday objects and traditions which are more akin to "cultural tools that facilitate the process of heritage-making, a process that requires both remembering and forgetting", rather than merely as objects for technical management (Smith, 2017, p. 20). These two heritage-making approaches are not always mutually exclusive and may inevitably come into concurrence or conflict, setting up the stage for competing understandings of whose knowledge matters. As we will see in Chapters 4 and 6, these applications of heritage-making are observable in the contestations, subversion, and reappropriations of heritage buildings, narratives, and traditions among different groups of actors. These three points of convergence lend support to my approach which builds on these conceptual frameworks in the context of urban housing.

2.5. Housing in cities of the global south: the urban village

The urban village is a unique urban artefact that encapsulates the complex debates surrounding urban redevelopment and gentrification, and in particular, the use of heritage in both resisting and advancing urban inequalities and displacement. The urban village has seen diverse manifestations examined in the cities of China, India, and Indonesia, among others. The origin of the concept has been attributed in the Anglophone literature to American sociologist Herbert Gans (1962) in "The Urban Villagers" (Zukin, 2007), though an alternative genealogy places its origin in the Global South (Levin, 2018). Many others have used it in contexts as diverse as Asian and Latin American cities, small semi-rural towns in Britain, and Russia (Lashchenko,

2020). In Southeast Asia, this form of urban settlement is often known as the *kampung* (a term used historically by Malay-speaking communities across Southeast Asia), “the front line of urbanisation” (Cairns & Friedrich, 2014, p. 44) where migrants and city residents alike find dwelling and community.

Various definitions have been put forth for the urban kampung, reflecting the complexity of the term for a housing form, a heterogeneous neighbourhood, a way of life often associated with the rural, historical legacy, administrative boundaries, low-income populations, and unplanned settlements (Cairns & Friedrich, 2014; Guinness, 2019; Mulyasari & Sihombing, 2017). While individual urban kampungs are often named after an ethnic group or its dominant trade or agriculture, there is usually social diversity in terms of ethnicity, language, occupations, economic status, which immigrants mostly experience for the first time since coming to the city (Santoso, 2006). Kampung in the urban context is usually translated to “urban village” in English, and this label reflects the contrasting features which are commonly associated with rural settings but present in an urban context, such as “close community bonds; stable patterns of culture; low-rise, vernacular buildings; intimate lanes and compounds; horticulture, aquaculture, and animal husbandry; and relatively modest economic means” (Cairns & Friedrich, 2014, p. 50). The urban kampung has also been defined as “an indigenous urban settlement mostly inhabited by lower middle-class and poor people, a mixed-used highly densely populated area, for working and living” (Rolnik, 2013, p. 6), with most of the infrastructure and houses built independently by the residents (Irawaty, 2018).

As urban villages or kampung have been over time incorporated into a larger entity of official administration of the *kelurahan* (subdistrict, ward), the sociospatial dynamics and identification as a kampung community often continue albeit with increasing political and economic challenges to their existing ways of living. Given their varied conditions and conflicting attitudes towards them, it follows that the kampung as a particular neighbourhood is not given the same treatment as other types of neighbourhood or areas in the city (such as gated communities of private apartment buildings or landed properties). Zukin’s (2007, p. 47) critique of Gans’s book on urban villages can serve as a reminder of the importance of the wider context in which kampungs are embedded: “Neighborhoods cannot be studied in isolation, as specimens of a social class or an ethnic group, without understanding their

hierarchical relation to other areas of the city”. This is especially useful to keep in mind when examining heritage-making of and by kampungs around the Kota Tua area.

The urban village as a phenomenon at the intersection of gentrification and heritage-making processes has received more attention in recent decades in both research and practice. This “kampung turn” in the 2010s (Budianta, 2019) is due to a variety and combination of reasons including (but not limited to): rapid urbanisation and migration, uneven development, displacement, eviction, gentrification, sustainability, alternative development and governance, as well as the political projects of kampung residents and their allies who seek to change the narrative around these neighbourhoods (Cairns & Friedrich, 2014; Yapp, 2020b). Under the spotlight, their re-evaluation by different stakeholders comes to the fore. While in many cities they are considered informal settlements with negative connotations, urban villages are being reappraised in some of these cities which struggle with a public housing crisis and the proliferation of real estate megaprojects and urban redevelopment by state and private actors (Leitner & Sheppard, 2017; Padawangi, 2019a; Shatkin, 2017). Heritage-making in such informal neighbourhoods has been used as a localisation strategy against the onslaught of (trans)national capital that threatens displacement. Yet the trope of the (urban) village as an idyllic community setting is also gathering transnational recognition and being used for marketing new real estate developments both in wealthier and poorer countries (Wang, 2020), adding further complexity to the gentrification debate.

The urban village is also an important site at which the dynamics of capital, state, and society can be observed. It is a site of intense struggle between different interests, such as urban redevelopment and private sector projects in a globalising city, housing needs for urban residents and migrants, and preserving a social heritage of the city in a post-independence landscape of Indonesia and other countries in the 21st century. This is a site whose (physical, political, social, economic) composition and evolution are often quite unique to the context, such as notions of housing as a commodity or a social right (Lees et al., 2016). The urban village is also often a neighbourhood unit, and scholars have argued that neighbourhoods are a key site for social change in cities that have thus far received inadequate attention (Padawangi et al., 2022). Steele (2018, p. 477) calls for the repoliticisation of the neighbourhood that takes the “neighbourhood more seriously as a site for social good and economic opportunity, both empirically right now and normatively for the future” amidst the planetary scale of

gentrification in geography. This makes the scale of the kampung fruitful for a comparative approach to examining heritage-making and gentrification processes.

The future of the urban village in Southeast Asian cities in literature and practice has in recent years been cast in a more positive light, as its “ephemeral materiality but relative stability” is being put forth as unusual from the viewpoint of normative urban theory (Cairns & Friedrich, 2014, p. 50). As informal settlements, they are “places from which [neoliberal global urbanism] can be challenged” (Leitner & Sheppard, 2021). Yet it remains to be seen whether and how these embedded and imagined potentialities can overcome the seemingly insurmountable and complex realities.

2.6. Urban villages and heritage-making: understanding gentrification processes in Jakarta

With rapid neoliberal urbanisation since the 1980s in Jakarta, the appearance of, and plans for, luxurious high-rise apartments amidst forced evictions of kampungs invoke a strong sense of injustice for affected marginalised residents and their advocates. Various bottom-up struggles to seek redress and overcome uncertainties through strategies such as self-improvement, collaborating and networking with civil society and local government, public demonstrations, and everyday acts of resistance have been documented (Padawangi, 2019a; Tilley et al., 2019). It is under these conditions that contemporary heritage-making has emerged as an approach by groups of residents and civil society organisations to resist the incursions of the state and private actors on kampung lands, to protect the living spaces and the socioeconomic and cultural practices of its residents while preserving the social heritage of the city (Kusno, 2015; The Jakarta Post, 2015; Wiryomartono, 2020). This novel phenomenon requires further examination, as the kampung, a forgotten legacy existing on the peripheries of the then Dutch colonial city of Batavia as “historically racialised ‘non-European’ spaces” (Tilley et al., 2019) has become an important part of the post-independence landscape of urban redevelopment projects by state and private actors in Indonesia (Putri, 2018).

Urban villages house a majority of Jakarta’s residents (70-80 percent in common estimates) and are often “in the shadow of its rapidly burgeoning skyscrapers, in largely auto-constructed informal settlements of widely varying housing quality” (Leitner & Sheppard, 2021). This is

also in a context where government and private housing have only fulfilled about 15 percent of residential needs (Kusumawati, 2015). This makes urban kampungs important as sites of study because not only do they reflect the spatially dynamic movement of peoples into and around the city, but they also capture the historical and socio-political changes of Jakarta's urban development. Kampungs have also been described as consisting of permanent buildings of original villages "upon which cities have encroached and not vice versa" (McCarthy, 2003, p. 1). Hence they can be differentiated from slums in various ways, though this is not always clear cut.

Housing conditions vary significantly and urban kampungs are often in slum-like conditions, generally "characterized by poor quality housing, lack of secure tenure, and lack of access to water, sanitation, drainage, and flood-control facilities, as well as by ambiguously defined legal status" (Rolnik, 2013, p. 6). This ambiguity is sometimes taken advantage of by state and private developers as well as kampung residents to advance their own agendas. Many kampung lands are legally registered at the local municipal administrative offices (*kelurahan*) but are mostly considered only informal housing as they are not formally registered with the National Land Agency (*Badan Pertahanan Nasional, BPN*) (Kusno, 2012; Rolnik, 2013). This is a feature of the complex dual land system in Indonesia which combines customary and post-colonial systems.

At the same time, there is another layer of complexity about the ambivalent place of kampungs in the city in official heritage-making, which concurs with the kampung's peripheral status mentioned previously. The initial unsuccessful attempt for Kota Tua to be included in the UNESCO World Heritage List in 2018 inadvertently opened up the heritage question of Kota Tua and the place of kampungs which were included in the plan. While it has been increasingly recognised that what makes Jakarta unique is not just colonial buildings but also its urban kampungs (The Jakarta Post, 2015), the attention on preserving the latter's living heritage tends to follow the ebbs and flows of electoral politics (Savirani & Aspinall, 2017) even as the lives of many depend on the availability of this housing arrangement. Heritage-making of kampungs is hence contested; it is not only a strategy employed by marginalised groups to protect their socioeconomic and cultural practices, but also one used by state and private actors who have their own agendas.

A heritage-making framework allows more insight into the social, economic, and intellectual life of urban villages, traversing the well-documented duality of positive and disparaging narratives about the urban village and its residents. Scholars have documented the various paths of development for urban villages across different contexts, where they do not just provide cheap and rental housing to locals and migrants, but have also become tourist areas, cultural centres, and niche villages known for certain trades and crafts. In Shenzhen, China, migrants are a “creative force” in the city, bringing food, music, literature, and art which embed them in the mosaic of the urban village (Wang, 2016). In Java, Indonesia, “cultural commoning” through practices of sharing, participation in the community, and reinvigorating traditional arts and rituals is undertaken by villagers to “simultaneously resist and appropriate capitalist forces” (Budianta, 2019). Where urban villages were evicted, not only were community and family lives disrupted, trades and home-based businesses have been discontinued and these are hard, if not impossible, to recreate even if relocated (Tilley et al., 2019). However, to understand how heritage-making affects displacement, more can be said about whether heritage-making from below itself is exclusive or inclusive, given the syncretic¹⁸ multicultural nature of Indonesian society (Wiryomartono, 2020). There is also a need to understand how such subaltern heritage-making might compete or align with other types of heritage-making driven by neoliberal logics of the state and elites that rest heavily on the aforementioned duality of narratives, and what the societal implications are in the long run. These themes will be taken up in Chapters 4, 5, and 6.

2.7. Conclusion

Drawing upon the key debates in literature on gentrification, heritage and housing in the Global South, I aim to understand how heritage-making has been approached, its impact on displacement in the housing context, and its broader impact on state-society politics at different scales in the urban context. The analysis in this thesis will show that heritage-making is political because of competing claims embedded in knowledge and value hierarchies, which are used for differing purposes by unequal actors, whether it is historic preservation, residential security, or global city aspirations. That these different levels of meaning-making are informed by and

¹⁸ “Syncretism in the Indonesian context is an ancient cultural strategy for inclusivity of sociocultural diversity toward the wholeness of beings and their growth” (Wiryomartono, 2020, p. 280).

alter other scales of politics – the individual, groups, neighbourhoods, local and national state, and transnational forces – complicates the matter at hand and requires further examination.

The current state of the literature remains ambivalent on the extent to which heritage-making contributes to or works against gentrification processes, hence requiring a more contextualised study which considers understudied dynamics of intersecting ethnic, religious, gender and age factors to uncover the conditions, mechanisms, and outcomes of resistance. I intend to fill this gap by further developing the political analyses and centring the case of Jakarta as a Global South city, contributing to the growing critical scholarship on “global urbanism from below” (Leitner & Sheppard, 2021) and “heritage from below” (Muzaini & Minca, 2018). Building on previous works, I argue that heritage-making is a useful lens to examine further how different actors advance or resist forms of urban development which have displacement effects. Using heritage-making as an approach informed by a postcolonial methodology, on which I will elaborate in the next chapter, allows the uncovering of the competing processes of knowledge production and valorisation, contributing to a nuanced understanding of multifaceted gentrification processes in other contexts beyond the usual suspects.

Chapter 3. Methodology

3.1. Introduction

“Are you usually in Singapore? Born in Singapore? How did you wander off (*nyasar*) to Indonesia?” were the questions one elderly woman in her mid-70s asked me one hour into our interview. Similar questions were a mainstay throughout my time in Jakarta, Indonesia, where I was conducting fieldwork between December 2022 and August 2023. Even though these questions on my origin and position as a researcher were usually out of genuine curiosity, they encapsulate the key problematic of this chapter, namely laying out the epistemological and methodological choices of this thesis.

This thesis is concerned with whether heritage-making projects resist or advance gentrification in Southeast Asia. Specifically, I seek to address this question by examining recent heritage-making projects of/by urban villages in the context of housing issues and gentrification in Jakarta. This entails investigating 1) heritage-making projects of different actors; 2) impact of heritage-making gentrification-led displacement in the housing context; and 3) impact of heritage-making from above and below on politics in the city. Variations on these questions have been approached through multiple ways in heritage studies, gentrification studies, and more broadly, urban studies, as shown in the literature review. Through the methods chosen, I aim to capture the varied and unequal ways of being in, knowing, and viewing the world. I also aim to be critical about expert-defined heritage, which is often Euro-centric due to the origins and proliferation of the international heritage regime, as well as the capitalist value systems in which heritage is usually validated, as discussed in Chapter 2.

Guided by critical perspectives from these fields of study as set out in the previous chapter, in the second section I outline my approach towards the research, defined by postcolonial and comparative concerns, which inform the case selection. The third section then turns to the qualitative mixed online and offline methods I use, which were semi-structured interviews, ethnographic observations, and textual and visual data. While these methods have their limitations and were impacted by the Covid-19 pandemic which was still ongoing during the first two and a half years of this research, their complementarity mitigated some of these challenges. The fourth section presents how the data collected was organised and analysed in

two main stages (preliminary memo and manual coding, before using NVivo). Finally, in the fifth section I discuss some challenges faced during this research and reflect on ethical considerations and positionality, before concluding the chapter.

3.2. Research epistemology

Contemporary events as set out in Chapter 1 and a review of relevant literature in Chapter 2 inform the main research question on heritage-making in the context of housing issues in Jakarta. High profile evictions of kampungs and the increased attention on heritage such as the UNESCO nomination and in the Indonesian press by kampung communities and experts between 2013 to 2018 form the backdrop of this study. Competing heritage claims across and within different groups of actors in the face of potential and real displacement bring to the forefront questions of power, resources, and control over defining what constitutes heritage and its value. The outcomes of such contestations for basic needs such as housing, especially for the urban poor, and the impact on politics in the city in the context of gentrification processes, need to be better understood. The dimensions in various gentrification, heritage and housing debates which need further investigation include the specific and complex postcolonial conditions that underpin urban development and governance in Southeast Asian contexts, such as in Jakarta, and the comparative and political aspects of these debates which are generally understudied.

To address these theoretical and empirical concerns, a critical approach is necessary to uncover the workings of various constructions and contestations of heritage, and their translation into housing outcomes and political impact in a neoliberalising city such as Jakarta (Budianta, 2019; Kusno, 2017). I draw on and build upon postcolonial approaches which question knowledge production and power relations (examining whose voices and which mediums) in a comparative manner (inter-referencing between urban cases in the Global South) to better understand the role and impact of heritage-making projects on people's lives in the face of gentrification-led displacement.

3.2.1 Postcolonial approaches

A key concern in my thesis is what and how knowledge about heritage and urban development is produced, whose knowledge matters, and what purposes knowledge serves. These questions

about knowledge production, value and uses are central to the theoretical and empirical concerns, and they also inform my research practice. Postcolonial approaches and methods addressing questions on heritage-making and urban housing are multifaceted, with emphases on different ways of knowing and being in the world, beyond dominant capitalist and often Eurocentric ones, and uneven power relations.

By using heritage-making from below as a core analytical concept, I locate it as part of subalternity, an idea proposed by Ananya Roy and others (Roy, 2011) to interrogate what has been written about non-elites. Subaltern communities generally lack control over dominant narratives which often misrepresent, marginalise, erase, and undermine the existence of large groups of people. Heritage-making is more often used by state and elites as an exercise of power from above, but it can also be an exercise of collective power from below by subaltern groups. Roy (2011, p. 227) advocates for the “shift from the subaltern marking the limits of archival recognition to the subaltern as an agent of change” in the development of subaltern urbanism. She underscores how this way of viewing the urbanism that is experienced by a majority of the world is a different, restorative one to the various versions of “slum entrepreneurialism” proffered by previous works on slum dwellers (Roy, 2011, p. 228). In this “theory of agency”, Roy (2011, p. 229) challenges us to reframe the projects of the subaltern by seeing their efforts in the context of how their “economies are also the active frontiers of contemporary capitalism, the greenfield sites where new forms of accumulation are forced and expanded”, and not merely as parasitic slums and informal settlements with unenviable socioeconomic conditions.

Drawing on this perspective, I focus on urban village residents and their advocates as agents of change who not only react to changing urban conditions which impinge on their livelihoods and ways of being, but also strategise based on their experiences, knowledge, value systems, and aspirations. This also means that how they attribute and receive success or failure in their efforts reflects how they view their own positions in the larger scheme of politics in Jakarta. By centring subaltern (non-elite) voices as agents and actors, I seek to examine heritage-making as an exercise of power from below.

Choosing to take heritage and heritage-making seriously for a study of politics in Jakarta stems from a recognition that heritage-making processes are crucial to understanding more ‘serious’

and urgent issues such as housing rights under neoliberal urbanism, and of the efforts of ordinary people using what they know through various mediums and platforms to make their case and to alter discourse (Vergès, 2014). Heritage and housing issues, especially for marginalised communities, are often treated separately as they involve different political processes and are not similarly prioritised. Linda Tuhiwai Smith (2021) underscores the importance of these oft-hidden processes of making meaning and value. In writing about challenging social conditions of indigenous peoples who have more urgent issues of survival than seemingly academic concerns about “imperialism and the effects of colonization”, she argues that

The problem is that constant efforts by governments, states, societies and institutions to deny the historical formations of such conditions have simultaneously denied our claims to humanity, to having a history, and to all sense of hope... The past, our stories local and global, the present, our communities, cultures, languages and social practices - all may be spaces of marginalization, but they have also become spaces of resistance and hope (Tuhiwai Smith, 2021, p. 4).

To reclaim these marginalised spaces resonates with subaltern urbanism, where the outcomes for marginalised groups are not fixed or inevitable even though the odds derived from colonial systems have been stacked against them. Knowing how they arrived at the present moment can pave the way to change, and also provide an avenue for reimagining the future.

Within the ‘field’, recognising subaltern epistemologies also means learning to engage with both expert and vernacular knowledge (Tsing, 2015) and choosing the appropriate methods to investigate heritage-making practices. For instance, marginalised groups may not have the typical accumulation of material and economically valued objects that the state and elites do to symbolise and represent their heritage (Vergès, 2014). These prized objects are often considered as tangible proof of a culture that is deemed worthy of preservation and admiration, with some value assigned to them by prevailing dominant value systems, whether they are displayed in public museums or private collections. Françoise Vergès (2014, p. 29) writes:

They [the vanquished and the oppressed] bequeath words rather than palaces, hope rather than private property, words, texts, and music rather than monuments. They leave

heritages embodied in people rather than stones. Songs, words, poems, declarations, texts often constitute the archive through which to evoke their past.

Reflecting on this quote, two important points emerge. First, this is an exhortation to look elsewhere, to not only consider a range of heritage ‘objects’ beyond dominant definitions, as there are other ways marginalised groups reconstruct their past for recognition and have their own ideas of heritage which they mobilise to make claims to space. Looking into absences of these ‘ordinary’ objects in the community or personal archives, might tell us something about the perspectives, agency, and conditions of communities than only what is apparent in official heritage discourses and preservation. However, in Jakarta’s context, the heritage-making by communities is often also tangibly material and spatial, as it is connected to the organisation of urban society, though it may not have formal recognition. Second, assigning value through appropriation and commodification of ordinary heritage objects from a community, such as traditional buildings or crafts, can and does take place with or without the community’s involvement. This means that the presence of ‘ordinary’ heritage objects should also be scrutinised to understand how they are being used and by whom.

However, taking subaltern epistemologies more seriously does not mean that the problems of using Eurocentric concepts and uneven relations have been avoided or dealt with. Nowadays, using concepts which claim their origins in the ‘West’, such as gentrification and heritage as discussed in Chapter 2, and applying these uncritically to ‘the rest of the world’ would elicit some criticism of Eurocentrism. Yet as Kuan-Hsing Chen (2010) argues, because of historical processes and ongoing entanglements of the West with the rest of the world, it is futile and limiting to maintain discrete spheres of theorisation. Chen (2010, pp. 216, 223) then proposes “Asia as Method” which “ceases to consider Asia as the object of analysis and becomes a means of transforming knowledge production,” and to do so requires that the West be treated, not with apprehension, but included “as bits and fragments that intervene in local social formations in a systematic, but never totalizing, way.” Positing Asia as a postcolonial space for such inter-referencing¹⁹ between societies where there is a more direct intellectual exchange and learning about similar issues and pressures while recognising the diversity within has been

¹⁹ Inter-referencing has been also attributed to Ananya Roy and Aihwa Ong’s works where it “refers more broadly to practices of citation, allusion, aspiration, comparison, and competition”, practices which can both fuel better standards to aim for (Ong, 2011, p. 17), even though often as tropes, through a “process of knowledge and expertise transfer”, but which can also be used to justify exclusive urban development (Chua, 2015, pp. 69, 74).

taken up in various fields. However, this is, I argue, still in its nascent stages within Southeast Asian itself. Through employing a comparative approach that addresses this gap, the cases chosen in this thesis and the subsequent findings and reflections bring out the relational dynamics within Asian cases that implicate the ‘West’.

3.2.2 Comparative case study approaches

With reference to Chen’s (2010) “Asia as method”, I use inter-referencing not only to embed Jakarta’s case as one of the multiple points of reference among other postcolonial cases in the region, but also for relating different ideas about heritage and urban villages within Jakarta and Indonesia. Doing so allows for the questioning of where, how, and by whom knowledge is produced that has been subjugated to dominant structures (Bhambra, 2014, p. 118) which are themselves evolving. In the context of Indonesia, these include paradigms of knowledge production which have been argued to dominate the social sciences, such as Dutch colonialism, US modernism/imperialism, and contemporary neoliberalism, as well as nationalism, while decolonising agendas remain emergent (Takbir et al., 2022).

Comparative case study research has been a mainstay in urban studies. Conventionally a case study is intended for in-depth understanding of processes and outcomes. Other key aspects of the case study approach include aiming at causal inference for small-n research, capturing variations and generalising across (usually) countries, which are useful not only for researchers but also policymakers, urban practitioners, research participants and their communities. Chen (2010, p. 225) argues that “comparative studies, or inter-reference studies” as he refers to them, are needed in “third-world spaces” because we are unable to understand ourselves if we do not pay attention to others who face similar issues and conditions. Further, Chen (2010, p. 226) makes the now familiar point that “we have already been doing comparative studies, but the comparison has been between Euro-American theory and our local experiences”, resulting in the reproduction of unequal structures, aims, and outcomes of knowledge production.

In recent years, with renewed interest in comparative approaches in urban studies there have been calls for rethinking, reformatting, and reflecting on why to compare, how to compare, and what ‘a case’ is (Lees, 2012; Robinson, 2016). The calls for revisiting the fundamentals of comparison stem from critiques that most comparative studies are not systematic, transparent

or reflective enough about their assumptions and processes to properly achieve their intended aims (Krehl & Weck, 2020). At the same time, it has been argued that such aims might be misplaced. For instance, the emphasis in some comparative analyses for “a-priori hypothesis building and empirical testing” (Krehl & Weck, 2020, p. 1861) has been criticised for assuming that cases can be generalised at all when there are no such universal standards against which to measure cases in the first place. Similarly in political science where comparisons are common, controlled comparisons dominate and limit the types of comparisons that are considered seriously, as well as the kinds of questions to ask, hence circumscribing the knowledge produced (Simmons et al., 2018). Furthermore, even with universalist theories such as planetary urbanisation which are useful for comparative work, there is still a need to allow for the plurality of local processes, such as of capitalism, displacement, land use regimes, and postcolonial conditions to emerge (Butcher & Maclean, 2018).

However there remains much that a comparative case study approach can provide. Instead of trying to “control for difference”, Jennifer Robinson (2016) argues that the approach can be turned on its head and a comparison can be about “thinking with variation and repetition” towards innovative theory building. Cases do not only have to rely on geographic conceptions and be concerned only with variations in outcomes but can also concern “political processes (how things happen), practices (what people do), meanings (how people interact with symbolic systems), and concepts (how people order the world)” (Simmons et al., 2018, p. 1). A case study approach can then be dynamic and iterative, rather than treating cases as fixed units of analysis, and can contribute to theory development especially in cases where concepts are not easy to operationalise and measure (Simmons et al., 2018, p. 4). This is useful for exploring varied heritage-making processes by different actors, where they can be examined for connections and contestations to advance current understandings of heritage-making from below.

3.3. Research methods

Aligned with a postcolonial approach which is concerned with knowledge production and power relations, I use qualitative research strategies through a comparative case study approach to address the key question of whether recent heritage-making projects of/by Jakarta’s urban kampungs resist or advance gentrification. A qualitative approach centres people’s

experiences, narratives, and knowledge, through methods such as in-depth interviews and ethnographic observations. It also allows for a processual approach that sheds light on the consonance and dissonance between how people view others vis-à-vis themselves, contributing to a better understanding of the less obvious issues of centring subaltern voices. No approach is without its limitations which I will elaborate on subsequently, but a qualitative approach is underpinned by the view that knowledge is “situated and different ways of knowing [are] inherently partial” (Elwood, 2010). This stance is reflected in using multiple methods and being reflexive about their usage through the data collected and its limitations.

Given the ethnographic focus of the methods employed in this research, it is also important to address the question of field site selection. While I focus on specific sites where I conducted interviews and ethnographic observations and on which I collected textual and visual materials, the ‘field’ is constructed in various ways, whether online or offline. Hence the broader sense of a ‘field’ site is not predetermined beforehand, takes many forms, and is (re)constituted each time the researcher makes a choice about line of inquiry, theories, and instincts to follow (Burrell, 2009; Hine, 2017). This means that researchers need to be aware and reflect on this process as the ‘field’ is not static and bounded. For instance, images and hence visibility can travel due to the increasing influence of the media in everyday life through “mediatization”, even if common use of ‘field sites’ as “places on the ground” may suggest otherwise (Törnberg & Uitermark, 2022, p. 19). Hence for the specific sites I focus on, it means being aware of their representations and intended audience, connections to elsewhere, the worlds constituted offline and online and the relations between them. This is especially the case given the hybrid aspects of this research during the Covid-19 pandemic, such as the different meanings of “time in the field” on which I elaborate in a later section.

In reflecting the postcolonial approach of centring ordinary people’s experience, knowledge, and perspectives about heritage in their lives, I delve into three sub-questions which guide the semi-structured interviews:

- 1) How has heritage been constructed by different actors?

This question explores the discourses, narratives, traditions, and focus of heritage-making practices by the government, experts, communities, and kampung residents,

as well as the methods that they use, with the aim of understanding how these processes unfold, within and across the case studies.

2) What have been the impacts of heritage-making projects on housing conditions?

Through this question I examine the effects of heritage-making projects on housing security and displacement experienced by kampung residents. In particular, I compare how residents perceive and contest the changes taking place within and across their neighbourhoods to reclaim their place in the city.

3) What are the broader impacts of heritage-making from above and below on state-society politics in the city?

I interrogate how political processes work at various scales to capture the contested dynamics of state-society engagement in the arena of urban heritage and housing. This reflects the fundamental concern of this thesis about heritage-making as politics from above and below, by examining the connections and disjunctures of current power formations, and possibilities and challenges of subaltern agency.

3.3.1 Kampung as sites

To build my comparative cases, I first did a scan of urban villages which employ heritage-making as a strategy against existing and potential displacement. I relied on secondary sources such as newspapers, government and non-governmental reports and plans, communities' media outputs such as on social media platforms and websites, as well as pilot interviews to narrow the scope of neighbourhoods and stakeholders to focus on. Pilot interviews were carried out to understand relevant work being done by different groups (NGOs, government bodies, research institutes, community groups, and academics), as well as connections and networks in the field which predated my research. The pilot interviews also served to assess the appropriateness and feasibility of the research and of gaining access to people and communities under then Covid-19 pandemic conditions. With Indonesia being one of the countries worst hit by the pandemic, the urban poor and other marginalised groups including those in North Jakarta have been particularly affected as poverty, hunger, and mortality rates increased (Lamb et al., 2021). These initial interviews helped to shape a more grounded case selection and fine-tuned interview questions, in line with the research aims to consider perspectives from those in the field as early on as possible. These resulted in the establishment of my focus on the Kota Tua area in North-West Jakarta (see Chapter 1 for a detailed description of the Kota Tua area).

By bringing together the various heritage-making projects introduced in Chapter 1 within a postcolonial urban comparative framework, I examine how they shape and are shaped by urban village residents and their allies. Two neighbourhoods within the historical area of Kota Tua (Kampung Luar Batang and Pekojan) which are predominantly residential, were chosen as cases as they demonstrate an instance of these projects to varying degrees and have been identified as prone to gentrification in recent years (Dewi, 2017; Padawangi et al., 2016). As introduced in Chapter 1, Luar Batang and Pekojan are both indicative of the areas in Kota Tua which continue to elude, resist, navigate, and coincide with top-down urban planning. Each area in Kota Tua should have its own Urban Design Guidelines (UDGL), which is one level more specific than the Detailed Spatial Plan (*Rencana Detail Tata Ruang* (RDTR)) of DKI Jakarta government, as each area has its own building and environmental characteristics and issues, according to a UPK Kota Tua officer. The RDTR is based on the more general Regional Spatial Plan (*Rencana Tata Ruang Wilayah* (RTRW)) which forms part of the national spatial planning. Unlike Pecinan, the third Kota Tua neighbourhood which has a local masterplan (UDGL) in place, these two kampungs did not yet have such plans at the neighbourhood level but they have been subjected to various external plans which attempt to alter the space. While there have been several studies on the historical, architectural, morphological, and religious aspects of these two kampungs, there is a gap regarding how these various aspects come together in the wider context of Kota Tua and in conversation with each other which my study aims to fill. They demonstrate the richness of their local economies, professions, culinary traditions, arts and crafts, and social activities, alongside the problems and challenges they face – ecological hazards, lack of resources, deteriorating physical structures, inadequate public infrastructure and services, and varying degrees and types of displacement.

3.3.2 Qualitative mixed methods

The qualitative methods I employed were semi-structured interviews (online and offline), documents and visual materials (online and offline), and they complement each other as mediums which brought out subaltern voices and perspectives. It is imperative to consider not only the development of methods in light of technological, philosophical and ethical shifts, but also prevalent conditions such as the Covid-19 pandemic which directly impacted on the first two and a half years of this research. Only online or remote data collection with human

participants were allowed as isolation measures, research and travel restrictions were slowly and unevenly being lifted by July 2022. During my fieldwork, while it seemed like it was business-as-usual after the pandemic, Covid-19 effects were still being felt by residents, especially disrupted livelihoods and upkeep of places of worship that relied on patrons and visitors. Mask wearing was still mandatory on public transportation and in some public places until the last third of my fieldwork, and people continued to wear them well after, partly due to the crowdedness of public transportation and urban air pollution (Aqil & Harish, 2023). For these reasons, the notion of mixed methods as used in this thesis encapsulates the types (text, visual, speech), mode (offline and online), and complementary approaches to address limitations or inadequacies of a method whether by design or circumstance.

There has been much written about ‘pandemic’ methods, where either conventional methods are adapted to be carried out online and/or remotely (such as video-conferencing or telephone interviews), or more innovative ways of data collection (such as “born digital” content which has already been created on the internet) that can be readily used (Lupton, 2021). The pandemic has arguably been a major impetus for being more creative and resourceful with carrying out social research under unpredictable and often uneven conditions for participants and researchers. However in the context of Covid-19, mixed methods also take on a different meaning. It is not just about using different quantitative and qualitative methods together, but also having to navigate online and offline data collection and analysis more strategically and deliberately, with their own set of ethical concerns, which I will deal with in turn.

3.3.3 Semi-structured interviews

Semi-structured interviews were conducted with two main groups of participants. First, I interviewed participants from government agencies, academia, non-governmental organisations, and advocacy groups working on heritage and housing issues in Jakarta. The in-person interviews took place mainly in public spaces and offices around Kota Tua, on university campuses or elsewhere in Jakarta. Second, I interviewed participants who are residents, youth leaders, neighbourhood/community leaders, heritage activists, business owners, street vendors, religious leaders in Luar Batang and Pekojan, and other participants who live or work in Kota Tua and Jakarta (see Appendix 1). They reflect to some extent the different age groups, gender, ethnicity, and occupational backgrounds of the neighbourhood

residents. These mainly took place in the respective neighbourhoods, either in public spaces such as mosques, temples, community centres, roadside food stalls or kiosks (*warung*), or in the common spaces of participants' homes.

Participants were approached through a combination of prior contacts, snowballing, introductions from mutual contacts, and new connections from desk research. I sought the assistance of two young residents from the *kampung*s (one male in his early 30s, and one female in her late 20s) and an Indonesian researcher (a female in her early 30s) at my host university (Universitas Indonesia)²⁰, particularly for the initial interviews in the neighbourhoods. At times they helped to approach the potential participants first to secure their informal agreement and suitable time to speak with us since people would be out working or going about their activities. At other times, we would approach the potential participants together. Their presence as interlocutors helped put participants, including myself, at ease with their deep cultural and contextual knowledge, and made the interviews less formal and more conversational. The process also gave them the opportunity to connect with fellow residents, especially those they rarely spoke to. I conducted a total of 45 in-depth semi-structured interviews, 44 of which were recorded with permission from the participants interviewed who numbered 52 in total (see Appendix 1). Interviews were between one to two hours long. Out of these, 8 were online interviews conducted on Zoom when only online or remote data collection was allowed. There were various other informal conversations with *kampung* residents and follow-up questions with participants when clarification was needed. These informal interactions proved invaluable as the interview method may not suit everyone who wanted to speak, especially those who may not have the luxury of time away from daily demands, or be comfortable with the main attention on them during an interview. There were also instances where residents agreed to be interviewed once they were familiar with my presence in the neighbourhood.

The interview questions stemmed from the three research questions on process, outcome and impact of heritage-making projects (see Appendix 2). First, the interview questions on housing conditions in Jakarta aimed to seek participants' views on the state and future of housing for

²⁰ As part of the foreign research permit which is required for foreigners conducting research in Indonesia, a foreign researcher must be hosted at a local university or research partner where they would have a counterpart to collaborate in a mutually agreed manner set out in a formal letter of guarantee. I was hosted at the Department of Architecture, Faculty of Engineering at Universitas Indonesia, one of the top three universities in Indonesia. After my unsuccessful attempts to approach an NGO, I was recommended to approach this Department as they had done prior research in my proposed field sites. For further elaboration on the permit process, see Section 3.5.1.

the city's residents and the role of the kampung in the city. Second, questions on heritage-making projects aimed to seek their views on their understandings of heritage, how it compares with other actors' understandings and heritage claims, especially about the kampung, and on what heritage-making practices take place and how. Third, questions on outcomes and impacts of heritage-making sought participants' views of the security of housing, gentrification risks, and wider impacts of heritage-making projects on urban and national politics. The earlier version of questions was piloted with Indonesian peers and prior contacts, especially with regard to translating not just words but also meanings and contexts. The questions then shifted in emphases or order during different phases of interviewing to respond to changing dynamics or developments in the field. The semi-structured nature of the interviews also allowed for varied attention to be given to some questions, depending on the flow of the interview and the participants' inclination to speak more about certain aspects.

Choosing which heritage actors to engage with and how to include them were important considerations as the selection can serve to amplify or silence certain voices. This task was made more complex as communities are not internally coherent and homogenous. Certain social differences and their intersections have been given more attention than others in various gentrification and heritage studies. For instance, ethnicity, religion and class have been considered in scholarly and popular discourses on heritage, housing and gentrification in Jakarta (Abaza, 2004; Hew, 2019). There is, however, a need to consider their intersections and other axes of social differentiation such as gender and age in postcolonial heritage constructions. This makes heritage constructions inherently contestable and unstable with a range of heritage-making processes at play across different communities and actors, sometimes in collaboration or solidarity, other times in conflict or opposition.

One of the issues that became evident in interviews with kampung residents and especially women is the deeper meaning behind the concept of "ordinary people" and "ordinary things" (as labelled by some participants). In an interview with one resident in her early 60s who has been living in the Luar Batang neighbourhood since she was born, it was initially quite challenging to get the conversation going because she did not think she could answer the broad questions. With the assistance of a young resident there who started with more specific questions about daily life and events, she shared her life experiences growing up in the kampung and the changes and continuities that she had seen which she did not think were

significant to mention, but which were important pieces in the puzzle of understanding the kampung's housing situation. For example, in talking to her, it was the first time someone had mentioned that they used to live on the land near the kampung entrance at the main road, which has remained vacant for so long after plans to build apartment buildings there failed. She also spoke to the questions on heritage by giving examples of “ordinary things” such as culinary and building traditions. After this interview, the young resident reminded me that a previous interviewee had told us to manage our expectations when approaching “ordinary” residents there, and implied that this was probably what he meant. The encounter with the elderly woman underscored the importance of speaking about “ordinary things” to engage with “ordinary people” – that people have valuable experiences, memories, and thoughts which are often hidden for a variety of reasons, but the researcher also needs to be equipped to bring these to the surface.

One of the reasons valuable information remains hidden which I came across during interviews, was how some actors such as women knowledge holders tended to decentre themselves more, as compared to their male counterparts in their sharing of knowledge and experiences. “Don’t need to talk about me. Let’s talk about this [temple]. Which year it was built. Usually people would also photograph the main deity (*tuan rumah*) ... If about me, not important,” was what an elderly woman in her 70s, the main caretaker of a historical temple in one of the kampungs told me when we started talking about the challenges she faced in maintaining the temple and her livelihood as donations decreased drastically since Covid-19. This is as compared to what a mosque leader said when I asked him if there was anyone else who might be able to tell me more about the history and happenings of the neighbourhood: “you already spoke to Pak Mad, and now me, that should be enough.” He meant that he and Pak Mad, a former community leader, would have provided a sufficient overview of the kampung, especially because he was just describing a few minutes before of some instances where people tended to relay what was passed down to them or something they read off the internet without verifying the claims.

While language has often been acknowledged as having an important role in daily life and research, more attention needs to be given to how language is used by heritage actors as well as by researchers and their implications. Indonesian (*Bahasa Indonesia*), the official standardised language of Indonesia, birthed out of a nationalist project, contains an abundance of borrowed words (e.g., Dutch, Arabic, Chinese, Portuguese, Malay, English, Sanskrit to

varying degrees), infused with its over 700 local languages belonging to its over 1000 ethnic groups (e.g., Javanese, Sundanese, Buginese). This is before considering the innovations in formal and vernacular expressions, such as acronyms and portmanteaus which easily escape the uninitiated. Actors use particular language or words in their heritage-making strategies to ground their claims and appeal to certain communities or authorities, and some words are not easily translated.

For instance, in this thesis I use “housing”, “kampung”, and “neighbourhood”. While they are often used interchangeably in everyday life to describe the habitat or residence of a majority of Jakartans, they can carry different connotations. While “housing” is intended for more descriptive purposes of a physical building and the process of “providing places for people to live”²¹, “kampung” (literally: village) and “neighbourhood” cover a wider geographical area and are more socially and politically constructed and contested. These terms are useful organising tools to make sense of findings on housing issues, and to reflect people’s usage of the words in everyday life. Early in the research, I had used “*perumahan*” (literally: housing) to inquire about housing conditions and issues and it came to light that the common usage of this word is usually in reference to housing complexes, which widely vary in types, in the local context. This usage has thus far undesirable connotations as elaborated in Chapter 4 kampung sections, such as when a resident from an evicted kampung in North Jakarta who was supposed to move into public rental vertical housing somewhere much further away, expressed “relocating people is not just about moving bodies, it’s their way of life and jobs”. By tending to these various connotations, I also aim to bring their relations in the Jakartan context to the fore, and in conversation with elsewhere, while navigating the challenges of translating and interpreting complex concepts and lived realities in a place for various audiences (e.g. participants, readers, present and future).

Interviews were conducted in the first instance online mainly via Zoom during the Covid-19 pandemic, and this included pilot interviews. The pilot interviews were useful to test out the substantial, technical and procedural parts of the process. For instance, ensuring that there is an alternative if the camera or network connection malfunctions halfway through the interview, such as switching to another device which was ready in the background and agreeing with

²¹ “Housing,” <https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/english/housing> (Last accessed February 2024).

participants beforehand what to do when disconnected. When it became permissible and appropriate for in-person data collection to take place, interviews were carried out in person and were complemented with ethnographic observations that enriched the study especially for the first two research questions on process and outcome of heritage-making strategies. In-person interviews provided the opportunity to understand more than what was being said, as I was able to spend time with the participants and other residents in their everyday environment. This allowed for more informal interactions which often brought out the unscripted and helped put both researcher and participant more at ease (McLees, 2013), especially as compared to an online environment which tended to feel more formal due to more linear proceedings. For instance, only one person could be speaking at any point in time, and any background sounds might suppress the person speaking.

For offline interviews, more attention was needed in terms of logistics (such as the things I need to bring along, how and where I set up), and surroundings (such as what if there are non-participants hanging around). Offline interviews also required more multi-tasking (listening, talking, taking notes, live observations, audio recording, and transitions). Unlike in online interviews, when the time “in the field” presumably ends when the camera is off, it is often less clear in offline interviews where different scenarios may ensue. For example, there were transitions into more casual interactions or the interview ended promptly and I left due to either the participant’s or my schedule. For both online and in-person interviews, at times the interview itself became a rapport building exercise especially with participants I was meeting for the first time. In such cases, subsequent informal conversations and ethnographic observations supported the data collected.

3.3.4 Ethnographic observations: field notes and diary

Ethnographic observations helped mitigate the limitations of interviews which happen under certain controlled conditions, as revelations or a deeper understanding of what people have described often happen over time and in relation to the field environment. For instance, Kampung Luar Batang is transformed on Thursday nights, weekends, and on special occasions, as droves of pilgrims arrive from various parts of the country and overseas, filling up the usually empty parking lot in front of the mosque gates with big cars, and patronising the myriad of stalls vending food and goods around the area and in the main streets of the neighbourhood.

“Hanging out”, described as an ethnographic method of “physical, informal, and prolonged immersion in a cultural environment” (Browne & McBride, 2015 citing Clifford Geertz), in the area regularly allowed me to observe simultaneous, often mundane, activities taking place. For instance, on one day I noted that there was ongoing reconstruction of the mosque’s gates with workers calmly painting while atop a rickety scaffold, as a small trickle of visitors and vehicles came in and out of the temporary car park. English pop songs were also being played from a speaker at a food stall nearby. These observations, which engage the different senses are useful entry points to understanding people’s experiences and uses of space in the neighbourhood, alongside interviews which may or may not capture these spatio-temporal occurrences.

Often these observations also occur as serendipitous moments which helped connect not only analytical concerns but also helped to imprint the connection more strongly for the participants and researcher. An instance of this was about the question of gender representation in a neighbourhood’s history. During a discussion with a community historian about a book project on eminent figures in their community, it appeared that not only were women excluded from the list (which is predictable given the historical contexts), but their role in the community was also not discussed even though there were noteworthy events and artefacts concerning women in the neighbourhood. Given that each community has its own gender relations and dynamics which an outsider may not be privy to, I asked him to consider some potential critiques that could be addressed by a better explanation of the contexts. A youth leader present supported this by highlighting that gender issues are becoming increasingly important in higher education and popular media and that it was important to address. The gender question later resurfaced in an amusing way because we adjourned to a nearby coffee shop for an interview and our mutual acquaintance, a female, needed to use the bathroom but there was only a urinal in there.

As I made frequent visits to the same sites, at the same or different times of the day, across different days and meeting the same or different people, these visits helped me fill the gaps and shed light on further aspects of the neighbourhood. It reiterated to me that while interviews were important as focused sessions of exchange, they need to be supported with other methods of inquiry and triangulated with other forms of data. One of the significant yet under-the-radar development in Pekojan was brought to my attention one day upon returning from an interview in the kampung. I passed by an incomplete construction of a small building, with some open

space in front, enclosed by wire fences under a flyover. I later found out from various sources that it was supposedly the heritage and literacy centre that the community historian was building from the ground-up amidst competing interests and funding issues for the space, which he had not yet mentioned during our interview or other informal meetings (see Chapter 4 for further elaboration). Beyond observing the main sites in Kota Tua, I also attended lectures, events, and workshops by various government agencies, NGOs, and resident groups that pertain to heritage and housing issues of Kota Tua and the wider city of Jakarta. These not only allowed me to triangulate information across different sources and sites, but to also gain a broader perspective of the dynamics of urban politics in Jakarta.

Whether data collection takes place online or in person, ethnographic field notes and the use of research diaries are important tools for reflexive research. While field notes “describe what is happening in the field: the researcher’s observations, descriptions of places, events, people and actions”, and may include reflections and early analyses, a field diary contains more personal thoughts, feelings, and issues which the researcher may encounter in the field but which are usually buried in the final write up (Punch, 2012, p. 90). Addressing reflexivity through positionality has been increasingly critiqued as merely a check box for researchers in their methodology. For instance, Samantha Punch (2012, p. 87) argues that when researchers articulate their positionality as part of being reflexive and critical about their own research, it is often couched in a “relatively safe manner by focusing on social categories of gender, class, or ethnicity rather than on more controversial issues such as personality”. By keeping a research diary to capture emotions and personality more systematically and deliberately, it enriches the quality of the data collected and analysed as the immediate context of the researcher is considered, as is their mental state (thoughts, emotions, and bodily experiences) in the field. Furthermore, it is consistent with the recognition that knowledge is partial and situated (Myers, 2010; Rose, 1997).

The way I have used these field notes and diary closely resemble what Punch has delineated, with added layers. “Field notes” were my handwritten interview notes, which were observations and exchanges before, during and after the interview, with further questions and preliminary themes that directly address the research questions flagged. My “field diary” consisted of my reflections after the interview about the interview process itself, how it went and how I felt about the encounter, and any realisations which occurred as I processed the

interview in my mind. These reflections would be written down with the field notes, or typed up on a notes application on my mobile phone when I was on the move – both of which feed in a larger digital document which was organised chronologically, with daily journaling about observations and reflections for the whole fieldwork period.

These two mediums are supplemented by a third document, a weekly memo²² where I laid out plans for the week ahead and reflected on the week that passed and actualisation of all fieldwork-related tasks. This was both for accountability purposes and importantly, a second layer of processing possible themes, after the first impressions were recorded in the field notes. The weekly document was useful for connecting between my personal experiences navigating the field as a foreign researcher and what I observed in the field sites, which allowed for further reflexivity on relations and ways of being in the field. For instance, in the early days of my fieldwork the concept of difference surfaced as something important in both the research sites and my lived experiences of settling in a different country. Perceiving and negotiating difference was deeply embedded in daily life – in practices (e.g. informalities in tenancy agreements and process, dressing styles, and means of travelling in the city), in spoken and written languages (e.g. regional, ethnic, or urban accents, portmanteaus), in spaces of inclusion and exclusion (e.g. gender, class and age disparities in heritage groups, shopping malls, public spaces and events). These send signals to individuals who interpret and decide how to interact with the other. In retrospect I found that using these ethnographic mediums in these ways made space for creative thought processes to occur at different moments while living in and researching about the field. While I found this heuristic system of taking notes and the incremental approach to analysis useful in my research, it could become cumbersome and tedious to maintain, and the initial intensity or detailed efforts might be difficult to sustain especially for a longer period of ethnography.

3.3.5 Textual and visual data collection

The semi-structured interview questions focused on certain themes while allowing participants to craft their own narratives, drawing from their experiences, feelings, and thoughts. These

²² I use this in reference to Johnny Saldaña's (2016, p. 44) description of analytic memos as "somewhat comparable to researcher journal entries or blogs – a place to "dump your brain" about the participants, phenomenon, or process under investigation by thinking and thus writing and thus thinking even more about them."

narratives often involve or require contextualisation for a proper analysis of their (re)production (Atkinson, 2015). Texts and visuals, whether shown by the participants or sourced by the researcher help to corroborate, situate, question, illuminate, and augment insights gained from the interviews as they explore the unspoken, unconscious, nonverbal dimensions of meaning-making (McLees, 2013).

For textual data gathered through desk-based research and participants, I drew from a variety of documents, ranging from government policies and reports, NGO publications, activist and community records (on websites, social media accounts, historical documents), as well as news outlets about heritage-making, housing and gentrification issues surrounding Kota Tua. These data directly shaped and addressed the three research questions, and helped to contextualise attitudes, actions, events of various actors regarding heritage-making strategies, housing issues and gentrification. They were also a means of knowledge exchange as I could share materials I came across in English and Indonesian with participants, while they could share materials in Indonesian which are not easily found online or offline.

Other sources which are closely linked to texts and often interpreted together are visual materials. They were already commonly used before the advent of digital technologies and social media platforms which further facilitated their usage and spread, and which has been useful for heritage actors during the pandemic when being online shaped much of people's realities. Visual materials commonly used by heritage actors include but are not limited to: photos, videos, posters, postcards, portraits, heritage brochures, tourist or trivia game sets, versions of city maps, murals, and even real estate advertisements (Jolivet & Alba-Carmichael, 2021). These were accessed in the physical forms (shown by participants or collected from field visits) and in virtual forms (websites, social media platforms).

Using visual materials is not without its problems in a postcolonial approach. For instance, the relationship between photography and colonialism has been well documented and continues to shape post-colonial practices which control how vulnerable populations are portrayed – what is made visible and what is hidden (Çelik, 2004; Crang, 2010). Their objectification under the gaze of the powerful in society, which is no longer confined to the local given the reach of information and communication technologies, have longstanding negative consequences on their communities and personal lives. First, this highlights the importance of mixed methods in

addressing both the presence and absences. Second, communities are not passive subjects of visual and knowledge production as they too understand the power of images and narratives (Vergès, 2014). Communities have also, over time and facilitated by more accessible and affordable technologies, attempted to subvert, reappropriate or reinforce dominant constructions of heritage and urban development. The varied uses of old monochromatic photos, especially those from the Dutch archives and family collections, proved to be an invaluable part of heritage claims. For some, it is about the ability to restore the original building as shown in those old photos that demonstrates authenticity, and for others, it is about proving the existence of something though it is no longer there or has been drastically altered. To have an image of something is to claim belonging in the place, as Roland Barthes (1980, p. 87) said, “Every photograph is a certificate of presence.”

3.4. Analysing the data

Data collection took place in two main phases, partly due to the Covid-19 pandemic. Round 1 (February 2022 - July 2022) consisted of pilot and online interviews, as well as text and visual data collection for building the case studies. After some initial data processing and reflection from Round 1, Round 2 (December 2022 - August 2023) consisted of in-person interviews with a wider group of participants. Ethnographic observations were also conducted during this period. During the second round, preliminary data analysis in the form of field notes and weekly memos was conducted to reflect on emerging themes and evaluate data collection processes.

The process of analysing the data was not linear and started even before formally commencing the “analysis” stage of this study, which was after the end of the fieldwork period in Jakarta. Processing the data meant listening to the recordings, transcribing the interviews, translating key quotes, organising the textual and visual materials. It also needed time for new, hidden, or alternative perspectives to surface, since knowledge is situated and incomplete. For instance, an idea or a connection which I did not yet piece together in the field, came through much later when I was able to step back to process and analyse the data. One of the stories from the field which I was reminded of much later convinced me about the importance of allowing people to tell their stories as a way of complex sensemaking. Two residents were describing collective efforts to put out fires effectively as a hallmark of the kampung’s social compact. They then

linked the issue to the growing population density of the kampung which has resulted in some alleys being too narrow for public emergency vehicles to pass. It then brought out the incident where residents' pent-up frustration towards the government manifested in some people wanting to burn down a smaller ambulance which finally came through only after the fire was extinguished. Just one answer about kampung characteristics brought out the other angles in such a connected way.

As mentioned in the previous section on ethnographic notes, I started to have a sense of which themes were resonating across the different data streams, while through the weekly memos I started to draw out some of the key findings thematically according to the research questions. For the question on heritage construction, the broad themes were: 1) defining heritage; 2) focus of heritage-making (e.g. kampungs, places of worship, renovations, image, economy, tourism); and 3) mediums of heritage-making (e.g. documents, technology, knowledge holders). On housing outcomes, the broad themes were security, social life, ecological issues, differentiation, gentrification, housing forms, and the future. Lastly, on political impacts, the broad themes were: 1) actors and organisations; 2) local politics; and 3) relations (e.g. family, ethnicity, religion, class, gender, generational). I used these broad themes to guide the coding process, to ensure that the analyses were answering the research question. These codes were first derived manually, by going through interview transcripts, documents, and images. I employed mainly In Vivo, Process, and Values coding methods which are often used together in initial coding processes (Saldaña, 2016).²³ Once I started to see a pattern of themes across the first few manual coding and the dataset was growing, I moved the coding process to NVivo 14 software for qualitative data analysis. I set up coding tables that correspond with the abovementioned broad themes under each of the three main research questions, and added more specific codes over time as certain themes became more significant and warranted their own codes.

3.5. Reflections on ethics and positionality in knowledge production

²³ "In Vivo Codes use the direct language of participants as codes rather than researcher-generated words and phrases" (Saldaña, 2016, p. 71), while "Process Coding... extracts participant action/interaction and consequences, and the documentation of routines and rituals" (Saldaña, 2016, p. 296), and "Values Coding" is applied to "data that reflect a participant's values, attitudes, and beliefs, representing his or her perspectives or worldview" (Saldaña, 2016, p. 298).

Through a postcolonial qualitative approach, I set out to centre subaltern experiences and voices while recognising that knowledge production is situated and always incomplete. These qualitative considerations require that I reflect on how my position, values, and beliefs impact on the research, and how my intervention in the field, in theorising, interacting, analysing, and writing, engage with the existing structures of knowledge production in different contexts.

3.5.1 Ethics

Due to the Covid-19 pandemic, three layers of ethics approval were required, and they helped clarify and reinforce ethical commitments to research participants. The first was for remote and online data collection with human participants; the second was when I transitioned to in-person fieldwork in Jakarta, with a risk assessment added; and the third was for the foreign research permit process required by Indonesia. Following the ethical guidelines set out by my home institution in the United Kingdom, and the National Research and Innovation Agency of Indonesia (BRIN), it was imperative that I ensured participants had adequate information and consented to participating in the study in ways which were safe and conducive for them. Before beginning any interview, I explained my study, provided a copy of the participant information sheet and consent form (see Appendix 3)²⁴, and checked with participants if they had any questions or concerns before, during, and after the interview. Most participants felt comfortable to give written consent, while a few chose to give recorded verbal consent. Various measures were taken to ensure anonymity, confidentiality, and data integrity. These included labelling recordings and transcripts with codes, replacing participants' names with pseudonyms, keeping all records under password protection, and handling the transcription of interviews myself.

Being a foreign citizen meant that I needed to apply for a research permit to conduct research in Indonesia and navigate the written and unwritten rules. At the time of my application, the system was undergoing major changes and adjustments as countrywide management and conduct of research was being centralised at a new national-level government agency named BRIN. It introduced more uncertainties in the process and paradoxically decentralised the process as it included navigating different government, academic, and localised neighbourhood institutions – all of which have their own rules and interests, and since BRIN was then relatively new, its processes were unfamiliar to many of them. As detailed by Nicholas J. Long (2023),

²⁴ These were translated into Indonesian by me and checked by native Indonesian speakers.

BRIN is more “hands-off” than its ministerial predecessor, with more responsibilities delegated to Indonesian counterparts which then increased burdens and expectations of the international collaboration which the permit intended to promote. The intricacies of such a process alone for foreign researchers working within and across different (two, in my case) countries’ approval systems, uneven in their standing, resources, and luck, need further examination.²⁵ For instance, a requirement of the permit application is a letter of acceptance from an Indonesian counterpart, who can be from a university, research institution, or non-governmental organisation which have their own priorities and criteria for collaboration, such as the ranking of the foreign researcher’s home institution.

Going through such a laborious ethics approval process was important to ensure adequate measures were in place for the protection of participants against possible direct or indirect harms. However, on the ground, various ethical issues surfaced which went beyond what was possible to be contained or imagined within the few sheets of an ethics application. This includes dealing with power relations which are contextual and not always obvious, given the multiple identities a researcher might have and how they are perceived by participants who are not only on the receiving end of inquiry but also co-construct the field. Jenna Burrell (2009, p. 195) points out that “examining the role(s) assigned to the researchers by those they study is one route to understanding the highly connected lives and global orientations of people and societies in the twenty-first century.” Often participants expressed how they understood that as a “student” (*mahasiswa*), the researcher needs guidance and instruction to expand their knowledge, and is to be received as a “guest (*tamu*) who brings blessings”. There were instances where the participant appraised my interview questions (“this is the best question”) or offered others I should be asking (“you need to know, find out”). At other times, interview questions which opened up more questions had made participants want to increase their own knowledge about certain heritages. These demonstrated their power, agency, and interest in shaping inquiries, based on how they perceive the inquirer. This perception is also highly contextual and draws upon their previous experiences and worldly knowledge.

Ethical research goes beyond the protection and interests of an individual participant. This research aimed to inform urban policymaking and advocacy for a more just urban development

²⁵ See Davies (2019) for a useful guide and documentation of experiences of foreign researchers before the change in system.

and governance, as well as make its findings useful for participants and their communities. However, Tuhiwai Smith's (2021, p. 2) critique about the leap between ideas and realities of research projects, in particular those on indigenous communities comes to mind: "belief in the ideal that benefitting mankind is indeed a primary outcome of scientific research is as much a reflection of ideology as it is of academic training". Researchers cannot assume that our research will necessarily benefit our research participants, not least in the exact ways that we intend. It is important to listen to what participants are saying (or not saying) when they are speaking.

However, this point does not exempt researchers from reciprocating and navigating varied expectations of benefit from participants in return for their input into the research. Tuhiwai Smith (2021, p. 16) argues that we have a duty towards the people and communities in which we do research to share insights and the aftermath of the project, to "report back". In my proposals, I intended to fulfil this duty by offering relevant work-in-progress presentations; exchanging knowledge on common topics of interest through seminars, workshops, and co-producing publications; and by helping to strengthen networks across communities and institutions involved in Jakarta, London, and Singapore. These aims were only partly fulfilled in the duration of my doctoral research. But the duty itself is and should not be confined to the limits of a doctoral project, as one participant reminded me, that research should not be a "one-off." There were various instances where participants expressed their hopes that either me or my research could "help Indonesia progress" or "so that this kampung is not forgotten." This reflects on their hopeful agency and ways to galvanise their communities to participate and take ownership, but also often on their perception of the researcher's positionality, to which I now turn.

3.5.2 Positionality

The critical approaches explored provide the impetus for reflection on pursuing this research as someone who would neither be simply considered 'local' nor 'foreigner' in Jakarta, even as these categories are themselves problematic. I claim my origins from the region (the Malay Archipelago, Nusantara, the Malay World, among other names) and share historical and cultural (ethnic, religious, language) similarities and ancestry with peoples of Jakarta and Indonesia at large. Yet I recognise the impact on the research of the differences in realities and

socialisations, of having been raised and educated in Singapore and its institutions which claim to provide the best of the 'East' and 'West', and pursuing this doctoral research at a British university. This assemblage of identities and socialisation contains both opportunities and challenges. The privileges of cultural affinity include being Malay-speaking, which is close to Indonesian (*Bahasa Indonesia*), and being visibly Muslim (i.e. wearing the headscarf) in a Muslim-majority country. This also meant that many Indonesians I spoke to were either initially confused or in disbelief that I was from Singapore (instead of Malaysia, for instance) since the majority of its population is ethnically Chinese, which generated further curiosity and exchange.

The more obvious elements which identified me as being an 'outsider' are language and comportment. Native Indonesian speakers have varying regional accents, allowing my spoken Indonesian alone, which could originate from the western parts of Indonesia closer to Malaysia, to meld into the Indonesian milieu over time. However the usage of language is very much tied to how we perceive and experience the world that, especially in unscripted conversations, brings forth the nuances. In this sense the role of interlocutors, who were usually the field assistants, were invaluable as a bridge since spoken and written Bahasa Indonesia could be quite different, and miscommunication a possibility as there are many shared words in Malay and Indonesian which have totally different meanings. This is compounded by the ubiquitous use of WhatsApp as a means of both personal and business communication in Indonesia, which challenges the researcher to figure out the appropriate practice and registers in which to communicate with different participants. However, the differences sometimes became a point of connection, as participants often extend encouragement and grace in making sure the 'outsider' understands what they mean when they use certain words or carry out certain actions.

In terms of behaviour, I was made more aware of how one moves in public spaces, such as walking as a means of getting to places instead of using motorcycle taxis (*ojek*) or minibuses (*angkot*), among other popular modes of urban transportation. Locals rarely walked to get from one place to another if it is more than one to two minutes' walk, either due to inconvenience, uneven or non-existent pavements. Women also rarely walked alone, which I sometimes did to get to the kampungs, and it drew some curious glances and questions from residents as my appearance could easily lead people to think I was a local resident. Such sociocultural differences sometimes felt amplified given the many apparent similarities.

Following Chen's (2010) proposal on inter-referencing, these complex and at times problematic combinations of categories, such as insider and outsider as well as race and ethnicity, can become productive sites of knowledge and self-transformation. One of the common questions I received, be it in Singapore, Jakarta, or London, is why I chose to study urban kampungs in Indonesia. It is also a common assumption that I must be Indonesian by origin since I am interested in this presumably local and specific phenomenon. People question less when one is studying one's own society or country, than when one is studying a foreign place. I find that this is especially the case for scholars from the Global South who are expected to do the former to improve their own societies, for various reasons which need further examination. As Singapore is often not considered part of the Global South, my presence in Jakarta was at times doubly bewildering, as I will elaborate at the end of this section. Such comments provided me with crucial material for further reflection towards a comparative postcolonial approach which is grounded in Asian inter-referencing where knowledge exchange happens, and perceptions are reshaped, often under unequal conditions.

The recurring question of "why Indonesia?" from participants and even fellow Singaporeans led me to think deeply about what drew me to the phenomenon of urban villages in general and in Jakarta specifically. It was partly the result of subconsciously following and living through the evolution of ideas and realities of "kampung" in Singapore. This underlying interest took more shape after my first visit to Jakarta in 2018 for exploratory research on housing and urbanisation in my capacity as a research assistant in a research centre in Singapore. The various attempts at (re)constructing the kampung (including its inhabitants) as socially undesirable at one point in time and desirable at another are intriguing. Negative stereotyping of kampungs in the early days of public housing projects in Singapore in the 1960s and 1970s to get people to relocate and support the national programme can be juxtaposed nowadays with state-led efforts to rehabilitate the kampung discourse and community or neighbourly 'spirit'. One such effort is the New Urban Kampung Research Programme which "combines data analytics and behavioural studies to develop tools and strategies to create resilient and inclusive communities" in public housing where most Singaporeans live (HDB, 2021). On the other side, in some state and public discourses in Jakarta, Singapore's high-rise public housing programme is often cited as a successful example and benchmark (Padawangi, 2019a), yet the programme is not without its own set of issues, some of which could only be fathomed on hindsight. During

my fieldwork, there were also various questions from participants about public housing in Singapore. Towards the end of my fieldwork when there were visibly more high-rise developments and the reclaimed area of Pantai Indah Kapuk along the northern coast of Jakarta was more developed (see Chapter 4), there was an all-too-familiar sense of ‘global’ city-making which reminded me of Singapore’s own development. These kinds of questionings and reflections are points of departure for a more critical inter-referencing in postcolonial spaces in Southeast Asia.

If Singapore was not already present in the minds of participants in their daily life, my presence did bring forth more varied discussions about Singapore. “Why Indonesia” was also another way for some participants to ask what was there for a person from a “developed country” like Singapore to learn from a “developing country”, if not to take advantage of the latter. Some participants were aware of the at times tense relations between Singapore and Indonesia on issues such as sand exports, and Singapore’s role and influence in private urban development such as in North Jakarta (Teresia & Christina, 2023; Valenta, 2024). The cautionary tale of Singapore’s development at the expense of its indigenous population who have been displaced has also been used to counter top-down and elite efforts to model Jakarta’s urban development projects after Singapore’s success stories (Subarkah, 2016). In this way, I was also learning about Singapore’s history and image as constructed from the outside, and the dynamic interconnections between postcolonial countries in the region. However, I also acknowledge that while Singapore is a cautionary tale for some, the fact that it is a model for many government, elite and non-elite actors may have also informed how they perceived my positionality and their positive reception towards me.

3.6. Conclusion

In this chapter, I presented the postcolonial and comparative approaches which influenced my research design. While this research employed conventional ethnographic methods in the form of interviews, as well as document and visual analysis which complement each other, it is guided by a postcolonial ethos of questioning uneven power relations and processes of knowledge production in heritage-making projects. In doing so, I also extend their utility in examining research processes with participants from various background such as kampung residents, community leaders, non-governmental organisations, advocacy groups, local

government representatives, and heritage professionals, with a focus on subaltern actors who exercise their agency in ways which are not confined to conventional politics. Shaped by these methodological considerations grounded in a conceptual framework from the literature review, I then analysed the different streams of data through a careful and deliberate strategy of thematic analysis in layered qualitative coding. This research has given me much to reflect on in terms of ethics and positionality as a researcher from one Southeast Asian country, conducting research in another, under the auspices of a British institution.

Through this I aim to contribute to the literature on postcolonial and comparative approaches that promotes inter-referencing between urban cases in the Global South, as well as the relation between online and offline modes of qualitative research which have become increasingly and unevenly intertwined in a post-Covid world. By bringing the case of Jakarta and Kota Tua's kampungs to the fore, I draw together the various aspects of the city and city dwellers' lives which hitherto have been studied separately. In the following chapters, I present the findings organised around each research question where I bring forth a comparative discussion of Kota Tua and two of its kampungs on the process, outcomes, and impact of heritage-making on politics in the city.

Chapter 4. Heritage-making in Kota Tua and its kampungs

4.1. Introduction

In this chapter I examine the constructions of heritage by various actors present in Jakarta's *Kota Tua* (Old Town) and two of its urban kampungs, Luar Batang and Pekojan to understand the role of heritage-making in advancing or resisting gentrification-led displacement in a rapidly developing urban context such as Jakarta. From the outline of actors engaged with heritage-making in Kota Tua and their relations with each other as given in Chapter 1, I argue that the dominant heritage constructions by key actors in Kota Tua demonstrate a top-down colonial-capitalist logic which is at times reappropriated or challenged by kampung residents and visitors who use the space in different ways. Top-down heritage-making by state and private sector entities demonstrates a higher likelihood of driving gentrification through the commodification of space, prioritising capital and material values in heritage preservation with little consideration for low-income residents. The second section develops the argument by showing how local and national authorities employ signages, and national and global discourses, with an emphasis on colonial buildings and the private sector's involvement.

The third and fourth section delves into subaltern constructions of heritage. Using Luar Batang and Pekojan as case studies, I argue that they employ heritage-making from below in various forms (buildings, traditions, and narratives) to reclaim their place in the city, amidst threats of displacement. While both sites focus on religious heritage-making, they do so in different ways that correspond to the various pressures they face, as well as the historical, political, religious, and spatial complexities under which such heritage-making takes place. In Luar Batang, heritage discourse and efforts have become centred on the Luar Batang mosque and shrine, as its other heritage elements fade with changing population and ecological conditions. In Pekojan, however, heritage discourse and efforts are more dispersed due to its diverse heritage and residential composition. Subaltern actors strive imperfectly to maintain their kampungs as spaces of living heritage through attempts to reinforce and expand collective and community spaces and relations. The fifth section examines the ways in which top-down and subaltern heritage-making employ old and new technologies to produce heritage which empower and democratise heritage-making, amidst existing social hierarchies and asymmetries in knowledge production.

4.2. Top-down constructions of heritage in Kota Tua

Conceptions of Kota Tua as a heritage site are dominated by top-down constructions that manifest in various forms. The focus on the built environment is the most common, and these can be seen in visual, textual, and discourse reinforcements. Kota Tua is one of the three cultural heritage areas which are protected (*kawasan cagar budaya*) under the Jakarta provincial government law. Like the other two sites, there are claims that the Kota Tua designation was not preceded by proper research and preparation about the heritage qualities, values and protection of the site that such a designation would have ordinarily required, as explained by one heritage expert. This indicates that a top-down decision was made for political expediency to conserve these areas that were experiencing increased development pressures, though the lack of preparation and follow through sees these areas racing against time to protect the old buildings and infrastructure in accordance with colonial, nationalist, or neoliberal discourses.

The geographical area considered as Kota Tua was downsized and reorganised from five historical districts, to two clusters named Area Inside the City Wall (*Area Dalam Tembok*) and Area Outside the City Wall (*Area Luar Tembok*) (DKI Jakarta Government, 2014; Robertson et al., 2014). The three neighbourhoods or *kampungs* (Luar Batang, Pecinan and Pekojan) which were initially included in the 1975 delineation of Kota Tua as separate districts are now categorised as a group under the Area Outside the City Wall.

Connectedly, the three *kampungs* were also included in the Kota Tua area in 2015 for the UNESCO World Heritage List nomination dossier submitted by Indonesia. According to various heritage experts and residents interviewed, the urban neighbourhoods included in the delineation were not actively involved in the drawing of the lines. However, one of the accidental impacts of the haphazard heritage area designation and delineation for Kota Tua has been that it has nudged some residents and business owners to consider the character of the area as part of their building renovations or business plans in seeking permission to redevelop in the protected area. This has undoubtedly given more work to heritage experts (mainly TACB and TSP) appointed by the city government to review the applications, but also more authority to government actors over heritage-making in these neighbourhoods.

This top-down shifting of boundaries, reminiscent of colonial zoning strategies that segregated populations, impacts on heritage protection. According to a local government officer, the downsizing of the heritage area means that their job “can be more focused on the inner area,” while the wider area can yield to tourism development needs, making it easier for businesses to come in and “support” the growing demands of tourism in the Old Town. However a heritage activist from a nearby kampung viewed such a situation as “sacrificing” the heritage area and giving in to businesses so that they can take up more space in the Kota Tua area. This means that heritage-making about and by the surrounding kampungs is also impacted in the redefined and increasingly commodified space.

While they are spatially included in top-down delineations such as the above, kampungs as residential areas fall outside the scope of the national heritage protection law which operates through a narrow framework of restoration (*pemugaran*). This means that discussion of kampungs in authorities’ consideration is not from the point of view of kampung as having heritage “value”, but more about the heritage objects (*cagar budaya*) within it that might warrant protection, according to one heritage expert appointed by the government. He also explained that operationally, they do consider the vision of the sitting governor who could be supportive of kampungs to avoid conflicting agendas. This means that heritage experts could play a crucial role in advocating for kampung communities by navigating the spaces in-between structural constraints.

He conceded that the value of areas such as kampungs should not only be assessed through the heritage protection lens but as housing areas, which would require political will and appropriate policy paradigms, which as other cases show, is possible. One such case he mentioned was the Betawi Cultural Village (*Kampung Setu Babakan*) in South Jakarta which has been a designated special area (*kawasan khusus*) since 2004 for the preservation of Betawi culture, which is rapidly disappearing with the decline in the Betawi population who are native to Jakarta.²⁶ The village does not yet have an official heritage status (*cagar budaya*) that is based on meeting the established criteria, and the process and impacts of preserving Betawi culture in this manner had varying reception, according to one heritage expert. However he highlighted that the

²⁶ For in-depth explanation about the emergence of Betawi as an ethnic group in Batavia (now Jakarta), see the works of Yasmine Shahab and Ridwan Saidi (Tjahjono, 2003).

existence of the cultural village demonstrates the possibilities of political will and interest of the Jakarta city government to preserve the culture of a community. I will return to this cultural village example in the two case studies later in the chapter.

Once the Kota Tua area became a “heritage area”, there is a reordering of space which attempts to discipline people using those spaces. From one angle, the expansion of a heritage area could be argued as an attempt to integrate communities and neighbourhoods, but the outcome shows an attempt to segregate the ‘formal’ and ‘informal’, to establish a clean slate. According to residents’ and visitors’ recollections, there used to be shops, street vendors all lined up from end to end in front of the maritime museum which is on one side of the river in the Sunda Kelapa area, and joining up with the fish market (*Pasar Ikan*) on the opposite side of the canal. This could still be seen in Google Street View of the area available from April 2013 to August 2023, at the time of writing.²⁷ Pak De, a hawker in his 60s, has had a roadside food stall in the area for more than a decade, and he used to live in a kampung nearby which has since been evicted. Facing the ongoing revitalisation construction works, with neat sidewalks and green bushes being planted, he was concerned about eventually being asked to move as this was part of the “heritage area”. His is one of the only few stalls left around the area, much dependent on an informal arrangement which places him in perpetual precarity as the management of the area (which is under the aegis of the maritime museum) changes periodically. This begs the question of whether heritage designation must erase existing physical and social infrastructures, and whose ideas and futures these erasures fit with.

4.2.1 Signages

Besides the redrawing of spatial boundaries, the three features which are focused on in top-down heritage constructions of Kota Tua are: signages, discourses, and colonial buildings. As part of the built environment, a common but often understated sight in Kota Tua and its surroundings is the variety of signages. At first they do not seem particularly problematic because they are situated in different parts, serving as traffic directions or pedestrian navigation. However a closer observation reveals the overlapping, conflicting, and at times disparate spatio-temporal constructions of Kota Tua that allude to the different heritage-making projects and jurisdictions of various local and central authorities.

²⁷ This can be seen in Figure 5.7 in the next chapter.

When asked about the old and new signages and maps around the area, a local government officer in the heritage conservation department said that there is an element of integration in the newer signages that bring together the various historic districts, and that they help in showing visitors that Kota Tua is beyond Fatahillah Square (*Taman Fatahillah*). This acknowledges the common perception that “Kota Tua” is only the area around Fatahillah Square where the Jakarta History Museum (also known as Fatahillah Museum) is, which was the city hall during the Dutch colonial period. This perception also excludes the surrounding kampung areas. However the appearance of integration brought about by thematic signages across the different parts of Kota Tua may do little to shift this common perception. This is because the part that the Kota Tua Management Unit (UPK Kota Tua) currently controls and has authority over is the Fatahillah Square, even though the signages by them such as in Figure 4.1 and Figure 4.2 include the other historical parts, according to a UPK Kota Tua officer. The UPK team has the security, orderliness, and cleanliness of the square to boast of as part of their track record, which is often in contrast to the adjacent areas that still attract street vendors who have been disallowed to operate in the square. The contrast therefore amplifies the common perception that Kota Tua equates to Fatahillah Square, even though the signages suggest otherwise.



Figure 4.1 UPK Kota Tua signage at the makeshift entrance of Kampung Susun Aquarium, showing the direction to Luar Batang Mosque (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 4.2 UPK Kota Tua signage on Fatahillah Square, showing directions to different landmarks. (Source: Author, 2023)

Frequent visits allowed me to witness the maritime museum and fish market area becoming more and more ‘integrated’ into Kota Tua tourism via signages, but at the same time sharper distinctions can be observed with its immediate residential surroundings. Figure 4.3, Figure 4.4, and Figure 4.5 show new pedestrian signages in different parts of Kota Tua. The signage in Figure 4.3 is nearest to inner Kota Tua while the one in Figure 4.4 is further north, nearer to the harbour. The latter did not have any words yet but was already in disrepair with grass growing around it one year later, as seen in Figure 4.5. The presence of the same signage material in the two spots serves to highlight the disparities in attention and maintenance between the inner and outer Kota Tua. The thematic lamp posts around the maritime museum area have also been rendered unusable as parts such as cables have been pulled out. According to residents, these were usual looting of public property, and repairs by the relevant authorities who provided the infrastructure have been wanting.



Figure 4.3 Pedestrian signage by the river in Kota Tua (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 4.4 Pedestrian signage near the maritime museum, with Luar Batang on the left, separated by a canal (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 4.5 Same signage as the previous figure, a few months later (Source: Halimah, 2024)

This mismatch between territorial delineation and spatial practices of different actors in Kota Tua not only engenders unmet expectations of Kota Tua management and different perceptions amongst the public about what is considered part of Kota Tua (detikNews, 2009; Wahyuningrum, 2018), but it also points to disparities between government actors. As different jurisdictions overlap in Kota Tua, there are various types of signages (including maps, lamp posts and hand-painted murals) done by different authorities which sometimes overlap or clash. A UPK Kota Tua officer said that “there are signages, for information on directions, for this and that narrative, [at times] using English. Even then there are mistakes because that is not their field”. This comment alludes to the fact that at times government actors may have the authority in the jurisdiction to carry out tasks but not necessarily the expertise in heritage-related matters.



Figure 4.6 Traffic signage showing “Kota Tua” in front of the old Chartered Bank building (Source: Author, February 2023)



Figure 4.7 Traffic signage showing correction to “Kota Tua” next to the maritime museum (Source: Author, November 2022)



Figure 4.8 Traffic signage showing correction to “Batavia” (Source: Google maps, March 2023)

Signages also provided evidence of the temporal nature of heritage-making by government actors, which usually coincide with their term in office and electoral cycles. In different parts of northern and western Jakarta during my fieldwork, one can see traffic signs which direct to “Kota Tua”, have been corrected to “Batavia”, or what looks like a reversion to “Kota Tua”, as evident from the different background colour for the replaced word(s) such as in Figure 4.6, Figure 4.7, and Figure 4.8. A brown background is usually used for tourist locations or areas, though in these cases the signages are not consistent (PM Perhubungan RI No 13 (2024)). These remnants are from the discourses of the previous administration. The previous elected governor, Anies Baswedan, received polarised responses from the public when he officially launched “Batavia” for the Old Town’s renaming in September 2022 after prolonged revitalisation works. Some approved of his idea of engaging with the past by reclaiming the narrative, while others criticised him for glorifying colonial times. He had explained that “the name Batavia mirrors the past, but its concept reflects the future modern city. That is what is being built here.”²⁸ The traffic signs remain as witnesses to the spatial and temporal regimes within which Kota Tua is bound.

²⁸ Author’s translation from his direct quote in a news article: “*Namanya Batavia mencerminkan masa lalu, tapi konsepnya mencerminkan kota modern masa depan. Itu yang sedang dibangun di tempat ini.*” “Alasan Anies Baswedan Ganti Nama Kota Tua Jadi Batavia”: <https://www.cnnindonesia.com/nasional/20220911083621-20-846148/alasan-anies-baswedan-ganti-nama-kota-tua-jadi-batavia>. (Last accessed January 2024).

On using colonial references, a parallel “Batavia” development has become a popular attraction since its official opening in 2023. Batavia PIK (Pantai Indah Kapuk), “a floating city”, is a private mixed-use development boasting plenty of public space on reclaimed land in North Jakarta. Its thematic development draws on historical and cultural heritage elements from the city during the Dutch colonial times. This is done using phrases such as “Queen of the East” and “Venice of the Orient”, and colonial artefacts such as the colonial Dutch soldier in Figure 4.9, and a colonial map in Figure 4.10.²⁹ The private sector’s reproduction of Kota Tua’s colonial landmarks and characteristics gives a strong indication of the parts of the Old Town’s heritage which have commercial and popular appeal, targeted at certain segments of the population such as the middle class, youth, and foreign tourists.



Figure 4.9 Statue of a soldier in colonial Dutch military uniform, Batavia PIK (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 4.10 Poster with background of an old colonial map of Jakarta, Batavia PIK (Source: Author, 2023)

Batavia PIK makes for an important reflection on the construction and use of heritage – for whom, by whom, and to what end. North Jakartan residents have mixed reactions towards

²⁹ The introduction video played at Batavia PIK’s grand opening in June 2023. Available from “Journey to the Past at Batavia PIK”, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YeEgmi4rJ1U> (Last accessed 26 November 2023). Quotations from the video are mainly originally in English, save a few Indonesian expressions.

PIK's existence in their backyard. On one hand, it is included in the same jurisdiction as many low-income kampungs and housing while their voices were excluded in the decision-making and impacts of land reclamation. On the other hand, while North Jakartan residents find it hard to identify with an area promoting commodified heritage and conspicuous consumption of homogenised 'global city' offerings, they highlight the experience of "like being overseas", presumably away from the protracted problems and challenges of the current Jakarta city such as flooding and pollution. Batavia PIK, for the moment at least, demonstrates the neoliberal possibilities of reproducing colonial and nationalist heritage by the private sector outside the spatial and temporal constraints as well as the overlapping jurisdictions that beleaguer Kota Tua, as seen from the example of signages. While the use of signages in top-down constructions reveal the various spatio-temporal and political regimes which sometimes overlap or conflict with each other, the discourses employed by authorities in Kota Tua attempt to demonstrate at once its uniqueness to gain international recognition, and conformity to postcolonial 'old town' templates to gain comparability.

4.2.2 Discourses

One of the paradoxes of Kota Tua is the unifying and internationalising discourses which at times blur its particularities and uniqueness that are essential to heritage claims, and at times reproduces colonial narratives. The different zones and areas of Kota Tua have been expressed as a geographical and historical unity, with each having its own contributing characteristic in trade and culture. A former UPK Kota Tua officer explained that the idea behind the "Old Town Integrated Development" during his term was to develop each of the five zones (which included the nearby kampungs) into a "tourist attraction" (*objek wisata*) according to its characteristics, whether it was historical or religious tourism. He said:

By studying the tourists we invite, we will adjust the 'menu' accordingly. For instance if it's a Chinese person, don't make the mistake of taking them to Pekojan, which is an area of mosques and religious places. But don't do the opposite as well in bringing Muslims to Chinatown... For general tourism, we can bring and tell about the history of Fatahillah Square, the museums or Sunda Kelapa harbour.

While part of the intention was thematic by bringing out the uniqueness or selling point of each area, and being sensitive to ways of life of local residents, it reinforces rigid understandings and boundaries of communities as well as visitors. The more ‘ethnic’ areas get categorised as mono-religious and cultural tourism, while more ‘general’ areas get categorised as historical tourism. This approach also had overseas tourists as the main target in mind, even though domestic tourists make up the overwhelming majority of those who visit Kota Tua. The five geographical zones have since been simplified by the inner and outer city wall separation but the “integration” logic mentioned earlier remains, albeit as an ideal for now. These approaches arguably reinforce status quo dominant heritage-making anchored by colonial Dutch legacies. Most notable are the logics of ethnic segregation where the colonial pass and quarter systems dictated where constructed identity groups of non-European foreigners, the “foreign orientals”, and indigenous communities could live and move outside their designated areas (Cowherd, 2021; Leisch, 2003).

Top-down heritage-making has also been influenced by learning from elsewhere, whether from Europe or Southeast Asia, as part of internationalising its discourse. A commonly cited successful case of and inspiration for heritage preservation of its Old Town amidst urban development whether by government officers, heritage experts, or residents, is Melaka, a city in neighbouring Malaysia. Melaka, together with George Town, is part of the Historic Cities of the Straits of Malacca, inscribed into the UNESCO World Heritage List in 2008.³⁰ However little of the negative impacts of the process towards being listed with UNESCO and the aftermath (see for instance Jamaludin et al., 2021) have been raised by these key stakeholders. Therefore while Kota Tua’s first attempt at being included in the list was not successful, invested actors still harbour aspirations for its inclusion, with one government officer stating that “it was not unsuccessful, but postponed”. One of the outcomes from the nomination process has been a regrouping of various parties which have agreed (*kesepakatan*) that they would need to propose a different concept and a more collective approach which involves other Indonesian cities to increase the chance of success. Closely tied to internationalising discourse is the preservation of old (colonial) buildings.

4.2.3 Colonial buildings

³⁰ Melaka and George Town, Historic Cities of the Straits of Malacca, <https://whc.unesco.org/en/list/1223/> (Last accessed January 2024).

Common definitions which surface during interviews with residents directly involved in the heritage-making of their neighbourhoods in Kota Tua and informal conversations with other residents are the temporal and physical qualities of “heritage” as very old (often colonial) buildings and embedded history in a particular location. “Heritage” is also something that has not been developed, renovated or revitalised, paradoxically containing some element of neglect, yet at other times care of the object or place is a criteria. These views give the sense that heritage as discourse and practice is at odds with Jakarta’s rapid urbanisation that seems to have no place for old artefacts or untouched landscapes. Yet according to Salomah, a Kota Tua resident and youth leader in her 20s, heritage is Jakarta’s defining identity given its rich history spanning various kingdoms, empires, and migration pathways as a strategic port and coastal location. This is even though the association with colonial times and places remains the dominant conception of Jakarta’s heritage among the general public. This has partly to do with the type of top-down revitalisation projects taking place within the inner walls of Kota Tua where many of the colonial buildings remain in various degrees of restoration and decay.

Amongst the five types of heritage (object, building, structure, site, and area) to be protected under the national law, there is an emphasis on protecting buildings in the Old Town, despite ideological, financial, and bureaucratic challenges. When asked about the emphasis on buildings, a government officer in conservation explained that buildings are prioritised because they are at a higher risk of being destroyed by the impact of development, modernisation and human needs, as compared to museum collections whose “preservation is more guaranteed, for a longer time”. However, the focus on buildings presents challenges as many of the variegated heritage buildings in Kota Tua and its surroundings are privately owned by companies and individuals, some unknown, and they are costly to maintain (Sastramidjaja, 2014; Vermeulen, 2024). Even those buildings which became government assets after the end of Dutch colonialism are not spared from these challenges. A UPK Kota Tua officer expressed their agency’s difficulty in getting the cooperation of other state bodies, especially those which are higher up in the hierarchy and have more power, such as the military: “It is very difficult for us to tell them, ‘please help save this building’. They hate the Dutch, they say that the Dutch [buildings] do not have to be saved, they should just be demolished.” Such anti-colonial nationalist sentiments add another layer of complexity to the existing bureaucratic impediments in the emphasis to protect heritage buildings.

The focus on physical works requires a lot of funding as the materials and skills needed to repair the old buildings are costly. This gives capital an influential role to play in selecting which works are to be preserved and by whom. One government officer interviewed estimated generally that for heritage buildings, the types of paint (e.g. has to be breathable), cement, and skilled workers needed cost about at least two to three times more than for the renovation of general buildings. Former Jakarta governor Ahok was reported to have said that “a revitalization of one building [in Kota Tua] would require dozens to hundreds of billions of rupiah” (Wardhani, 2015). This is even before buying over the building from the previous owner if need be, which in one news report was estimated at Rp88 miliar (Antara News, 2019).³¹ Therefore as one government appointed heritage expert explained, there was an ongoing debate amongst heritage experts on the merits of promoting and advancing heritage recognition when financial help does not come with it, since the main objective is to confer acknowledgement. Government subsidies are available for religious buildings but not for commercial ones. Upon request government agencies could try to help secure sponsorship from elsewhere, such as from international organisations or donations, which would have their own criteria. The implication is that those who have the money, notably the private sector and foreign entities, have the power to determine the substance and success of preservation, especially considering the poorly funded and non-profit character of independent heritage-making efforts, as highlighted by several participants.

While the heritage policy is partial towards the preservation of religious buildings, various reports from participants show that even a religious building with heritage status does not have guaranteed funding for maintenance. Therefore, the status becomes more of a burden to owners and the community who have increased pressures to make money. This led to one community leader commenting that “the government has no concept when it comes to heritage; the only concept they have is ‘which entrepreneur or company is interested in which area, can we administer that?’”. These examples highlight the neoliberal tendencies in top-down and private heritage-making.

³¹ Rp1 miliar = 1,000,000,000 Indonesian Rupiah (IDR), which is about 82,000 Singapore Dollars (SGD) or 48,000 British Pounds (GBP), rounded to the nearest thousand, at the time of writing.

“Utilization” (*manfaat*) is part of the criteria to fulfil for heritage status buildings, and while some people in the government have realised that it has always been thought about in economic terms when sometimes the value of something is immaterial, they admit that finding the balance between heritage protection and economic development is difficult in Kota Tua. Even though the heritage law allows for adaptive reuse of buildings for commercial activities, there are limits to how much economic gains can be made in Kota Tua given that the majority of visitors have been domestic, from the middle- and lower-income groups. A local government officer highlighted this, saying that Kota Tua is easily the most affordable and accessible local tourist destination by the commuter line, and gave the examples of museum tickets being reduced and hotel plans thwarted because they make no business sense in the Kota Tua area, at least for now.

With a continued focus on buildings, as evident from more recent news and discussions about the government buying up property in Kota Tua, Kota Tua could be subjected to further commodification (UPK Kota Tua, 2021; Yusuf, 2019). This is partly brought about by the ‘touristification’ of sites to generate more interest and income, which is already being felt by residents and visitors alike. One Kota Tua resident lamented that “just to relieve oneself, sometimes we pay. Sometimes it costs 2000 rupiah. To expel waste we also have to pay. Want to pray, also pay. Parking, pay. Everything requires payment”. Lived experiences such as these lend evidence to the criticisms of the ongoing revitalisation efforts in Kota Tua as being too focused on facilitating pedestrians and visitors, who become easy scapegoats for poor urban management. Such efforts are undertaken without considering the negative impact for the many low-income residents who live and work in the area, many of whom were evicted or forced to move their street kiosks to a different location without prior consultation.

The communities living in and around Kota Tua are recognised as important stakeholders by the state and non-governmental organisations, but their assigned roles in heritage-making do not always reflect that. One government officer described the role of the public and residents in Kota Tua in the everyday maintenance of the area, for example, as security officers and cleaners, that would instil a sense of ownership and belonging that “when they guard here [Kota Tua], it means their care is not only based on the job but they also have passion”. However while their physical and emotional labour are needed in these roles, the implication is that they should extend it to their own living quarters.

The top-down cleaning up of Kota Tua's image in recent years conformed to the history and heritage that Kota Tua should represent in the eyes of the city government. The Old Town changed from a space which was not tourist-friendly (Mariani, 2016b), to a more sterilised, curated, and "dignified" public space, as described by a government officer, where some of the street buskers and community interest groups have been allowed to remain. However, people always found a way to persist and carry out activities which were not strictly defined as "heritage" in the dominant framings (Park, 2023). On the communities' side, several challenges persist. One heritage activist said that it was difficult to find like-minded people in the heritage scene who do not prioritise profit-making and monetising heritage, and for that reason described his organisation as "radical" because heritage activism tends to be a form of "rich people activism". While there is more awareness amongst government actors about the need to include local communities in their heritage-making efforts, initiatives continue to centre on more established or visible heritage groups, though this is mediated by the rise of social media platforms. The final section of this chapter will pick up this thread on social media and ways of heritage-making.

Following this I discuss how subaltern urbanism means subverting these dominant imaginations by being present and occupying space, often in ways which are not following the script, or by reappropriating dominant discourses for their purposes. In other words, I show how kampung residents and their advocates put forth their own heritage-making, in relation to the heritage-making by others about them simultaneously as part and not part of Kota Tua, though not without their own contradictions and unanticipated consequences. The choices of mediums form an important way to navigate, escape, overcome spatio-temporal restrictions that define dominant heritage-making in Kota Tua, and Jakarta in general.

4.3. Subaltern constructions of heritage in Kampung Luar Batang

"The threat of eviction is still high. It will not go away... Because this area [Luar Batang] is strategic. Then, I don't know how true this is, according to the Chinese, this area is the head of the dragon. There's the tail, head, body, legs of the dragon. Apparently this spot is the head."

The above quote from the point of view of a community leader and third-generation resident in the kampung illustrates the existential threat of displacement that Luar Batang perennially faces. It also acknowledges the various definitions of ‘strategic location’ or the importance of the area, not only to the majority Muslim residents, visitors, and pilgrims of the revered shrine (*keramat*) and mosque (*masjid*) at the heart of the kampung. While this perspective captures the high value of the area by virtue of its *feng-shui* (Chinese geomancy), it also gestures to a major driver of displacement in Jakarta – private property developers, the majority of which are owned by Indonesian Chinese (Kusno, 1998). This precarity generates an anxiety (Zukin, 2010) for subaltern actors whose responses manifest in various forms. One of the responses provoked by the anxiety of anticipated gentrification is heritage-making which has several distinctive characteristics in Kampung Luar Batang.

As compared to the constructions around Kota Tua, heritage definitions and discourses in the kampungs are more dynamic and fluid. The tangible-intangible discourse in part popularised by UNESCO does not reflect the everyday conversations surrounding heritage but people are aware of it and use it depending on the situation. A heritage activist in the kampung explained that usage of “tangible” and “intangible” to understand heritage is useful for educational purposes and gaining knowledge, but can be confusing, and at times “dangerous” (*bahaya*) when used in some situations. For instance, he explained that it could backfire if people, especially those with ulterior motives respond with: “why should we preserve Luar Batang if it’s intangible, let’s just evict it since it [the kampung] is intangible”. This shows a keen sense of how such labels and discourses can be used against kampung communities even if their intention was to be part of the recognised discourses of heritage, to speak the lingo of the official, formalised, heritage world.

Over time, heritage activists devise various arguments that they would use when interfacing with different state actors. For instance, using the logic of time: “I told them, this is an old kampung. A historical, cultural relict and in fact, the root of national culture is here... Shouldn’t it be maintained?... If you say this land is yours, which came first, Luar Batang or the Republic of Indonesia.” In using a temporal argument which reappropriates the priority given to chronology in dominant official heritage-making, such statements construct claims over the space, from below (the “root” as mentioned by the heritage activist).

The focus of contemporary heritage-making in Luar Batang is religious in nature, closely intertwined with the existence of the *kampung* in people's narratives. Specifically, the cultural-religious tourism (*wisata religi*) surrounding the shrine (*keramat*) and mosque (*masjid*), which are housed in one compound named the “Masjid Jami Keramat Luar Batang”, has overtaken other types of heritage-making which used to exist in the area. This development is in parallel to the changing population composition and other urban ecological pressures such as housing, pollution, flooding, and land subsidence.

There have been periodic mosque renovations and expansions in the last few decades, notably in the early 1990s and 2000s. The latest renovation was attributed to the current mosque management's request for the mosque compound to be returned to its original form. When he first joined the mosque management about two decades ago, one mosque manager said that he felt grateful because he saw that the mosque (front gate pictured in Figure 4.11) had been nicely renovated with a new design but admitted that it was before he had any understanding of heritage: “It was in fact a loss, ... after I knew about heritage and cultural heritage buildings, I felt a sense of loss but it was too late then.”



Figure 4.11 The previous gate of the mosque, before its latest renovation in 2023 (Source: Author, 2018)



Figure 4.12 The new gate of the mosque, inaugurated in February 2023 (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 4.13 The original gate of the mosque (1920-1935) (Source: Wereldmuseum Amsterdam (Photographer: G.F.J. Bley))

From an external perspective, the mosque compound as a whole is more spacious and put together as a site for pilgrims, visitors, and residents, it obscures any contestation about the development of the mosque and shrine as a heritage site between the different stakeholders.

During my fieldwork period I witnessed the mosque compound slowly transformed in parts, with the new entrance gate in Figure 4.12 being a centrepiece of the latest renovation, supposedly a replica of the original gate in Figure 4.13. The latest renovations have been lauded by residents and local leaders though some underlying issues have also surfaced. First, while proud that the latest rebuilding is based on its original form, the mosque manager expressed that “from the perspective of a heritage lover, this mosque has lost its soul [and its historical value] because it is no longer the original structure.” Preservation of the original structure would seem to be rendered more valuable than a remake. Second, the Hindu-Javanese design of the original gate in a multi-ethnic kampung where the majority of the residents are Bugis by ethnicity and Muslim by religion receives little to no special attention. Third, the sacred tomb housed within is that of Habib Husein bin Abubakar Alaydrus, an important Islamic religious figure from Hadhramaut, Yemen, who migrated to Batavia in early 18th century. The current appearance of the shrine is also quite different from the previous one. Colours were changed from natural wood structure with a green cover, said to be following Yemeni traditions, to white and “the ornament is Javanese style now, probably inspired by other shrines in Java”, as one of the Habib’s kin explained. While changes to the shrine need permission from its trustees (*mutawalli*) which is made up of the most senior members of the Habib’s kinsmen, not everyone is on board with the aesthetic changes which took place not because the shrine necessarily needed an upgrade or repair, but because of donors’ wishes. The mosque and shrine have been managed separately for some time now though the exact date this began is unknown (Puspitasari, Djunaedi, & Putra, 2012). However, representatives from both sides have expressed reservations on the recent renovations, for different reasons.

Events, particularly those with religious significance, play a significant role in the heritage repertoire of Luar Batang. This includes major commemorations for Muslims such as Prophet Muhammad’s Birthday, Eid Al Adha and Eid Al Fitr, the Habib’s annual commemoration (*haul*), regular religious as well as cultural events such as Quran recitations, classes, talks, concerts, bazaars to cater to different segments of its population (men, women, youth, and children). Organisers have a keen sense of what is appropriate for the spaces within and in front of the mosque compound (eg. Islamic arts and music), and what is not. For instance one youth leader talked of his experience of organising the Luar Batang Festival which covers “bazaars, theatre, music, poetry, dance, and standup” but steered clear of the mosque vicinity even though some people had suggested it be there. It would have made sense spatially as there is a large

parking lot. Even though there is no written restrictions on the uses of space around the mosque compound, as can be seen in ad hoc uses of the space for parking and commerce, resident organisers contribute to maintaining the sanctity of the area by deciding where and when to conduct their activities. Taken together, these events make up the heritage repertoire of Luar Batang that residents and visitors alike anticipate over the course of the year.

Events are temporal markers that are popular and historically meaningful (often mentioned in interviews as “looking for the moments” (*cari momen*) that present a predictable calendar of events in a kampung’s social life. They are also marked by spatial logics which appear only for these moments. While streams of visitors and pilgrims go in and out of the kampung daily round the clock, with different intensities, there are times when life almost comes to a standstill with massive crowds, such as during the major commemorations. During the holy month of Ramadan, there were more stalls in front of houses springing up to sell local fares, as well as some offering Ramadan specials, such as sweets and desserts. Many stalls continue to open late into the night, till the next morning when it becomes quiet again. People spread canvas sheets on the streets between their houses and gather for communal breaking of fast (*iftar*), while others gather in the mosque compounds. Events and practices such as these are heritage repertoires that create a sense of familiarity and of belonging, as well as demarcate an identity distinct from other kampungs or heritage sites.

There have been various attempts at ‘touristifying’ Luar Batang, though with different goals. Luar Batang has been one of the 12 Coastal Tourist Destinations (12 *Jalur Destinasi Wisata Pesisir*) in North Jakarta since 2011 (Puspasari, 2012). One community activist in his 50s shared about his non-governmental organisation’s (*Lembaga Swadaya Masyarakat*) efforts with the then mayor of North Jakarta in 2004 to promote 12 tourist “must visit” (*wajib dikunjungi*) spots across North Jakarta. He underscored the difference between their intention to develop (*kembangkan*) the attractions in North Jakarta, but not to commercialise (*komersial*). He pointed out that the problem with using the label “destination” (*destinasi*) was that authorities in their plans to revitalise the area focused on the mosque compound (which includes the shrine) as an object of heritage protection but overlooked the mosque-resident relations that sustain Luar Batang.

One recent traumatic period people commonly refer to is that of the governorship of Basuki Tjahaja Purnama (Ahok) from 2014 to 2017. Other than being infamous for eviction policies, supposedly to remedy perennial flooding in Jakarta, his government also had plans for Luar Batang as part of the making of a maritime tourist destination (“Port of Jakarta”). This would see most of the area, which includes the fish market, reorganised (*penertiban*), without consultation with the residents there.³² There was a “*12 jalur destinasi*” (12 destination routes) banner along the entrance to the mosque to mark its inclusion in the earlier programme which has since disappeared after the latest renovation works and new concrete walls replaced the older compound gates, but the one at the main entrance to the kampung remains. For as long as the latter banner stands, it is a temporal marker of a previous project which had actors with similar attempts to promote the kampung’s heritage but for different ends – something which Steele (2018, p. 475) differentiates as “social preservationists” versus “gentrifiers”.

The focus on religious heritage-making has left little space for heritage claims about what used to be there, whether in remnants or social memory. Woven into these claims are hidden stories about the urbanisation, social and economic development of the kampung. When Pak San mentioned that in the past there were weaving (*tenun*) and printing (*percetakan*) practices of the Bugis-Makassar community in Luar Batang, it was a eureka moment as no one had mentioned these to me until then. Pak San explained that the impetus then for introducing these traditions from Sulawesi here was economic necessity, propelled by the logic that if people’s economic situation was remedied, they might be better able to “self-organise” (*tata diri*) their built environment. However, other than the fact that improving their own livelihoods became the focus, the practices were also not passed down as people found other more profitable ways of earning a living such as providing rental accommodation to a perpetual flow of migrants and workers. Residential and economic needs and priorities to optimise space have seen the last of the Betawi model house (*rumah percontohan*) in Luar Batang in Figure 4.14 fall into disrepair (while a few similar ones were sold off or modified, according to kampung residents) with the front space used for commerce. Where before visitors on guided tours were able to walk through the house, they now only stand at the junction near the mosque while the guide shows them the house.

³² See for instance <https://www.cnnindonesia.com/nasional/20160331105716-20-120720/masjid-bersejarah-luar-batang-akan-disulap-jadi-tempat-wisata> (Last accessed January 2024); <https://www.cnnindonesia.com/nasional/20160330130011-20-120505/ahok-akan-gusur-seribu-warga-luar-batang-demi-proyek-ambisius/> (Last accessed January 2024).



Figure 4.14 Betawi-style 1990s model housing, possibly the only one left in Luar Batang (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 4.15 Part of the seawall which stands between Luar Batang and the harbour (Source: Author, 2023)

The ecological challenges that Luar Batang faces – rising sea level and the changes to the adjacent Sunda Kelapa harbour and the wider coast which has seen reclamation works – and the measures taken to mitigate them (e.g. the seawall) have also impacted on the kampung. Specifically, these challenges impact the livelihoods, traditions and practices which used to be a unique feature of Luar Batang as a multiethnic neighbourhood with many residents in the fishing or shipping industry. While sitting in the front yard of a house near the seawall, I noticed trickles of local and foreign tourists walking past us towards the wall pictured in Figure 4.15. This alley was quite a walk away from the centre of the kampung – the *masjid keramat* – so I was intrigued by what could be the attraction here.

Two Malaysian tourists exploring the area on their own said that they saw on social media that there was a boat service around here to the harbour and surrounding areas. According to a few residents, boat rides used to be a more formalised service rendered by boatmen (who were usually also fishermen) to bring tourists to tour the port area or nearby islands. But this has now become an “alternative route” as the business was moved elsewhere once the seawall was built and the waters also became more polluted and silted. Pak Adi, a boatman dealing with the tourists, talked about some practices that thus far seem to have faded into the background as boat rides departing from Luar Batang rapidly decreased. This includes facilitating the cultural and religious practices of non-Muslim visitors, such as the scattering of ashes at sea. Ecological changes impacting on tourism and the strengthened focus on religious heritage-making in the

form of buildings and traditions underscore the intrinsic role of the kampung in heritage-making.

One aspect of heritage-making which residents often spoke about, but which is easy to miss as it has become something mundane, ordinary, and normal is the “kampung” itself. The well-known uniqueness of Luar Batang is the *masjid keramat* and the heritage-making surrounding it. But as Pak San points out, the one heritage “value” (*nilai*) which has yet to be fully realised is the kampung itself even though it has been iterated countless times by various interviewees that the mosque and the kampung are a “unity” (*satu kesatuan*). Facing displacement threats with varying intensities over the last decade sharpened heritage advocates’ arguments and sentiments about the “symbiotic mutualism” between the mosque and kampung. I heard this concept used in various interviews within and outside the kampungs, to express formulations of mosque and kampung co-dependency. The inclusion of Luar Batang as a tourist destination was welcomed by residents even though they were not directly involved in the process, but “if residents are evicted, there will be no mosque to speak of” is a common refrain. Herein lies a paradox. Longtime and generational residents are concerned about the pace of arrival of newcomers which challenge the social compact within the kampung, but population growth is also needed to enliven and maintain the existence of the mosque. At the same time residents resist government plans to make Luar Batang a non-residential heritage site, holding on to the conviction that without the kampung, there will be no mosque, and vice versa.

Residents express the heritage value of the kampung in various ways. One is when they describe how the built environment matters for the preservation of cultural values. As a community leader described: “kampung is an old way of life (*peradaban kuno*) that remains. With housing complexes (*kompleks*) come a new way of life and culture. One difference between complex and kampung, is that without a detailed address, we won’t be able to find the person.” In this case, I read needing a detailed address to find someone as a metaphor for the anomie and alienation that people might otherwise experience in a housing complex, typically mid- to high-rise, which kampung residents are concerned about. It is about facing not just physical displacement pressures, but also the disruptions to a kampung social life as they know it.

Residents describe Luar Batang as mostly still a collective where there is “harmony, kinship and mutual aid” (*kerukunan, kekeluargaan, gotong royong*) from birth to death. They recognise that kampungs are still needed in the city to counter an increasingly individualistic culture which they worry would be exacerbated by more people moving into vertical housing. Vertical housing, as described by a resident, is typically where community works have been outsourced and all the facilities that one needs are at one’s disposal, as long as one has money. There is a temporal quality associated with kampung life, that people speak of a need to “return to the times like before”, but not necessarily returning to the poorer housing conditions in the past. This indicates an acknowledgement of the changing conditions in the kampung, and also their agency to deal with them. A resident from the adjacent kampung which was evicted described “relocating people is not just about moving bodies, it’s their culture (way of life).” A kampung is not merely a place fulfilling housing needs, but it is important for maintaining a meaningful life in community. As put forth in Chapter 2, gentrification results not in just physical dislocation but the potential loss of a cultural way of life that requires a particular arrangement of bodies, things, and buildings.

Besides threats of gentrification-led displacement, historical arguments and experience of exclusionary changes have shaped people’s views and imagination about whether Luar Batang is or should be part of Kota Tua. One resident in his 30s did not consider Luar Batang as part of Kota Tua because when it was first made into a settlement by the Dutch for Javanese labourers (Puspitasari, Djunaedi, Sudaryono, et al., 2012), its name was “Kampoeng Baroe” (New Village). It was only later that its name became “Luar Batang”. During the latest renovation works of the mosque compound, the mosque management put up a banner as shown in Figure 4.16 to show their appreciation to the construction company which featured an undated colonial map. The added descriptive text I translate here as: “Map during Colonial times. Mosque and Old Kampung Luar Batang. Encircled in blue, ‘Masigit Loear Batang’ before this was named Kampoeng Baroe as written in this map.” Put this way, to be related to Kota Tua means needing to trace the direct colonial thread, which people may or may not want to be part of their claims, depending on their purposes.



Figure 4.16 Appreciation banner from the mosque management to the construction company, which shows an undated colonial map linking the mosque and kampung to its previous Dutch names and delineation (Source: Author, 2023)

Older residents also tend to view Luar Batang not as part of Kota Tua, having spent most of their life within the kampung and neighbouring villages, and many did not feel much difference or impact from the revitalisations of Kota Tua over time. For residents who locate Luar Batang within Kota Tua's imaginary, they tend to express it in terms of increased barriers between the kampung and main Kota Tua from all the changes within the kampung and Kota Tua's revitalisations, how people used to be able to walk to and fro safely or even have motorist access, and that there used to be more tourists, not just pilgrims, coming to Luar Batang from Kota Tua. Subaltern heritage construction puts forth the kampung as heritage without necessarily needing to connect it to Kota Tua, though they expressed being affected by changes taking place. Hence the kampung itself as subaltern heritage is an important part of Luar Batang, which has focused on religious heritage in various forms to remain in place in the face of gentrification processes. I will now turn to the case of Pekojan.

4.4. Subaltern constructions of heritage in Kampung Pekojan

What is apparent in Pekojan over time is its longstanding multiethnic, multicultural, and multireligious community which comprises Arabs, Chinese, and various ethnic groups indigenous to Indonesia (*pribumi*). While there have been growing concerns about the increase of local and overseas Chinese migrants, residents were quick to dismiss any ill-intended narratives about inter-ethnic discord, pointing to historical and physical evidence that they have been living harmoniously alongside each other. This evidence includes the presence of old and new Chinese big and small temples, and shophouses in a neighbourhood which has been predominantly a Muslim settlement since the Dutch arrived. Vihara Padi Lapa, a Buddhist temple established in its current location since 1901 (Kurniawan et al., 2020), houses within its compounds (as seen in Figure 4.17) a memorial for a well-known Muslim saint, while the intergenerational perfume and essentials shops run by Arab families on the ground floor of the mosque in Figure 4.18 also offer incense sticks for Buddhist prayers. The same mosque is also of mixed Chinese, Portuguese and Javanese construction as seen from its floor tiles in Figure 4.19. Much of the recent concerns about newcomers stem from visible changes (such as more types of businesses and houses which stand out from previous ones³³), which I will elaborate on in the next chapter. These visible changes are perceived to disrupt the social life of the multiethnic neighbourhood. Other concerns are generated by wider politically motivated rhetoric coming from political figures, business rivals, and aggrieved residents.



Figure 4.17 Colour transitions from red to green towards the inner compound of Padi Lapa temple which has a special area to remember a Muslim saint (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 4.18 Langgar Tinggi mosque, a heritage building with ground floor shops-cum-residences (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 4.19 Mixed tiles on Langgar Tinggi steps (Source: Author, 2023)

³³ Elements such as high and strong steel gates became a feature of Chinese houses as the Chinese community has historically been targets of violence (Nas & Pratiwo, 2003).

In recent years there has been a noticeable increase in the heritage-making efforts of the Arab community, many of whom are descendants of Hadramaut migrants. Some of the current writings, posters and videos about the kampung's heritage are available online but others are mostly circulated offline within the community and personal archives. These sources tend to focus on the heritage mosques and important historical Arab male figures, sometimes with an inclusion of one or two main Chinese temples or buildings.

I read these heritage-making efforts against the anxiety about gentrification via ethnic and class displacement. This anxiety surfaced in various interviews with residents who bring up new residents and their perceived strong purchasing power given that land prices in Pekojan as part of Kota Tua are high. This is paired with a more specific anxiety amongst the Arabs (and consequently affecting Muslims of other ethnic groups) about their perceived dwindling numbers, influence, and way of life in the kampung and Kota Tua.

What has received less attention than its multiculturalism is Pekojan's political heritage. Khairuddin, a youth leader in his 20s, lamented how people nowadays are indifferent and uninterested in the rich political history of his kampung, which has slowly disappeared from everyday conversations and contemporary collective memory. As Pekojan residents are increasingly anxious about the kampung's future, heritage-making takes on more political tones, such as countering stereotypes and recentering certain narratives about its ethnic communities. For instance, a counternarrative by both Arab and non-Arab community leaders which is slowly re-emerging is of Pekojan being the centre of knowledge and birth of the country's independence fighters. Ar Raudah (sometimes spelled Raudhah or Raudoh) mosque (built circa 1770) has been called the birthplace of the first "modern Islamic education in Indonesia" under a social organisation named Jamiat Kheir in 1901. It was to meet the needs of the Muslim and Arab community and was believed to have demonstrated its anticolonial leanings (particularly against the Dutch) by offering subjects in English, rather than Dutch (Al-Masyhur, n.d.; Shahab, 2004; Usman, 2019). The organisation later faced recognition barriers and restrictions from the Dutch colonial government, which only officially recognised it in 1905. The mosque was said to be where community leaders gathered to discuss its formation which later seeded national independence movements (Usman, 2019). Community and

religious leaders in Pekojan continue to make Islamic education a priority, while steering clear of overt political activities.

Heritage-making in Pekojan evokes what once used to be there, which is an expected function of heritage-making in a changing context. Here heritage requires that people keep alive practices and knowledge passed down over the years. What Pekojan is known for is its myriad of old houses of worship and vernacular houses that continue to stand the test of time, yet as Khairuddin expressed, what is missing in Pekojan is the answer to “what is there to see?” that visitors tend to ask. Reminiscent of the current mainstream heritage landscape, this expresses a need for some sort of predictable itinerary which boasts culinary offerings, historic places, and traditional businesses, with the objective of guiding visitors on what to do and see when they come to Pekojan, in order to experience and appreciate it as a historic kampung. The nostalgia reflects the embedded anxiety about original inhabitants moving out due to various reasons such as economic and inheritance issues and taking with them the embodied and practiced heritage (e.g. selling uniquely Pekojan cuisine). Therefore there is a desire to resume some of these traditions, partly for themselves, partly for visitors. This builds on Zukin’s (2010) argument about how one’s definition and pursuit of authenticity is tied to one’s anxiety about change.

With the number of generational residents decreasing, particularly from the Arab community, it is noteworthy that the name “Kampung Arab Pekojan” is being repopularised in public discourse, whether by the kampung residents, or Kota Tua authorities to frame it as a ‘Muslim’ destination, among others. The inclusion of ‘Arab’ in the name can be read as re-centering the Arabs of Pekojan as having important influence at a time when their numbers are dwindling due to outmigration of Arabs, and new in-migration of non-Arabs. It is also reminiscent of the Dutch colonial segregation system (*wijkenstelsel*) which divided people into ethnic quarters (Ellisa, 2007). However, it is more than just about the Arab identity, as it brings together ethnicity, religion and residential concerns in complex ways that I will elaborate on in the next two chapters. When viewed in this manner, the re-emphasis on labels juxtaposes the Arab community with the migrant community who were there before them, the Indians, whose influence and legacies have almost disappeared in the public sphere except in name (Syahid et al., 2020). This is seen in ‘Pekojan’ where ‘Koja’ refers to Muslims of Indian origins who are sometimes referred to in everyday conversation as Moors (Kurniawan et al., 2020). People are

also reminded of them by the first two mosques built in the kampung (which have undergone significant transformation) even though there is very little public knowledge about their histories and descendants.

As Pekojan residents work to maintain a representative repertoire of their culture, there is at times a conflict between wanting to showcase or explain to outsiders what Pekojan traditions were like, and to acknowledge that change due to adaptation with local conditions is also part of their culture. Youth leader Khairuddin agreed with other residents' suggestions that there needed to be a reintroduction of Arab cuisine in the kampung because it would be something unique which is attractive to visitors, since its name is "Kampung Arab Pekojan". However, he later commented that locals may not always enjoy or partake in the unique foods from the Arab world. This outward orientation is reinforced when speaking to Ibu Yu, a Chinese woman in her 70s, who is the de facto manager in-charge of an old temple there after her husband's passing. She said that they rely on visitors for donations to maintain the temple, most of whom come from outside the neighbourhood, whilst the locals around the area "are not diligent" in coming to the temple. Therefore any approach towards heritage-making needs to consider who keeps the heritage alive. In many cases it is the visitors and tourists for whom 'heritage' is something codified, static, and dated whose donations help keep heritage live, while those on the inside living with heritage have to always deal with change.

In relation to Kota Tua, Pekojan is closer geographically than Luar Batang is, and has more recognised heritage features in terms of heritage buildings, traditions, and stories. The current project to recentre the 'Arab' in "Kampung Arab Pekojan" from various heritage actors within Pekojan seems to go along with this neat packaging of the neighbourhood promoted by both Kota Tua authorities and heritage groups, though for different reasons. While the community historian has made it clear that Pekojan has historically, economically and politically been part of Kota Tua, together with Chinatown (Pecinan) and the coastal kampungs (Pesisir), the linkages between Pekojan and Kota Tua in recent times have waned. He had encouraged youth groups and local residents to be at the forefront of bringing visitors to the kampung to reclaim the relation to Kota Tua. Thus far what he has seen is outsiders bringing visitors around when he thinks it should be their own residents doing so, something which he sees as a "great loss", not least economically. Post-Covid 19 pandemic in early 2023 saw the Kota Tua Management Unit (UPK Kota Tua) start a new slate of free guided walking tours in the different parts of

Kota Tua, including for Pekojan, named “*Susur Kampung Arab Pekojan*” (Retracing Kampung Arab Pekojan).³⁴ When I inquired about the involvement of Pekojan in this, a former neighbourhood leader said that this was something organised amongst the “heritage groups in Kota Tua” and not with communities within Pekojan, though they may be involved in welcoming visitors. Therefore, certain versions of Pekojan are included within the official and popular imaginations of Kota Tua, but its people are not actively included.

There are, however, subaltern attempts to reappropriate the Kota Tua narrative. In Pekojan, there are various instances of heritage-making from below, in part due to more dispersed sites, groups, and individuals involved than in Luar Batang. There are renewed anxieties about the loss of identity and diminishing influence of the longtime communities in the economic and social life of the neighbourhood. These anxieties have resulted from the outmigration of Arabs, the in-migration of new residents, and the spatial changes taking place, as more residential areas turned into commercial and storage facilities with increasing land prices. The local Chinese population also faces multifaceted pressures, with efforts to resurface their buried histories and heritage potentially eclipsed by the increasing focus on Arab and Muslim heritage-making, and by new Chinese migrants who are perceived as being different from them by virtue of their language, norms, and origins.

This is against the wider backdrop of general perceptions about growing Chinese influence with the beginning of China’s Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) in 2013 which brought more new Chinese migrants and companies to Indonesia (Suryadinata, 2020), and the various forms of displacement local populations experience. Although longtime non-Chinese residents in Pekojan are discerning about such complex dynamics in deeper discussions, it has become a familiar trope by “indigenous middle class” and “underclass” Indonesians for the Chinese community to be called to account for the various socio-economic issues and uninvited changes taking place in their neighbourhoods and beyond, stemming from “the long history of the society’s resentment of the Chinese” (Kusno, 2000, pp. 158–159). As an Arab resident acknowledged, “the local Chinese residents become victims (*korban*)” as they face pressures from various directions amid urban change and unresolved historical injustices. As a

³⁴ The videos and posts on its Instagram account has become much more coordinated, thematic, and bilingual with English being the first language to appear followed by Indonesian since June 2023 (as compared to mainly Indonesian content or occasional use of English prior to that).

community, Pekojan is at a crossroads and has the potential to be the bridge between new and old, familiar and foreign. Heritage-making is an avenue in which these dynamics can be observed and acted upon, either to unite the community around a common project or create further divisions.

Much of the heritage-making from below in Pekojan takes shape through incremental and piecemeal improvements to heritage buildings and the slow work of forming heritage advocacy and awareness. Pekojan has several old mosques, temples, houses and other buildings spanning mid-18th to early 19th century which are considered as heritage (*peninggalan*) by residents, though not all have the official heritage status (*cagar budaya*). A few residents commented on how the local or national government bodies usually only get involved or visit once things take off, or when regulations are flouted. Amongst the places of worship, care for heritage buildings is mostly from ground-up efforts, which means that they have a significant influence on heritage-making practices, and this is where dominant or alternative imaginations can be observed.

Many visitors who had visited Langgar Tinggi mosque (as seen in Figure 4.18) before its most recent renovations commented that they felt sad to see an officially recognised heritage building poorly maintained and under-utilised as a prayer hall. A heritage activist from another kampung said that government agencies have been missing in action when it comes to heritage protection in kampungs, citing the example of Langgar Tinggi. He added that “it was in a saddening condition. I gathered our friends and some funds to slowly spruce up the space until it was a bit more presentable, even though not yet great.” As a heritage building, Langgar Tinggi is an exemplary case because it represents the multifaceted nature of buildings which have various functions, and not just for aesthetics. Typically heritage buildings are not used for residential purposes, as seen in the dominant heritage-making logics predicated on erasing people from the frame as discussed in Chapter 2. Even as a place of worship, it is quite unusual for it to provide almost permanent housing for residents, given its history as a rest stop and temporary shelter for traders. On the ground floor which is now lower than the road level which was raised for flood mitigation (Achmad & Kurniawan, 2021), residents living there are at least third-generation descendants of those who were first given temporary housing during difficult circumstances, aided by informal arrangements due to family ties. Two of the residents have family business shopfronts selling perfumes and other paraphernalia. Its various functions as a

heritage building, place of worship, housing and commerce, and on *waqf* land (Islamic endowment) present a complex social, political and economic situation that translates into competing constructions and focus of heritage-making that impact on housing security.

Heritage is continuously made and unmade by people living in and around it, in their bid to maintain the functions and value of the building, which may be in conflict. A few residents of Langgar Tinggi expressed awareness about how they may need to increasingly adhere to the heritage building regulations, because they had the impression that it is going to be like a “museum” once there was increased effort to uplift the mosque compound. This reflects the dominant viewpoint and practice about heritage buildings, as seen earlier in this chapter.

While displacement via gentrification has been mediated thus far by *waqf* and family ties, there are underlying tensions as the neighbourhood leader who is part of the family finds it challenging to enforce certain standards that befit a heritage mosque, as urged by concerned kampung residents and external allies. Such efforts would include contributing to bills and upkeep of building, refraining from using the public area as a storage or laundry area, and livening up the area by using the prayer hall for the five daily prayers. When asked about who pays for the electricity, one resident had assumed that it was all taken care of by the leader since he was in charge. Any suggestion of reclaiming the space for wider community needs, such as opening a kindergarten, triggers fears of displacement among residents of the mosque building. The fear of being displaced has placed some pressure on the generational residents living in the mosque to keep up with its heritage requirements.

The case of Al Anshor mosque departs from Langgar Tinggi in that the housing and survival practices of mostly poor residents and the lack of timely support from the relevant authorities have adversely impacted on the physical qualities of the building which has thus far facilitated generations to remain in situ. Al Anshor is claimed to be the oldest mosque in West Jakarta and particularly important as a legacy from the first Indian Muslim migrants (Syahid et al., 2020). It went through an almost total transformation due to community-driven renovations done to respond to the growing needs of the expanding population as well as mitigating severe flooding and collapsing structures, with very little help or monitoring from the government or heritage experts. To this day, not much information is available about the founders of the mosque and people did not seem too concerned about that in various interviews and informal conversations.

Perhaps such information, if widely known, may complicate matters in terms of land ownership and its current uses in prime real estate, as densely self-built housing has closed in on the mosque, partially captured in Figure 4.20, rendering the one-storey building in its distinctive Moorish architecture, as pictured on a prayer booklet in Figure 4.21, hidden and unrecognisable.



Figure 4.20 Main path to Al Anshor now, with residential buildings all around (Source: Author, 2023)

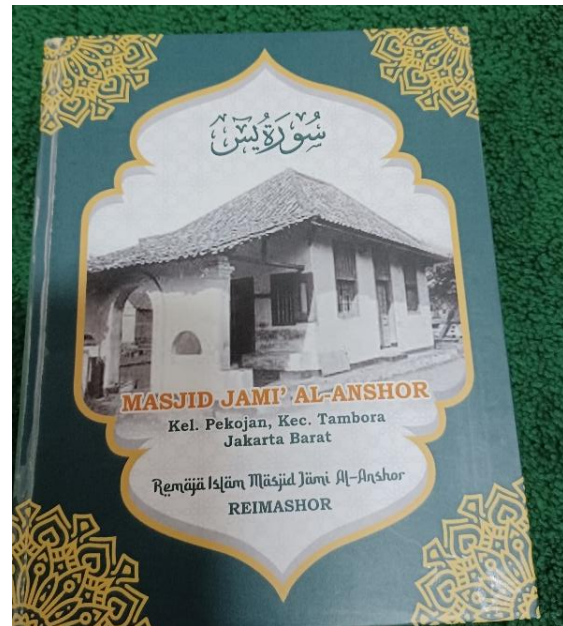


Figure 4.21 A photograph of the original Al Anshor mosque on the book cover designed by the mosque's youth group (Source: Author, 2023)

The Jami' Kampung Baru mosque, the second oldest mosque in Pekojan, was also built by the Kojas, and was officially recognised as a heritage building in 1988 (Kemendikbudristek n.d.). The role of symbolic objects in the community's heritage-making is central in this case, especially as it has undergone significant renovations. The renovations which took place during my fieldwork were supported and carried out by the Pekojan community including noted contributions from non-Muslim residents. The renovations focused on the current functions of the mosque and its congregants' needs, while being bounded to heritage protection regulations which some have argued have been contravened.³⁵ Inside the main hall, just under the roof,

³⁵ The contested process has been well-documented by other authors such as Syahid et al. (2020).

there remains a sculpture of a bunch of grapes as seen in Figure 4.22, which was said to be one of the few remnants from the original building. Neither the residents nor the various other researchers documenting the mosque knew the symbolism or the origins of the grape sculpture, but the story that this artifact has been preserved over generations since its founding continues to be retold.

The other important remnant from the original building, a beautifully carved wooden pulpit, is currently housed in the Jakarta History Museum in the Old Town (see Figure 4.23), effectively as a national treasure. The neighbourhood leader involved in the mosque works mentioned it was a gift from the then Sultan of Kalimantan, while the information in the museum stated the “2.5 centuries old podium” was bought over in 1939 by “*Batavia Genootschap*, (now *Museum Nasional*) and the sale revenue was used to renovate [sic] Kampung Baru Mosque” (see Figure 4.24). He elaborated that the community had suggested that it be returned to them so that the object is preserved and used in its context, given that the mosque has the heritage status but this has been so far unsuccessful.

This case highlights the conflicting standards of heritage protection regulations where communities are expected to preserve the authenticity of a heritage site but for conservation reasons, the government can decide to alter the site. At the same time, because of the renovations to accommodate current needs for more space and flood mitigation, the original pulpit or even a replica (as suggested by a local government officer from Kota Tua) could not fit in the new arrangement without upsetting certain Islamic rulings about the order of spaces, according to a religious teacher in Pekojan. This case showed the historical, political, religious, and spatial ambiguities and complexities under which heritage-making surrounding symbolic objects takes place.



Figure 4.22 Bunch of grapes sculpture under the roof of the main prayer hall (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 4.23 Original pulpit housed in the Jakarta History Museum (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 4.24 Information about the pulpit in the Jakarta History Museum, near its base (Source: Author, 2023)

To create a central reference point for the various heritage, history, and cultural elements of Pekojan, a community historian decided to revamp a site under the main flyover into the kampung as a heritage and literacy centre. There were supposedly other plans for the space, in collaboration with various constituencies beyond Pekojan but according to a few sources, the collaboration fell through due to lack of funding and cooperation amongst the various parties that the local government leader could not resolve. The site housed an early childhood education centre (PAUD) previously but it was moved to a nearby site for safety reasons. The community historian described the site as a “work in progress”, as evident from the incremental stages of construction with bits added over time, as seen in Figure 4.25. He insisted that it should be community and donor-funded, not by the government with whom he had “lost hope” because they are “NATO – No Action, Talk Only”. He also wanted the community to have a sense of ownership over something they built collectively. He was inspired by other communities in Indonesia where they had reading corners in unexpected places like under bridges and toll roads.

In the meantime, the space was already serving one of its functions as a multipurpose community area, with youth groups often playing football there, at a time when such recreational spaces are increasingly rare in Jakarta where land usage is always being economically maximised. The site itself is arguably a case of reclaiming city space from inadequacies of urban planning and development, as building and architecture experts have

wondered how it was possible and permissible to build under a flyover. The building roof has the grasshopper teeth (*gigi balang*) motif (see Figure 4.26), which is traditionally attributed to the Betawi (ethnic group native to Jakarta). This is a symbolic choice that attempts to not only bring together the multicultural community of Pekojan, but also to cast a physical stake which centres the belonging of the kampung to Jakarta, as residents of the city. While there are currently no plans to seek official heritage status for the building-in-progress, it represents heritage-making for the future of the kampung.



Figure 4.25 Heritage and cultural literacy centre building in progress (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 4.26 Betawi style ornament added to the roof (Source: Author, 2023)

More than just the unique building typologies in Pekojan, heritage-making in this kampung is anchored in a strong sense of community and collective memory through annual flagship events and the associated Hadrami-influenced traditions that people over generations attempt to continue. These generate a momentum that carries Pekojan through the urban changes taking place. *Nasi Kebuli* (a rice dish cooked with spices), *Kue Kaak* (spiced cookies), and *Kopi Jahe* (ginger coffee) are some of the uniquely localised Arab (sometimes labelled Betawi) traditions enjoyed in such events and social gatherings. Even hotel cooks have been reported to be learning how to make a special porridge from the kampung before it fades into obscurity (Sakina, 2023).

Keeping these traditions going is increasingly challenging as population and spatial changes taking place inadvertently alter community composition and priorities. Khairuddin, a youth leader born and raised in Pekojan, lamented how their kampung culture and traditions of “care, mutual aid, and camaraderie” (*kepedulian, gotong royong, silaturahmi*) have been adversely impacted by outflows of original residents which have diminished local population numbers.

Yet, contrary to the popular view among participants that kampungs would prevail in Jakarta, Khairuddin proposes for the preservation of his kampung through the documentation of its culture and history in the form of a “cultural village” (*Kampung Budaya*). He believes that kampungs will likely disappear with the rapid commercial development taking place all around, including the ongoing Mass Rapid Transit (MRT) construction. Through the “cultural village” model, he hoped that Pekojan as an urban village in the city with historic value would be included in the *Program Wajib Kunjung* (Must-Visit Programme), run by Ministry of Culture for each region targeting school students, just like the Betawi Cultural Village in South Jakarta. While the kampung as a physical mode of socio-spatial organisation as people know it might eventually cease to exist, at least its heritage value is preserved through the “cultural village” model. It is a step which seeks to secure the heritage of the kampung even if the community is slowly disappearing, showing the impact of gentrification processes.

4.5 Ways of heritage-making in Kota Tua

Returning to the ways of heritage-making, looking at the methods used allows more insight into the processes of knowledge production of the various heritage projects in Kota Tua. Aside from heritage-making which focuses on various types of tangible signages, maps, and historical documents, what is also characteristic about heritage-making in Kota Tua is storytelling (*cerita*). When asked how people come to know, remember, and spread knowledge, “*cerita*” is a common answer.

In Luar Batang, there are two aspects of heritage-making through stories which are not as easily categorised, defy conventional spatio-temporal dynamics, and generate its own source of power. “*Mistis*” or the mystical appears in everyday conversations as a medium for storytelling and narratives. It is the unknowable, the unexplainable, the sacrosanct which has its own intrigue and power. “*Mistis*” has been used to describe the stories, legends, and mythologies that people disseminate about certain places which attract believers and curious visitors – making it a part of oral traditions. Though sometimes their historical authenticity is doubted, this ‘intangible’ heritage plays an important role in various realms of a society which is still highly spiritual. Political and religious leaders are often spotted paying a visit to the *keramat* for prayers and blessings around critical junctures such as elections, with the mosque management stipulating that such visits must be in personal and not political capacities (Aditra,

2024; P, 2023). In times of turmoil such as facing displacement under urban redevelopment plans, various stories were heard about the apparitions and unseen role of the Habib in protecting the kampung (see Sevea, 2022, p. 83). Hence the *mistis* plays an important role in claims to space in the context of Indonesian society which still places importance on the spiritual.

Narratives and storytelling often feature a *tokoh* (a community leader or an authoritative figure) as a source for legitimising certain versions over others, especially when there are ambiguous or conflicting details or claims. “A *tokoh* is born out of the times”, said a community leader in Luar Batang, with the times referring to important historical events or incidents and having lived through these, one has authority to speak on them. Neither the level of education nor official position guarantees *tokoh* status which is usually an informal position, indicating a distinction between power and authority. As he explains, “For example, if A becomes a member of parliament, mayor, governor, he may or may not be a *tokoh*. It means, whenever people hear my name, they panic. Meaning, my name has value, a value which makes people nervous.” Comparing a *tokoh* like himself to technologies, he attributed his abilities to reason and argue to God’s will for which he is only a medium: “I am like the radio, whichever expensive or cheap radio you use, the voice that comes out isn’t it the same? Yes, right? Only that one sounds nice, the other hurts the ear. If you buy the cheapest China-made TV or the most expensive one to watch boxing or football, it’s the same.” While saying that he may not be the most refined medium for the message, embedded in his statement is a critique of the role of money and status in politics and heritage-making as he claimed neither, but others have recognised him as a *tokoh*. In Chapter 6, I will return to this statement which gives rise to questions about the challenges posed by this source and how its role and form need to evolve when contexts change.

Just as in Luar Batang, narratives and stories passed down through generations play a central role in the heritage-making of Pekojan. Much value is placed in being able to trace a trusted source of the story (*cerita*) directly from one generation to the next, as people often said, “I heard this *cerita* directly from my father/mother/teacher”. However a mosque leader mentioned that nowadays there are similar stories being shared online because the tendency to “copy” each other’s stories to increase attention and connections to a place have become easier, and there is still little by way of validating the truth given the paucity of records. One example he mentioned was about An Nawier mosque having to slightly alter its prayer direction (*kiblat*)

mid-construction of the last expansion in 1800s when they were informed by a famous visiting Islamic scholar that the orientation was off. This is why today when one is inside the mosque, the lines on the marble floor are slanted instead of being perpendicular to the doors, as shown in Figure 4.27. He said as far as he knew, this had only happened in An Nawier with records as proof, but after that he heard that other mosques also claimed something similar.

Caretakers of other religious buildings such as Pak Is and Ibu Yu, in their 60s and 70s respectively, had a slightly different take on online searches. They were readily suggesting that I “go on YouTube” to look up more historical details or photographs, some of which were also the product of their participation in helping to document and share their knowledge. They shared the same enthusiasm as Khairuddin who had initially thought of doing an in-person neighbourhood tour “*Jejak Pekojan*” (Pekojan Trail) but switched to planning for a short video documentary instead. Using digital technology and social media in heritage-making can increase outreach, such as through screenings at community events and mass sharing in group chats and online platforms which are global in reach and documenting the contemporary moment. However, this approach misses the embodied process of walking through and interacting with the neighbourhood, and directly experiencing its sometimes unexpected sights, sounds, and smells.

In relation to this, there is an attempt at a renewal of cultural goods and experience as part of its heritage-making in Pekojan. A kampung may provide a spectrum of sensory experiences by which residents and visitors alike know it. One all-year-round particularity in Pekojan is the smell, sounds, and sight of goats in the centre near the “goat bridge” (*jembatan kambing*) as locals refer to it, which goes over the Krukut river. In wanting to reclaim the sights and smells from before, to renew and expand a culinary heritage of Pekojan, Ustaz, a mosque leader and fifth-generation resident, talked about plans to open a food stall by the side of the main mosque, which came to fruition towards the end of my fieldwork, as seen from an illustrated menu in Figure 4.28. He had expressed concern about how the sensory elements of heritage, such as the taste and smell of their signature cuisines such *sop kambing* (mutton soup) and *sate* (skewered meat) were missing from everyday life in their neighbourhood which has been known for goat trading. The idea was also to provide free food after every Friday prayer, and to generate some income for the upkeep of the mosque and the surrounding community, in keeping with obligations to fulfil being on *waqf* (endowed) land. There were already a few *sate* and *sop*

kambing stalls spread throughout the neighbourhood, but there was none in the vicinity of the main mosque, the goat bridge, and the Arab community living there. Therefore, thus far, the efforts to preserve a living heritage which is people- and place-based (crucial against gentrification-led displacement) are evident through the methods of heritage-making in these two kampungs, though they are not without their challenges.

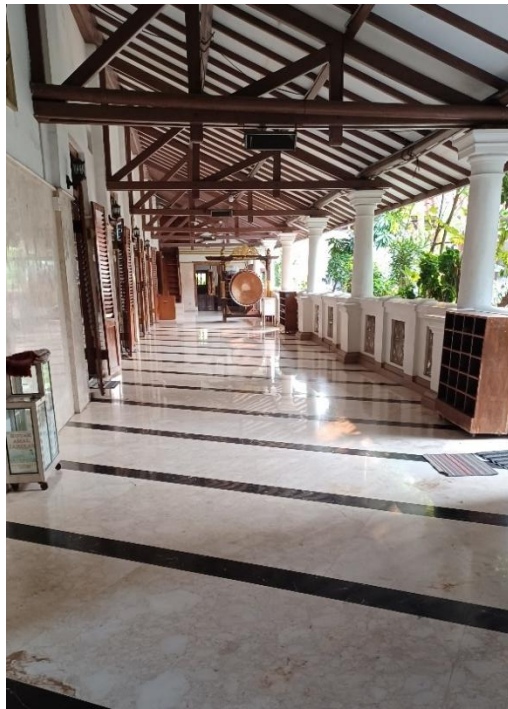


Figure 4.27 The floor of An Nawier mosque is slanted, due to recalibration of its orientation to the Kaaba in Mecca (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 4.28 Hanging menu in newly opened food stall (waroeng – Old Dutch spelling of warung) (Source: Author, 2023)

As alluded to in earlier sections, with the increasing usage of social media, the ways that people (can) tell their stories have changed, which also shape the stories they tell. The proliferation of smartphones and social media platforms (e.g. Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, Spotify) has accelerated content creation practices which centre visual and auditory forms (e.g. short and instant videos, livestreaming, podcasts). These kinds of content creation have become a staple medium for individuals and groups who engage in heritage-making. It is the base upon which they self-evaluate their effectiveness and are appraised for opportunities and funding by the number of followers they have and the online engagement they generate. No event, ranging from cultural, political to religious, is complete without the use of such platforms. Digital technologies and social media platforms have been used by government actors to capture the public(s)'s imagination, such as the Ministry of Tourism and UPK Kota Tua's Instagram

accounts, but they also are critical in empowering and democratising non-elite heritage-making.

The importance and ubiquity of social media was apparent when I witnessed how a government representative from the sub-office (*sukudinas*) of the Ministry of Tourism was exhorting participants (including secondary school students, small business owners, content creators, community groups) to boost content of the tourist spots on social media during a day-long tour around various tourist sites in North Jakarta, in order to influence the algorithm (see Faisal, 2023). The event impressed on some participants that image and form are prioritised over substance, as the photo ops at each site visit took place without much explanation of its significance, as was the case for the usage of terms in English such as “littoral tourism” as part of the branding. The contrast was a sight to behold – a motley group occupying the otherwise sanitised and aestheticised spaces of globalised offerings (e.g. famous Singapore restaurants, and a golf island named Hyde Park, also the name of a famous park in London) and property billboards. The tour’s inclusion of the recently completed ‘instagrammable’ Pantjoran PIK, a recreation of Chinatown promoting culinary tourism, on reclaimed land as part of North Jakarta tourism was noteworthy, given the abovementioned apprehension of North Jakartan residents about the inclusion of the reclaimed developments into their district. At the same time, online content feeds into attempts to represent North Jakarta as a modern and affluent urban area (Arshad, 2023).

I observed one “Photo hunting” activity of Pokdarwis (Tourism Awareness Group) youth members, where they took photographs and made videos of the maritime museum and Sunda Kelapa port to generate interest online to translate that into offline interest to visit, as well as to boost their newfound status as a collective. This was one of their early attempts at online tourism promotion after their proposals to various levels of local government were approved but without guidance or resources provided to implement their plans to promote local tourism. A few days later, one of the members had asked me to translate an online message in English to Indonesian which she received from someone who was offering thousands of new followers to increase her social media presence in exchange for a sum of money following one of the Instagram posts on the port. While she initially expressed interest in using this service to boost the group’s social media presence, she decided against it after discussing how dubious the solicitor was. With content creation on social media platforms being increasingly motivated by

numbers and algorithms, these mediums can help democratise heritage-making but also further entrench the status quo of disproportionate top-down approaches.

Having more followers and views for the sake of numbers, a common feature of social media usage, raises the need to consider how people use such platforms for heritage-making and its impact on the ground, as on other existing mediums such as books. One kampung resident who is active in filmmaking said that “the easiest medium to absorb is film or video. Because I know the culture in Indonesia...when I was doing my research in 2010, around 80 percent of Indonesians were lazy to read. Maybe now it has reached 100 percent.” Here the participant expresses their opinion about the detrimental impact of the widespread use of digital technologies and social media platforms on reading as a mode of consumption in Indonesia.

Yet contrary to the general pessimism about reading habits in Indonesia due to poor literacy levels according to international and national metrics (Antara News, 2024b; Wijayanti, 2020), there are some efforts to continue producing and promoting books from the kampungs and their advocates. One heritage advocate expressed how their efforts in writing books is to raise awareness and “rally enthusiasm”, by giving an enduring and respected platform to the stories of “past struggles and local wisdom”, and “not just about buildings and architectural features on which much has been written”. For such advocates, social media platforms are important but so are ‘older’ technologies of knowledge production and dissemination such as books especially by local communities.

Given that oral tradition has been the main way of transmitting knowledge and culture in these communities, the renewed interest in books and the written word amongst heritage activists is noteworthy. Books can be an important intellectual marker of an individual or community, to destabilise or reappropriate dominant heritage discourses of more powerful actors with a respected and time-tested knowledge product. Based on observing community meetings and insights from various interviews, journal articles, news, and social media posts thus far produced about kampungs in Kota Tua, the lack of involvement of local communities in producing knowledge about their own neighbourhoods is notable. However, of late there is a growing awareness amongst kampung and allied heritage activists of the need for more research and documentation to strengthen kampung narratives against displacement, judging from various responses from heritage actors in Kota Tua.

Yet, just like oral traditions, there are embedded inequalities in such knowledge production for heritage-making. For instance, there is acknowledgement from various heritage actors, sometimes begrudgingly, that external pressure on the authorities tends to be more effective in getting them to pay attention to local issues. Outsiders who are “from modern, developed countries with wider access to information and resources”, according to a kampung activist, also play a role because of the socially embedded “colonised mentality” which requires foreign intervention and valuation in order to realise the “worth of their own backyard”. The intention here is not to put outsiders on a pedestal, but as resources to draw from in an attempt to reappropriate the unequal status of knowledge producers, in this case between the local and foreign.

Documenting history and pushing for more research has also become more important for Pekojan. This is evident from recent collaborations with local universities and NGOs in Indonesia (Kurniawan et al., 2020; Syahid et al., 2020), even though the community historian lamented that the knowledge and recommendations produced have not been considered seriously by the government. But he has continued to produce or help others produce knowledge. He understood the currency of knowledge production for international organisations like UNESCO which he held in better regard as being “solutions oriented” than local organisations which are “more politicised”. Having himself prepared a book manuscript on historical events, eminent figures (*tokoh*) and important buildings in Pekojan, the role of non-Arab and non-traditional figures like the community historian is crucial to the heritage-making process as they provide a bridge within and without. When asked by an external youth group for advice on how they could overcome difficulties such as uneven attention and public knowledge about neighbourhoods around Kota Tua, he suggested that one of the first things is to get to know their own neighbourhoods better and share this knowledge with others so that people feel an attachment to and care for the neighbourhood. Learning from each other as a way to overcome urban spaces which have been fragmented whether by bureaucracy, territorial jurisdiction, social differences, is an emerging theme which I will elaborate on in the context of gentrification and displacement in the next two chapters.

4.6. Conclusion

In this chapter I delved into how different actors in Kota Tua and its kampungs construct and use heritage from above and below, in order to provide the context for the following two chapters where I examine the role of heritage-making in relation to gentrification-led displacement. Local and national authorities employ heritage-making through top-down decisions on the built environment, and unifying and internationalising discourses, though not without disparities among the different state actors who are bound by hierarchical bureaucracies and electoral cycles. The emphasis on buildings by the state and private sector has brought about not only funding issues and the commodification of Kota Tua. The colonial-capitalist heritage-making has also brought about a spatial reordering which creates sharper distinctions between those who fit with dominant understandings of heritage, and those who do not, leading to the exclusion of people, especially marginalised groups, from the imagination and use of its shared spaces, which is a form of gentrification.

On the other hand, heritage activists, community leaders, and kampung residents use heritage-making to strengthen their culture and identity in efforts to reclaim and maintain their living spaces in a city, as they increasingly face gentrification-led displacement. There are several similarities between the two kampungs in how heritage-making is employed, such as the focus on ethno-religious buildings, traditions, and stories, by occupying space and at times reappropriating dominant discourses. In doing so, heritage actors can be seen to be doing the slow work of building heritage advocacy and awareness, centering the kampung as a living heritage in the historic district of Kota Tua, each with its own dynamics and possibilities.

What both cases demonstrate is the importance of narratives and stories that people tell about themselves vis-à-vis others through various ways, which reflect how they place themselves in the city amidst threats of displacement. The cases also demonstrate people's sense of agency, belonging, and organisation, as well as existing social hierarchies and asymmetries in knowledge production. The importance and increased access to narratives and stories as a means to remain in place under uncertain conditions, as I will argue in Chapter 5, paves the way towards more democratic heritage-making which impacts on housing security vis-à-vis gentrification-led displacement.

Chapter 5. Housing and gentrification-led displacement in Luar Batang and Pekojan

5.1. Introduction

“Eviction is a form of colonialism.”³⁶

The quote above, translated from a Luar Batang resident (Qurrataa’yun, 2016), and its variations have been used by residents and activists to describe the forced displacement of kampung residents in Jakarta due to state and corporate (*kaum kapitalis*) plans.³⁷ In particular, the analogy has been used in relation to the top-down plans of DKI Jakarta government then headed by Governor Ahok to redevelop the coastal area of North Jakarta. This redevelopment project called “Port of Jakarta” included island reclamations, reported to have been inspired by the Port of Rotterdam.³⁸ Ahok said it was not intended to evict people but buildings, and residents would be moved into low-income vertical housing (*rumah susun*) in stages. This he deemed would ultimately be better for the residents in terms of access to public amenities, livelihoods, and environment because Luar Batang, as one of the kampungs in North Jakarta, is a “slum area” (*kawasan kumuh*).³⁹ In the case of Kota Tua and its kampungs, the colonial-capitalist connection echoes even louder as it is tied to top-down, profit-driven heritage-making projects by powerful actors focused on preserving colonial legacies, as explored in the preceding chapter, that impact on the lives of many marginalised residents.

To address the overarching research question of whether heritage-making of and in kampungs advances or resists gentrification-led displacement, this chapter delves into the impact of heritage-making as a process by the different actors on housing conditions, particularly housing security for kampung residents. I argue that the dominant heritage-making by the government, private sector, and residents in Kota Tua impact in varied ways on its kampungs, namely Luar

³⁶ Translated from “*Penggusuran itu sebuah bentuk penjajahan*,” quoted from the news article which attributed the expression to personnel from the Luar Batang Mosque.

³⁷ For another example, see “Rajawati veteran says eviction is a new style of colonialism,” <https://news.republika.co.id/berita/octhte335/veteran-rawajati-sebut-penggusuran-adalah-penjajahan-gaya-baru> (Last accessed: March 2024).

³⁸ “Ahok will evict a thousand residents of Luar Batang for an ambitious project,” <https://www.cnnindonesia.com/nasional/20160330130011-20-120505/ahok-akan-gusur-seribu-warga-luar-batang-demi-proyek-ambisius> (Last accessed: February 2024).

³⁹ “Ahok will evict a thousand residents of Luar Batang”.

Batang and Pekojan. The second section presents the state of housing in Kota Tua's neighbourhoods. The third and fourth section develops the argument by explaining how the struggles for heritage and housing security are at times complementary or conflicting. I delve into the immediate and gradual displacement experienced by residents and show how these impacts are countered with subaltern heritage-making of residents and their advocates as a collective process of agency, care, and organisation to reclaim their place in the city. The fifth section argues that these contentious efforts to remain in the city result in a more complex housing situation, with unanticipated consequences such as amplified precarity for some residents and social differences that affect kampung relations. Finally, while there is more attention on the place of kampungs as the city's heritage and the role of residents in Kota Tua from the state and in public discourse, the changing geographies of inequalities within and across the kampungs also become more evident. Ultimately, to the extent that these heritage-making efforts craft a future that transcends current narrow economic impulses that drive gentrification-led displacement, they hold promise for the remaking of the neighbourhood for the preservation of the kampung.

5.2. State of housing in Kota Tua's neighbourhoods

As noted in Chapter 1, various scholars and observers have argued that neoliberal urbanism is in process in Jakarta in the sense of commodified, financialised, and privatised housing, heritage, environment policies and practices (see for instance Budianta, 2019; Herlambang et al., 2018; Leitner & Sheppard, 2017). The minimum wage in Jakarta is Rp 4.5 million or around 300 USD (Siagian et al., 2023), while estimates of land price in Jakarta ranges from Rp 20 million to Rp 60 million per square metre (Elyda, 2024; Novriyadi, 2025). The property price to income ratio in Jakarta was recorded at 10.3 by the World Bank in 2019 mainly due to housing shortage, as compared to Singapore's 4.8 for instance (Elyda, 2024). Such stark figures have led various non-governmental organisations and urban poor networks to declare that there is a crisis of adequate and affordable housing in Jakarta (Sari, 2021).

There is especially acute pressure in living in this historic part of Jakarta. Neoliberal housing policies and practices enacted by the state, private sector, and elites threaten the housing security of vulnerable residents especially those in kampungs with various legal statuses who make up the "urban majority" (Colven et al., 2024, p. 3). This is coupled with political

ecological issues such as flooding, sinking, and pollution, which have largely been driven by the pursuit of state and private capitalist production of space, as seen in high-rise buildings, gated apartment complexes, malls, and ‘green spaces’ (Batubara et al., 2023; Goh, 2019). The unprecedented increase in concreted areas impede water drainage, while high-rise buildings which require extensive groundwater extraction contribute to land subsidence, resulting in worsened sinking and flooding. The increased and haphazard urban development also disrupts the ecology of Jakarta as a “swamp” (*rawa*) where some flooding is expected (Dovey et al., 2019), something which residents occasionally remarked. Amidst political shortcomings to arrest these issues, they have been used in state and private sector discourses and tactics to displace vulnerable communities. These pressures are compounded by top-down heritage-making which, as examined in Chapter 4, prioritises narrowly defined heritage preservation over residents’ concerns about displacement, particularly in housing and livelihoods.

As mentioned in the previous chapters, three kampungs were officially included in the 2015 delineation of Kota Tua for Indonesia’s bid to the UNESCO World Heritage List. While the inclusion was problematic as insufficient research, preparation or involvement of the kampung communities preceded it, the unintended outcome was a spotlight on communities and kampungs in Kota Tua. Periodic revitalisation of Kota Tua has also given the main areas various uplifts over time, even though these often run against the various uses of its spaces (e.g. itinerant street vendors, performers, mendicants, and group gatherings). These miscellaneous uses see the local authorities constantly attempting to clear and re-establish order in the main areas within their respective jurisdiction. The latest revitalisation in the past couple of years done by then Governor Anies also included a new model of participatory vertical housing (*kampung susun*) in Akuarium, Kunir, and Tongkol. The *kampung susun* idea (also known as “elevated *kampung*”) was originally a grassroots idea for alternative social housing developed by urban poor organisations in association with architects and researchers which was then adopted by the city government (Sari et al., 2022). These were built to house some of the residents who were forcibly displaced from their kampungs in earlier city redevelopment efforts, making it part of the changing face of Kota Tua (Medianti, 2023). Figure 5.1 shows one such kampung (Kunir) which boasts a slogan “*Kampungnya Kota Tua*” (Kota Tua’s kampung). Beyond these highlights, many residents interviewed during my fieldwork did not feel that Kota Tua’s evolution and revitalisation thus far have had any major impact for them in terms

of improving their housing conditions. While this was not unexpected, the impacts that come with more attention on kampungs and their heritage need to be examined.



Figure 5.1 One of the participatory vertical housing projects in Kota Tua to house some of the displaced kampung Kunir residents (Source: Author, 2023)

Although popular ideas of Kota Tua centre around tourism, colonial buildings and other legacies, and not so much about its inhabitants, the relations between residential life and conditions in Kota Tua that surface during interviews, informal interactions, and observations demonstrate a different reality – that the fate of the two are closely intertwined. For example, residents often refer to the high urban density, evictions, displacements, pollution, and traffic jams in Kota Tua which impact on their daily life, as well as the role of kampungs as spaces of social and economic reproduction that are crucial to the workings of Kota Tua. A Pekojaan resident described the congestion issues in Kota Tua:

The immediate, drastic negative impact is the congestion, especially in Kota Tua here, [it's] merciless (*ampun-ampunan*). Then the changes from people selling their buildings to become storage, warehouses and shops, are also sources of congestion because of the vehicular movement. Previously where there were no vehicles, now there are lots of vehicles. Shopee, Lazada, Blibli, all have their warehouses here, in Kota Tua.

The irony is that, he added, “Our own people are lazy to go to Jembatan Lima, or Glodok, or Asemka [popular markets nearby]. They use Shopee, sold and bought right here, in their own

kampung too.” Other than reflecting the current living conditions in the area, it demonstrates the sense that many residents have of Kota Tua being less and less of a residential urban kampung area and more for commercial activities.

The accumulated pressures resulting in loss of heritage and habitat can be seen through an example common to Luar Batang and Pekojan. The original mosque minaret, with its religious function for broadcasting the call to prayer required that no surrounding buildings be higher than the minaret, therefore acting tacitly as a spatial reference in the neighbourhood. This function has been disrupted due to the rising sea levels and frequent flooding which have led to people levelling their houses and roads, and buildings getting higher to maximise economic value. The original minaret in Luar Batang’s case looks shorter than before due to the levelled up mosque compound as seen in Figure 5.2, and is no longer accessible to people. As I will elaborate in the next section, some residents living within and around the mosque compound also had to move due to flood mitigation arrangements and mosque expansion.



Figure 5.2 The original minaret of the Luar Batang mosque in the foreground (Source: Author, 2023)

Some of the housing struggles of the low-income groups in and around Kota Tua have been documented, with the focus in recent years on high-profile evictions of kampungs along riverbanks and in contested areas (see for instance Betteridge & Webber, 2019; Siagian et al., 2023; Widyaningsih & Van den Broeck, 2021). These kampungs tend to be those which are in poorer conditions, often labelled as slums, and while multiple generations have lived there, they tend to be post-independence settlements. The fate of older pre-independence kampungs such as Luar Batang and Pekojan which have existed and evolved since the Dutch colonial period has received less attention in this respect, given that the various forms of displacement taking place in these older kampungs have been more gradual and subtle. The notion of multifaceted displacement itself is not new as recent studies have worked to recognise “different modalities of displacement”, the ways in which displacement takes place and is experienced by different parties (e.g. residents, renters, landlords, developers, brokers) (Colven et al., 2024, p. 3). Here I focus on the role and impact of heritage-making, an aspect important to both kampungs, to deepen understanding of displacement processes.

5.3. Eviction and displacement in Kota Tua in the pursuit of tourism

Eviction of residents and small businesses (UMKM - *Usaha Mikro, Kecil, dan Menengah*, which stands for micro, small, and medium-sized businesses) took place regularly according to the government’s plan to clean up the area. Figure 5.3 shows a local government poster on one of the lampposts which reads “Selling in the Kota Tua tourist area is prohibited”. However, local authorities thus far have little power to continually enforce the boundaries created and did not consult people affected beforehand to get their buy-in.⁴⁰ Groups of residents, street vendors and performers collectively resisted being planned for, in various ways, such as illegally setting up shop in nearby areas as shown in Figure 5.4 and Figure 5.5, instead of taking up allocated spaces for rent (*lokbin*) set up by the government, which they deemed as being far from the main crowds in Kota Tua.

⁴⁰ Informal conversations with residents and street vendors around Kota Tua.



Figure 5.3 Prohibition to sell in the Kota Tua tourist area (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 5.4 Street vendors set up shop along the roads just outside the inner walls of Kota Tua (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 5.5 A few street vendors set up shop just outside the fences of the Kota Tua train station (Source: Author, 2023)

As part of beautifying the city, a former UPK Kota Tua officer acknowledges that enforcing the “green space” in planning documents has led to the displacement of some residents. This can also be observed in the maritime museum area. A few remaining street vendors who also used to live in the area expressed concern that their stalls would eventually be evicted too, in tandem with the appearance of green spaces (*taman*) as part of the revitalised “heritage area”, as seen in Figure 5.6. This fits with dominant heritage-making that a ‘heritage area’ or a ‘historic site’ needs to be kept pristine and separated from residential parts (Herzfeld, 2015), as discussed in Chapter 2. This has resulted in the reordering of spaces, manifested in thematic

lampposts and signboards going up, greening of spaces, and the clearing of street life as noted in Chapter 4. For former residents like Pak De, the revitalisation of the area as part of Kota Tua heritage has meant that over time the spaces where they work and live have become separated. This makes daily life more challenging, whereas before they were in the same space usually in a semi-permanent structure made from plywood (Figure 5.7). The messiness and connectedness of living needs (housing and work) of people have to make way for the *modus operandi* of pairing heritage areas with curated pathways and green spaces.



Figure 5.6 The revitalised area around the maritime museum which boasts more greenery and cleaned up streets (Source: Author, 2022)



5 Jl. Ps. Ikan



Figure 5.7 The area outside the maritime museum used to be lined with shops and homes (Source: Google maps, Oct 2015)

In Luar Batang, flood mitigation was both a welcome and disappointing affair. One of Habib's kinsmen⁴¹ detailed the frequent occurrence and severity of floods when he was growing up in the kampung during the 1970s, and how the mosque management then negotiated with the city government:

⁴¹ I borrow Teren Sevea's (2022) usage of "kinsmen" to describe the family members of the buried saint of the Luar Batang shrine (*keramat*), Habib Hussein b. Abu Bakr b. 'Abdullah al-'Aydarus. These family members have the legitimate right to manage the shrine, as determined by religious authorities (*ulama*), as the saint did not have children and there were various claims to heirship.

In the past there were floods every afternoon. When we wake up in the morning, the water level would have sometimes reached our calves, thighs, depending on the condition of the water. It happens every day. On that basis we asked for government assistance to build (*bangun*) because we didn't have the money... He [Pak Fauzi] built it [the mosque area] on the condition that the family [of the Habib] could not live here... Why Pak Fauzi proposed something like that, it's because this would be made into a religious tourist destination (*destinasi wisata religi*).

Even though from his perspective, the Habib's family accepted the compromise to preserve the compound and moved out because of flood mitigation measures, the kinsman interviewed expressed some dissatisfaction with how the mosque compound has been altered, especially the original buildings. He deemed the alterations as counter to the purposes of making it a religious tourist destination:

I mean, where there was flooding, just fill in (*diurug*) the building, raise it, finished. There's no need to alter (*dirubah*) it, right? Since this is said to be a tourist destination, it means the buildings must be maintained (*dipertahankan*) right?

However, it was not just the buildings in the mosque compound which was the issue. Because the descendants of the Habib of Luar Batang had to move out around the mid-1990s, the loss of their homes and hence their constant presence in the kampung meant that "there is a loss of information... the guests who come and would like to know more, the information is cut off. Because we [the Habib's family] no longer live here, the mosque [management] was handed over to the residents here", according to the kinsman interviewed. Beyond the family and those who help to upkeep and manage the shrine, who provided some information with rough dates, there has been very little mentioned amongst interviewees, residents, general public, and published material about the details of the move (see Puspitasari, Djunaedi, & Putra, 2012; Puspitasari & Djunaedi, 2009).

I read the dissatisfaction with the mosque alterations based on the same criteria for mainstream heritage-making – that original buildings matter – as highlighting two important issues which are in tension. The first is accepting that external help is needed to maintain the heritage, and

the second is that the heritage and legacy of the shrine is also linked to the loss of the kinsmen's homes and of the power of directly being in that space as knowledge holders. This is in contrast to the Langgar Tinggi mosque in Pekojan as discussed in the previous chapter which also has cultural heritage status, but generations of residents have thus far continued to live on the property. This also lends evidence to the uneven treatment of cultural heritage sites in kampungs.

To support the growing domestic and international tourism in Kota Tua, there have been more attempts by the private sector to provide tourist accommodation in the area, with varied success. Residents in Luar Batang and Pekojan are concerned that more hotels are coming up in and around their neighbourhood, with one community leader urging the local Pokdarwis (Tourism Awareness Group) youth group to promote homestays in the kampungs to counter the growing presence of hotels. A youth leader from Pekojan described how there are not as many houses left in his area, as many have become warehouses, even lodgings (*penginapan*). However, he mentioned that there was a resident's house which became a hotel, but it did not work out and was now a drug rehabilitation facility.

On factors which would impact on future housing in Kota Tua, a Pekojan resident argued for the need to "shut down any developments such as apartments, excessive hotels because it will probably be damaging". He added that:

if it's outside Kota Tua, please carry on building hotels to support the tourism in Kota Tua. It doesn't have to be in Kota Tua, right? Because in Kota Tua there are only three villages (*kampung*) as I said before. Therefore, it is actually very simple, no need to make a fuss (*ributin*) about Kota Tua... Not in Pekojan, not in Glodok, not in the coastal kampungs.

The emphasis on the immovable place of kampungs in Kota Tua and on the importance of Kota Tua remaining mostly a residential area signal the sense of displacement by gentrification that caters to tourists and which residents want to counteract.

5.4. Gradual displacement through land, migration, and demographic changes

Other than direct displacements from heritage tourism, a major concern raised among residents was the significant shift in their neighbourhood spaces from mostly residential to more commercial uses, which is a form of gentrification. In a strategic location like Kota Tua, significant change in residential composition has been taking place as people move out, and buildings change from being homes and shophouses to warehouses, workshops, and lodgings. These changes in function from the area's spatial plan, enabled by permission from neighbourhood and city authorities, faced some resistance from residents who conceded that anything was possible because "money talks". This is especially considering the high costs of land in Kota Tua which shape and are shaped by economic considerations, with businesses attracted to setting up there due to its strategic location and large land plots and buildings. A former neighbourhood leader in his 50s said:

Apart from housing, they [the businesses] also need warehouses, which need land. The storage space for their goods to be bought and sold is here...And most of them are looking and competing for profit. That's one of it when we are talking about land issues in Kota Tua, other than for hotels or apartments.

These sought-after spaces are being transformed into economically productive sites whose main objective is generating profit for the businesses. These altered spatial functions and economic dynamics have been expressed as a sense of loss by residents who used to identify the streets of their neighbourhood with the people and their shophouses that they knew well.

In tandem with land use changes, a fifth-generation resident of Pekojan described the hollowing out of residents in the Kota Tua area:

Eventually it won't be occupied by residents but only as commercial land (*lahan usaha*). That's what happens mostly... even though Tambora subdistrict [of which Pekojan is a part] is one of the most densely populated areas. But for the Pekojan ward, it could be said that it has the lowest number of people in Tambora.

The latter observation is attributed to the outmigration of original inhabitants, and the fact that the houses and land plots in Pekojan are still considered quite large as compared to the other Kota Tua neighbourhoods. The general depopulation trend in Kota Tua's older neighbourhoods

mirrors historic centres elsewhere that experience revitalisation, rehabilitation, and recovery that led to the displacement of local residents through various means and increase in property values, as discussed in Chapter 2 (Soccali & Cinà, 2020, p. 288).

But what is distinctive in this case is the ethnic character of the hollowing out, with the Arab community feeling that they are most affected. Heritage preservation has proven challenging given the loss of a significant segment of its population, even in the case where there was government interest in the maintenance of the kampung's heritage. One Pekojan mosque leader said that the city government was “in fact making efforts to make this area as a destination... The government had revitalised Kota Tua, its museums, its tourism, and they want the next target to be *halal* tourism such as in the Arab kampung. But they find it difficult to realise this because there are no longer elements which can make that happen”, with “elements” referring to the declining cultural presence of the Arab population in Pekojan.

While there are various ways to promote *halal* tourism amid an evolving population, this comment underscores the living heritage embedded within kampungs that is not so easily replicated and authentically reproduced without its inhabitants, even if it is formally considered a heritage area or contains heritage objects. This comment also resulted from the mosque leader observing other Indonesian cities which become references, models, templates, and proof of what should be:

If I compare [Pekojan] with other Arab kampungs in various major Indonesian cities such as Surabaya and Semarang, it could be said that there is a legacy, the people there still have characteristics that are in accordance with the title “Arab kampung” – there are still many Arabs, conditions that show Arabness (*kearaban*), Arab identity, such as the food, the traders.

This comparison of dynamics among similar entities within Indonesia has led to a process of connecting, learning, and self-understanding, but also a greater sense of loss of the community.

Unlike in Pekojan, residents of Luar Batang expressed more confidence that the kampung would remain a residential area according to the city's spatial plan despite top-down heritage constructions but acknowledged that its residential relations have changed over time. A piece

of land in Figure 5.8 next to the main entrance has been lying empty since at least 2013 (Google maps, Mar 2013), covered with thick foliage. The houses which used to be there were demolished and the land was said to have been bought over by a company about 25 years ago, according to Ibu Ya who had to move to another plot in Luar Batang. The impasse is often cited as evidence that nothing can be done outside of the rules which govern its land use for residential purposes only. People have varying ideas of what should be done with it (e.g. build more rental housing or an animal farm, as expressed by a few interviewees from the kampung), signifying diverse visions but expressing optimism for the future of the existence of their kampung.

However, the perennial threat of displacement by gentrification had led a Luar Batang kampung resident to express that “whoever sells their house is a traitor”, condemning those who do so as acting against the collective wishes and existence. This rhetoric echoed the apparent response to past displacement overtures from the DKI Jakarta government in 2016 (OkeViral, 2016). There were banners throughout the kampung demonstrating the collective resistance towards then government plans to evict residents, including one which read, “Don’t evict the people just for the sake of developers” (*Jangan usir rakyat hanya demi kepentingan pengembang*). There remains a strong sense of solidarity though recent events and current economic conditions have impacted on people’s individual priorities.



Figure 5.8 Land lying empty, covered with overgrown foliage over the years
(Source: Author, 2023)

Another source of displacement which is heritage-related is the migration and demographic changes taking place in the kampungs. While migration is part and parcel of life in Jakarta, when observed with the housing dynamics and strategies, it reveals underlying issues of economic disparities. In Pekojan, for families living in the traditional inherited houses (*rumah warisan*), these houses with heritage value and expensive upkeep are increasingly being sold, fetching a high price for their location and plot size. Some are sold as families grow and need more space or are struggling economically and move elsewhere cheaper. As one Pekojan resident explained: “Sell at a high price, then they move to Bogor or Tangerang or Depok where the land price is much cheaper. They sell one house here [in Pekojan], they can buy three or four houses in another place when they migrate (*hijrah*). In general most of them are inherited houses (*warisan*).” With inherited houses, this means that the breaking of inheritance (*pecah waris*) occurs, but only if all the inheritors agree. This can become a long-protracted process to get the various inheritors to agree, often leaving the house to languish. Some members within a family do not wish to sell their inherited homes due to its heritage value, prime location, and a reluctance to move out of the Pekojan community. Two common expressions amongst those I spoke to in Pekojan are that “no one really wants to move unless they have to”, and “there is an old saying that those who leave will always return” – refrains often heard in Luar Batang too.

A perspective which is less obvious in studies of displacement is the feeling of being left behind, of being identified as the ‘underclass’, which occurs in the kampungs when people, especially those who share the same cultural background, move out. The affective displacement (Butcher & Dickens, 2016) felt by those who remain, particularly the Arab community, is tinged with class sentiments interlaced with a shared ethnic identity. In Pekojan, besides the major factor of the break-up of inheritance (*pecah waris*), the other major factor for out-migration is the choice made by some to “separate themselves as a class” (*mengkelaskan diri*), as perceived by those who remain. A Pekojan resident of Arab descent spoke about the formation of class ‘here’ in Pekojan, and ‘there’ wherever Arabs in Pekojan were moving which was perceivably more suited to their new economic status after having done well for themselves. He said, “they set themselves apart (*mengasingkan diri*), withdrawing (*menarik diri*) to places that they consider to be suitable for them, for their community...which is among those with higher economic status (*ekonomi atas*)” and leaving behind “those with weak economy”. The feeling of being displaced is hence not just about wealthier people moving into and gentrifying the neighbourhood, but also about those who left and are left behind.

This opting out from Pekojan, while a decision made individually, has a profound impact on housing security as these choices, understood collectively, are as much about the monetary value of the property as the changing social values and meanings of living in a kampung. The impact of these choices on kampung life are felt by those who remain. A Pekojan resident in his early 40s described his feelings of affective displacement in terms of the number of familial relations, houses and shops which belonged to Arabs in the past: “When I was a child, around the 90s till 2000s, we still felt contented living here [in Pekojan] because there were still many of our relatives and Arab houses around here.” He elaborated on economic and spatial changes which have taken place, as explored in Chapter 4, going so far as to describe the “Singaporeanisation”⁴² (*disingapurakan*) of Pekojan, referring to the historical process where the majority original inhabitants became a minority over time: “The distance between Pekojan and Pecinan, which is known as the Chinese (*Tionghoa*) village, in the middle, there are many shops at the morning market (*Pasar Pagi*)...It could be said that the majority of the shops were owned by Arabs, but now not even one.” Interestingly, a Chinese resident in his 60s also had expressed nostalgia regarding the Chinese businesses trading spices, agricultural produce, and

⁴² I note that this comparison was likely surfaced by my presence as a Singaporean in the field.

essential groceries at Pasar Pagi which have been taken over mostly by shops offering mass produced goods like plastics, t-shirts, and sports equipment. In kampungs, everyday life and its social, economic, political dimensions are intimately connected to the neighbourhood. Understanding how these dimensions shape and are shaped by heritage-making, in terms of buildings, traditions, and narratives as elaborated on in Chapter 4, is critical to housing security for kampung residents, beyond dealing with immediate and direct eviction or displacement.

However, the differentiated challenges faced by Pekojan residents and the impact of newcomers on the inter- and intra- ethnic relations within the neighbourhood known for its harmonious diversity are not lost on its Arab residents, as mentioned in Chapter 4. An Arab resident in his 40s observed that

Those who come in, as if a replacement for the Arab ethnic group, it's the Chinese, such as those from Kalimantan where most of them are from. So, during the 70s, 80s or even early 90s, the Chinese present were indigenous (*pribumi*) of Pekojan too. They got along, they mingled, and they were united [with the rest of the neighbourhood] ... This is what makes the Pekojan community divergent once again, with different nuances and conditions, where they [the immigrants] are more closed off from mixing in the area.

His quote expresses a complex reality – an acknowledgement that communities grow and decline, and a recognition of the older generations of Chinese as indigenous to the neighbourhood because they were one of the first ones to settle or be born there. The usage of “*pribumi*” is notable because during the Dutch colonial period Arabs, Chinese and other Asian foreigners were eventually conveniently categorised as “foreign orientals” (De Jonge, 2001), placed below the “Europeans” and above the “natives” (*inlanders* in Dutch, *pribumi* in Indonesian), but its usage has evolved to encompass a broader Indonesian identity (Indrayana, 2017). Yet at the same time, terms that are meant to be inclusive can mask the ethnic complexities and tensions behind socio-economic grievances (Kusno, 2000).

The arrival of new co-ethnics who are perceived to be wealthier introduced visible differences in the neighbourhood. While external changes such as more gated architecture of houses can be observed as compared to before where scholars noted the lack of the “architecture of fear” in the form of gates in Pekojan (Nas & Pratiwo, 2003), the changes in the built environment

have now impacted the way social life is conducted in the neighbourhood. Where neighbours mixed more freely across ethnic and religious boundaries in the past, according to residents' recollections, with newer migration, the current transformation seem to present insecurities for both newer and older residents. As a non-Chinese Pekojan resident describes the newer residents who find Pekojan attractive as a location to own property but not necessarily live there, leaving the property in the care of workers for instance:

Having found a place like Pekojan which they [the Chinese] consider comfortable (*nyaman*), easy access to anywhere, but they are not sure that this place is safe for them to live in. They are more closed off, exclusive, and would feel more at ease living in a complex (*komplek*) such as in Pluit, Pantai Indah Kapuk, or in an apartment where the security is better taken care of.⁴³

On the other hand, a Chinese resident in his 60s pinned the latter trend of owners having their shophouse businesses in Pekojan but living in gated communities elsewhere on generational differences. There is therefore some ambivalence in how these physical changes are being perceived by residents.

Various older residents across ethnic backgrounds have described how it was becoming difficult to engage with newer residents who tend to refuse to open their homes or are rarely around for neighbourhood activities such as routine mosquito breeding inspections or tend to “keep to themselves more”. While the newer residents may have their own concerns about being in a new area, older and longtime residents also have had to contend with the insecurities brought about by the internally and externally induced change in kampung socialities that have characterised their kampung life for generations. One member from the local women's group shared how her elderly neighbour decided to move to a different part of Pekojan after her husband's passing because she did not feel at home in her transformed area which has seen more new immigrants who are from a different ethnic background. While residents from different backgrounds may witness the same phenomenon, that is the presence of newcomers, their individual perceptions depend on the configuration of their relative identities and situations which become differentially activated in heritage-making.

⁴³ A subtle reference to violent and deadly periodic attacks on the ethnic Chinese population, during colonial and post-colonial times (Kusno, 2000, 2003).

5.5. Subaltern contestations

The forms of displacement thus far described is coloured significantly by ethnic and religious hues. This is because of the way that the history, governance, and everyday kampung life in these two kampungs have been heavily shaped by such primary identity markers, which are themselves unstable and being transformed from within as changes take place. However, these displacement experiences have not gone uncontested by those under threat. Residents and their allies found ways to manage and anticipate displacement threats, by using religious narratives to create openings to contest dominant heritage-making, refusing official heritage recognition, and looking for other sources of authority and resources.

By engaging in heritage-making that at times reappropriates and subverts dominant discourses, subaltern actors attempt to create alternative pathways and relations to the one offered by the state and other powerful actors by employing different understandings and undertakings of heritage (buildings, traditions, and narratives). They also aim to alter the future of kampungs by making efforts at securing the community's needs to reduce reliance on any one powerful actor.

Following subaltern contestations on housing in Kota Tua and its kampungs bring to mind the concept of “habitability” (Green & Murray, 2012, p. 17, citing de Certeau) which speaks to the ability of narratives to ‘open up’ the possibilities of being in the increasingly homogenised city, as mentioned in Chapter 2. Narratives in this sense allow for the telling of stories, memories, and experiences of people, that defies simple definitions, linear histories, and rigid categories that could be easily co-opted, and reproduced for other purposes. Top-down heritage constructions and attempts not only aim to extract profit from heritage-making but also to reorder spaces into controllable, measurable, and sanitised sites. The extent to which subaltern heritage-making does not follow such restrictive and narrow heritage conservation scripts that reproduce exclusive identities, claims, and access (Hammami et al., 2022, p. 10), creates openings for varied ways of existing in and imagining the city, against displacement.

The role of religious narratives through heritage-making is crucial in creating these openings to contest top-down planning and practices. In the case of shrines in Luar Batang and Pekojan, it surfaced in various interviews with residents, mosque and temple caretakers, that they attract

pilgrims and visitors from all over the country and even overseas. This is the case for even those shrines or graves currently with limited recorded information (such as those in the An-Nawier mosque or Padi Lapa temple) or are unmarked (such as those in Al Anshor mosque). The physical structures, traditions, and narratives surrounding the shrines constitute the heritage and value of the area that is neither easily evaluated nor dismissed. The An-Nawier mosque has a shrine of the same name as another shrine in a mosque located in an Arab kampung in Semarang, another Indonesian city in Central Java, but not much is known about the former and its name was only known since early 2000s. Similarly, for the Padi Lapa temple, the Chinese temple with a Muslim saint memorial whom they claimed had set foot there and had Chinese ancestry, claims which are disputed by some but upheld by many from various religious backgrounds in ways that defy simplistic categorisations or treatment. Religious or spiritual experiences form part of the site's public heritage, but they also involve deeply personal connections that go beyond the technical details and historically accurate information that mainstream heritage-making increasingly promotes and attempts to codify.

With such attention, attendance, religious beliefs and connotations surrounding a place, residents and observers expressed that their belief that it has had some deterrent effect on interested parties who may want to redevelop the area. Hence religious narratives have been strategic in securing the settlement against displacement. This also became evident when I interviewed a caretaker of the oldest mosque (Al Anshor) where the first settlement of Muslim migrants took place in Pekojan. No one seemed to know the founders of the mosque, nor its descendants, nor seem too interested to find out, as mentioned in Chapter 4. There are also a few unmarked graves in its backyard which continue to attract outside visitors (Ardiansyah, 2018). Researchers have just started the process of tracing their origins at the time of my fieldwork.⁴⁴ For as long as the building is imbued with sacred narratives and therefore valued heritage (whether formally or informally), even though it has been totally renovated several times to reinforce the crumbling structure due to age, flooding, and the densification of surrounding residences, the existing conditions of the mosque and its surrounding settlement can be maintained indefinitely.

Contrary to religious buildings for which heritage status has mostly been seen as a boon, residents often cited examples of homeowners whose houses have heritage value yet refuse to

⁴⁴ Personal communication with a heritage expert on Kota Tua.

officially acquire heritage status. This could be due to observing precedents where strict regulations were enforced on heritage buildings which became onerous to upkeep, or fears, not wholly unfounded, that they might lose control over their homes, given the government's inconsistent track record in managing cultural heritage. These examples of refusals have led some observers to suggest that that was why many historical residential buildings have been left uncared for. As one Pekojan resident expressed,

the houses cannot be maintained properly because they have not been included as cultural heritage (*cagar budaya*). Many of them don't want their houses to be designated as cultural heritage. If it is cultural heritage, the government will take care of it, but they [the homeowners] are afraid that nothing can be done to the house – cannot add an attic (*diloteng*), cannot change the tiles, because they can't change.

It is apparent that various buildings in Pekojan with heritage value have either been altered to suit occupants' needs (e.g. splitting the house to sell or creating partitions for a home-based business) or neglected. However it is not necessarily only the fact that changes or maintenance would be difficult as an official heritage building, nor the oft-unreliable promise of government help with a heritage building that deters people from coveting the heritage designation. By refusing heritage designation and its associated processes, residents safeguard autonomy and privacy over their houses and surroundings, against mainstream heritage definitions and practices which are narrowly constructed and inflexible to the dynamic contexts of housing needs in the kampungs.

The wide-ranging influence of religion in politics and the economy means that heritage-making is not only confined to the usual authorities that deal with heritage matters such as the Ministry of Education and Culture and its associated agencies. One of the ways in which kampung residents have contested convention is by looking for other allies beyond the usual suspects. Ustaz described how he figured that by appealing to different authorities and knowing how they operate and what they offer, he could raise the funds needed to improve the quality of life in the neighbourhood. He compared the Ministry of Education and Culture which oversees cultural heritage for which “there has not been any action at all”, and the Ministry of Religious Affairs which has a productive *waqf* programme:

They [the Ministry of Religious Affairs] were happy with our efforts to manage this waqf land, as it turns out there is business (*usaha*). And I conveyed to them my two aspirations (*harapan*) which had yet to materialise because of funding issues. Firstly, I want to open a restaurant (*rumah makan*), and secondly, a polyclinic... So in the shortest time the first proposal has been disbursed by them...

Looking to other sources of authority and resources allows simultaneous goals to be achieved. There is support for certain forms of heritage-making to preserve and reproduce the kampung (such as the eatery offering the neighbourhood's specialties), and alternative relations are explored and mainstream pathways that enclose power, authority and knowledge in certain fields such as heritage are contested.

However, such efforts to look for other ways to proceed are not without drawbacks and temptations, as the mosque leader recognised when he underscored the importance of remaining independent and focusing on the community's priorities:

There have been many tempting offers, many who wish to give cash to rent the place [the building next to the mosque], either for residence or business. But I rejected them all...I do not want people using this place without it being of interest to the mosque. Even though the money is in a form [cash] I can use right away. But what I hope for is that this land becomes a source of empowerment for the mosque's congregation.⁴⁵

In that mission of improving the quality of residential life for the community without giving in to shortcuts to raise money, shops are lined up along the side of the mosque, offering electrical supplies, water refills, laundrette, and the latest addition – an eatery offering Pekojan specialties.

Subaltern contestations of top-down urbanisms through heritage-making aim to address gentrification-led displacement differentially experienced by kampung residents. They do so by managing and anticipating threats, through employing heritage narratives and actions which open up various ways and relations other than the ones determined by the state. However, these

⁴⁵ Typically a mosque's main congregation is made up of the surrounding residents living in the neighbourhood who attend the mosque, but it can also include anyone who comes to the mosque and joins congregational prayers.

efforts at contesting displacement strategies and threats from the top are not without unintended consequences, as power can still be concentrated in the hands of a few if these efforts become exclusive or fall into the very dominant ‘heritage’ trappings that they contest.

5.6. Changing geographies of inequalities within and across kampungs

Both heritage-making from below and above in Kota Tua have made use of the kampung in heritage constructions, with different impacts for housing security as seen through the lens of displacement processes. State-led, heritage-making from above, such as thematic kampungs or designated destination spots lend visibility and legitimacy to some kampungs, often without much input from the communities themselves. ‘Kampung as heritage’ is rarely employed from the top-down because it would mean legitimising kampungs with their various legal statuses as a valid residential typology in today’s rapidly urbanising and modernising Jakarta.

Heritage-making from below has thus far attempted to align certain aspects of kampungs that reproduce dominant heritage discourses or surface alternative heritage strategically, while bringing away attention from or rehabilitating other aspects which have been used as justification for displacing or evicting residents (e.g. red-light districts, drug problems, delinquency). Beyond ground-up efforts to improve the existing living conditions of their neighbourhoods, by emphasising the heritage aspects (buildings, traditions, and narratives) of the kampung, the corollary is that the kampung as a heritage area therefore is not a ‘slum’, because heritage areas cannot be slums. This turns on its head dominant displacement logics which dictate that anything labelled as ‘slums’ by more powerful actors do not have heritage value and therefore need to be eradicated in pursuit of housing redevelopment. Therefore heritage-making has a role to play in material and narrative differentiations between “*kumuh*” (slum) versus “*kampung*” (village/neighbourhood), whether by the government, or residents and their advocates.

What makes a kampung is not only the shared experiences, stories, and struggles, which often transcend geographical boundaries, but also the unique characteristics that make one kampung different from others. For example, earlier I referred to how small businesses surrounding the mosques in Pekojan boast goods and services which aim to meet the daily needs of residents living in the neighbourhood. But the community and its leaders also make deliberate efforts to recreate, enliven, and sustain the unique characteristics of the Arab kampung and awaken the

consciousness of people through appealing to their senses and experiences. As one mosque leader leading some of the community efforts expressed his hopes about setting up the restaurant: “This is something that hopefully can provide a breath of fresh air or awaken the senses, because *sate* [skewered and barbequed meat] has smoke, so the people of Pekojan through their sense of smell start to realise that they live in Pekojan.” His use of the olfactory signals speaks to the everyday and ordinary placemaking that calls on identity – that residents feel that their neighbourhood is distinct from other neighbourhoods and has value which is worth upkeeping.

When asked about the role of kampungs in Jakarta, one of the Habib’s kinsmen expressed the important role of kampung residents in the upkeep of Luar Batang’s heritage: “For apartments, they [the residents] are more towards business, workers, like that right. It’s different from people in the kampung who tend to be more religious (*religi*) and feel like the place belongs to them”. His comment was meant to highlight the differences between kampung and apartment residents in terms of sense of belonging and religious culture that drive the former towards maintaining heritage. However it also illustrates a common but contentious perception that people living in kampungs tend to participate in the city’s economy in a way which does not place their economic self before other parts of their life (in this case religion and community), as compared to those who live in apartments. This perception was both echoed and contradicted in other interviews with kampung residents. Hence heritage-making efforts to counter the displacement of the kampung in the city reflect these anxieties and the value that people have for the built environment (the ‘hardware’) of the kampung though it is neither sufficient nor necessary for the upkeep of the ‘software’ of the kampung.

However, the effects of heritage-making on housing security for residents have been mixed. As discussed in Chapter 4, the Luar Batang mosque compound has most recently been renovated to revert to its “original” design. According to various resident accounts, while there is more public open space within the mosque compound for visitors and events, the actual prayer hall space has somehow shrunk. Though it is not clear yet what the implications of the latter are, it was a source of concern for some residents. Rental housing just next to the mosque has been knocked down, as seen in Figure 5.9, to reclaim the plot of land for the expansion of the mosque, with renters reportedly given compensation and moved elsewhere.⁴⁶ This brings about

⁴⁶ Informal conversations with residents living near the mosque.

common tensions between bringing back “old forms” in a bid for heritage authenticity in a changing context, and providing adequate housing to meet growing demands in society.

Further, as mentioned in Chapter 4, in Jakarta, as in many Muslim-majority areas, the “symbiotic” relationship between the mosque and kampung is a constant feature of a residential landscape, or that the mosque and kampung are a “unity” (*satu-kesatuan*), as various interviewees referred to. The mosque is a socio-religious institution kept alive by congregants who are usually from the surrounding constituency. The extent to which this relation between heritage-making and socio-religious function continues to be upheld as complementary rather than conflicting would impact positively on anti-displacement struggles. The latter was seen in the previous eviction plans by the DKI government under Governor Ahok in 2016 which prioritised heritage-making projects over the wider functions of the mosque as a central religious, social, and cultural space for the community.



Figure 5.9 Rental housing demolished to make way for next phase of mosque expansion (Source: Author, 2023)

One of the ways in which the anti-displacement struggles can be undermined is the differentiations within and across neighbourhoods that become more apparent once heritage-making comes into play. Some residents viewed Luar Batang as relatively secure as the

kampung has not been officially considered a “slum” by the city administration.⁴⁷ However they expressed concern that varying degrees of slum-like conditions⁴⁸ in one part of the neighbourhood can lead to a whole neighbourhood being stigmatised by the government or outsiders. One interviewee from Luar Batang viewed that a major cause of this was people using up whatever available free space, around their house, such as a front yard or spaces between building, for renting out as accommodation (*kontrakan*). This has not only contributed to the increase of slum-like conditions such as overcrowding, unsafe makeshift structures, and inadequate facilities, but has also affected the way the neighbourhood functions as a convivial social space that he fondly recalled from his childhood days as there are more outsiders. A major issue raised by a few residents in Luar Batang is self-organisation which requires a collective mindset that they argue is being challenged with the increase of people from outside the kampung. These newcomers could be Indonesian migrants from other parts of the archipelago to whom houses are being sold at high prices in the strategic location, or workers in rental arrangements. These differentiations reveal concerns about the maintenance of kampung life and impacting on its heritage construction.

Similarly in Pekojan, a second-generation resident expressed that “in the 1970s, my house still had a yard, houses were still big, the roads were also wide. But with time, there is a need for more housing. Eventually we see that houses have become small, and slum-like (*kumuh*)... There are so many buildings being built that are not what they used to be.” The latter was referring to the traditional houses (mainly Moorish, Chinese, and vernacular) characteristic of Pekojan, which are narrow in the front as seen in Figure 5.10 and long lengthwise as seen from the extended roofs in Figure 5.11. Many of these houses have been split up, repurposed, or with facades drastically altered.

⁴⁷ Residents spoke of the presence of an orange gate (*gapura oren*) signified that an area is a slum (*kumuh*) since the community planning programmes during Anies Baswedan’s governorship, and how it has been unevenly applied because there are other kampungs which fulfil the criteria but have not labelled as such.

⁴⁸ Slums are defined as “sub-standard areas include irregular building plots, high-density buildings, and poor infrastructure” (Alzamil, 2020), translated from the Housing and Residential Area Act No 1 2011 (*Undang-Undang Perumahan dan Kawasan Permukiman Nomor 1 Tahun 2011*).



Figure 5.10 Narrow fronts of old houses in Pekojan (Source: Author, 2023)



Figure 5.11 Extended roofs of houses show the lengths of houses in Pekojan (Source: Author, 2023)

Embedded within residents' comments that more segmented and rental housing tend to lead to more slum-like conditions in the neighbourhood is the experience of some residents that the increasing diversity of residents and prosperity from profitable real estate and other pursuits make it more difficult for people to cooperate with each other and conform to the existing social norms. This is in addition to the spatial reorganisation as areas around heritage sites are renovated, refurbished, or rebuilt over time.

As mentioned in Chapter 4, according to one interviewee Pak San, there were already attempts in the 1980s to organise the Luar Batang neighbourhood into a more orderly space through improving their livelihoods first by promoting training for weaving and printing traditions, and small businesses. It was thought that with a better economy, people would be driven to improve their physical surroundings. However, together with more in-migration, Pak San observed that the economy became people's focus and no longer merely the means to an end of better physical living conditions. More economically expedient means of earning a livelihood overtook traditional businesses which have all but disappeared. One such way is renting out rooms (*kost*) or houses (*kontrakan*) to residents and temporary migrants, at times maximising space within and outside the house. There have been no regulations about renting out thus far and it remains a private arrangement between renters and owners. According to residents, while localities have tacit agreements with landlords, they are hard to enforce and communal ties are relied upon to sort things out where there are issues, such as blocking pathways, waste and sanitation management, and building safety. With a changing residential and economic composition, shifting communal ties are more challenging to rely on and undermine attempts to preserve the

heritage character of the kampung, in addition to adding more slum-like features which feed displacement narratives.

The struggle against displacement amongst ordinary residents becomes more nuanced when further internal differentiations are taken into account. In these two kampungs, the differentiation between older residents as “indigenous” (*pribumi*), often used by residents to mean at least second or third generation, and newer residents, who are labelled as “urban” and “newcomers” (*pendatang*), becomes more apparent under heritage-making projects. As discussed in Chapter 2, Hammami et al. (2022, p. 8) argue, “constructions of self and the Other are central mechanisms of processes of both heritagization and of gentrification”. In this case, it is noteworthy that those are moving to Jakarta for work are labelled “urban” by longtime residents who think of themselves as “not urban”, probably by virtue of the fact that they still embody the socialities of living in a rural village, amidst an urban landscape.

People differentiate between indigenes and newcomers whose presence is felt immediately, even though both may be informally remaining in place, to claim their place in the city and to pin at least some of the unwanted changes to their historic neighbourhood on a tangible, external source. According to a youth leader in Luar Batang, the kampung used to be “more comfortable, [with] less traffic, less renters” because there were “less newcomers”, and it is now more “complex” and “dizzying (*pusing*)” to move around the neighbourhood. The latter was due to increased number of vehicles, rented houses, and various street vendors turning up along the walkways to sell their wares to visitors and pilgrims, making it more onerous to move about. While he was referring to the increasing disorder and density of the neighbourhood commonly attributed to newcomers, he was also expressing the understated dimensions of gentrification-induced displacement that are not as easily seen or felt from the outside, in particular the spatial dislocation experienced by people who live in the neighbourhood.

However, while the indigene-newcomer differentiations are more openly spoken about, what is less obvious is other types of divergences along ethno-religious, generational, or gender lines which surface but are not discussed as much and contribute to instances of displacement from within the neighbourhood (Ahmad, 2022), as highlighted in Chapter 2. These manifest in the dominance of a particular type of Muslim culture over others, younger generations feeling trapped by heritage-making of elders, and role of women in heritage-making relegated to the

background. The differences constructed and emphasised reflect on the unsurprising nature of heritage-making, where there is as much a tendency for exclusions as treating a community as homogenous, to portray a stronger united front. By speaking about housing issues as it relates to heritage-making, some of these understated differences under the heritage lens come to the fore. For instance, various home-based businesses such as stalls offering unique traditional dishes, goods or services in Luar Batang and Pekojan are managed by women. Perhaps for various reasons such as being home-based, they are rarely the first examples when it comes to discussing heritage-making in the kampungs. In a few of these examples, the women also were the ones who moved into the kampung of their husbands after marriage. This added another layer of complexity for them in being recognised for the work they do that contributes indirectly or directly to the heritage of the kampung. Hence having more attention on kampungs in terms of housing security vis-à-vis displacement highlights some differences either by design or circumstance, but a heritage lens further draws out the understated differences which have become so ubiquitous as to be mundane, which will be further elaborated in the next chapter.

5.7. Conclusion

This chapter has highlighted how the recentering, remaking, or at times repairing, of the (im)material value of kampungs and their residents through heritage-making from below, contends with the materialistic values espoused by the city's economy and urbanisation. Housing provision and the heritage of the kampung are uniquely entwined in Jakarta, as illuminated in this chapter. To speak of either without addressing the other is impossible, as long as the housing crisis in Jakarta continues, and the kampung remains an important social, political and economic organisation of a neighbourhood. Various heritage-making projects from above and below have created, preserved, challenged, and reinforced the boundaries and contents of the neighbourhood for their own purposes.

In seeking to understand the impact of constructions of heritage and approaches towards the future in the housing context, I look to the practices of kampung residents and their allies, positioning their heritage-making, process and practice, as one of the various strategies and tactics in housing struggles by the marginalised in Jakarta against displacement. While immediate and direct displacement are common themes in and around Kota Tua in the pursuit to become tourist-ready according to government and private sector plans, it is the gradual

affective and spatial displacement (through land use, migration and demographic changes) which kampung residents experience that has received less attention in literature and practice. However the multifaceted displacement is not without contestation from those whose lives are affected. The role of religion in organising and valorising a neighbourhood through both economic and symbolic ways beyond neoliberal and top-down measures is often understated in urban scholarship. These contentious efforts, though bringing more attention to kampungs as the city's heritage, have unanticipated consequences as complex effects surface, such as increased housing precarity for some groups, amplified differences within and across neighbourhoods, and which obscure other differences along ethnic, generational, and gender lines. Heritage-making from below lays the ground and strengthens the connections through openings and cracks in the market-driven homogenisation of the city to shape urban outcomes away from both immediate and gradual displacement, which I will delve into in the next chapter.

Chapter 6. The politics of heritage-making from above and below

6.1. Introduction

“If you say this land is yours, which came first, Luar Batang or the Republic of Indonesia?”⁴⁹

The quote above is by a heritage activist from one of the kampungs examined in this thesis. He was giving an example of how he would debate with government agents who would lay claims to kampung lands to directly exploit or facilitate their sale to private developers and companies. In resisting displacement and eviction plans for Luar Batang, the activist makes a claim to the prior existence of the kampung to the country, arguing that it should give them certain rights to remain in place. It exemplifies the contested urbanisms which manifest in the kampung through heritage and housing issues, a scalar politics embodied in the claims to determine urban development by various local, national and international, individual and collective actors.

The previous two chapters focused on understanding the constructions of heritage in postcolonial Jakarta and examining their impact on the processes of displacement experienced by kampung residents. This chapter builds on this work by addressing the impact of heritage-making from above and below on state-society politics in Jakarta within the housing context. I argue that through processes of heritage-making from above and below that reveal contested ideas about urban development, as shown in the ways of seeing and producing the city, the connections and disjunctures between different authorities have been made more apparent. These connections and disjunctures have, in turn, enabled authorities to manage, control and neglect the less powerful, with the help of the private sector. However, subaltern actors work through the cracks and openings in top-down processes, producing new power formations and politics that contest or entrench the existing order. These include formations of horizontal solidarities, which demonstrate possibilities of overcoming such fragmented urban spaces.

The second section traces the political processes at various scales (the national, city, and community), building on emergent literature on the political dimensions of gentrification, and the bottom-up challenges presented by kampung communities and their advocates. The third and final section shows that while communities document, collaborate, and learn from each

⁴⁹ Quote by a heritage activist first used in Chapter 4.

other, solidarity connections are also fraught as the processes of heritage-making from below have made constructed differences more complex. This is observed through ethno-religious, class, gendered, and generational dynamics which complicate the top-down/subaltern power binaries.

6.2. Contested urbanisms: ways of seeing and producing the city

6.2.1 Top-down paradigms and practices

As noted in Chapter 1, various urbanisms have been described as operating on the ground in the context of Jakarta, such as “vernacular urbanism” (Achmadi & Josey, 2022), “neoliberal (global) urbanism” (Herlambang et al., 2018; Leitner & Sheppard, 2017), and “middling urbanism” (Kusno, 2020). These urbanisms play out in top-down and bottom-up processes which shape the urban condition in overlapping, contrasting, and disjointed ways that defy simple binaries of state-society dynamics, requiring a closer examination in specific contexts.

An episode which illustrates this complexity of state-society relations was a public discussion titled “The Fate of the Old Town after Revitalization and Planning” (*Nasib Kota Tua Pasca Revitalisasi dan Penataan Kota Tua*) in July 2023, organised by the Jakarta’s Old Town Journalists Working Group (*Pokja Wartawan Kota Tua Jakarta*). It brought together, for the first time since Covid-19, representatives from Kota Tua stakeholders such as the government, journalists, academics, heritage communities, and the private sector to discuss the future of Kota Tua after the most recent revitalisation and reorganisation by the city government (Pokjawar Kotu, 2023). Notably it was reported that the chair of the organising committee had expressed one of his hopes for Kota Tua was to restore the “local economy of the kampung” through efficient regulations and policy (Tahira, 2023) – describing Kota Tua as a “kampung”, and not just a site for commerce and tourism. Three of the eight speakers invited were government representatives who did not turn up, much to the disappointment of the organisers and participants (Tahira, 2023). One of the participants was a kampung activist who criticised the public discussion because first, it only discussed the Kota Tua inner zone which contained the colonial government buildings while Kota Tua included other zones which encompassed the different kampungs. Second, he argued that the forum title would have “scared off” the local government representatives, especially because policies were determined from the top by the governor, and not up to the representatives to preside over. When asked about the discussion

a few weeks later, one local government officer interviewed said that “honestly, I do not expect too much from discussing, discussing, discussing, because for journalists that’s their job,” hence dismissing such efforts to rejuvenate public debates on Kota Tua after the pandemic as nothing more than the journalists’ attempt to raise their own profiles.

The episode described above illustrates how top-down paradigms and practices in the form of territorial delineations and decision-making hierarchy remain dominant, shaping expectations and limitations of each stakeholder’s role. At a more abstract level, the hierarchical city-state relations and different levels of government also complicate policymaking and execution in unexpected ways. Even though Jakarta is a special capital region where the governor is a powerful actor, the city is subjected to national laws and regulations which constrain its autonomy. In the case of heritage preservation, as mentioned in Chapter 1, regulations have been slow to change, and coordination is impacted by intra-ministerial issues which ultimately affect local implementation. Therefore not much can be formally done even if the governor has good ideas about supporting kampungs, according to a heritage expert.

Paradoxically, he explained that Jakarta’s national dominance, rapid urban development, and wider heritage repertoires over time have precluded it from the more active heritage networks of smaller cities which have “frozen” cultural heritage forms that span particular time periods. These forms are archaeological sites which remain relatively more intact due to less development pressures than in the capital city, but that means the dominant types of heritage preservation taking place nationally have been focused on colonial, natural or ancient heritage. This pattern is reflected in Indonesia’s ten inscribed properties in the UNESCO World Heritage List (as of 2024) which include, for example, the Borobudur Temple Compounds, the Prambanan Temple Compounds, the Ombilin Coal Mine in Sawahlunto, and Yogyakarta’s *Kraton* (Palace). Dominance of this pattern at the national level inevitably impacts on Jakarta, lending support for the official focus on colonial heritage preservation and discourse in Kota Tua.

The hierarchical relationship between the city and state is reinforced through the different levels of government. One local government officer in UPK Kota Tua explained that “if only

we have more authority by being at a higher echelon (*eselon*)⁵⁰, we can initiate collaborations across government agencies”, as he reflected on his failed attempts to initiate collaborations with government organisations which are in the higher divisions. However, he also acknowledged that waiting for directions from the top may be futile if no one in the upper ranks wants to initiate measures, often reaching an impasse.

Being top-down driven while expanding the number of agencies and partnerships as part of “neoliberal restructuring” (Coombe & Weiss, 2015, p. 45) results in not only overlaps but also disjointed outcomes when the varied territorial features and duration of political regimes are considered. This is exacerbated by the different administrative jurisdictions and government agencies operating in the same area under different mandates, while the historic old town is part of the city of Jakarta and governed according to the city’s political cycles. An example of the problem is the decline of an acclaimed programme from the previous elected governorship (2017-2022), “Jakpreneur”. This was a post-pandemic programme designed to help local small and medium-sized businesses. Figure 6.1 shows a former Jakpreneur site, housed in an old building along *Kali Besar* (Big River) on the canal side of inner Kota Tua, which has become a parking lot in a pedestrianised area, just two years after its inauguration in 2021. A local government officer described such governor programmes as “sporadic” because “when one governor’s term ends, all that remains is the news (*khabar*), the stories (*cerita*). It’s always like that.”

⁵⁰ The official echelon classification system is used in the civil service to distinguish the level of hierarchy between management-level civil servants, with level IV (heads of subdivisions and sections) currently being the lowest, to 1a and 1b the highest (e.g. heads of national agencies) (Pierskalla et al., 2021). Local department of a Ministry or government agency (*Dinas*) is at Echelon II, while UPK Kota Tua is at Echelon III (UPK Kota Tua, 2021).



Figure 6.1 Photo of a Jakpreneur site along Kali Besar (Big River), now a parking lot, a shadow of its former self (Source: Author, April 2023)

The shifting priorities of each elected governor lend support to this officer's and others' (such as members of the public) repeated calls for a dedicated institution with the right mandate and powers for the Kota Tua area. The call is for an institution similar to what the other nine Priority Destinations (*Destinasi Pariwisata Prioritas* - DPP) and National Strategic Tourism Areas (*Kawasan Strategis Pariwisata Nasional* - KSPN) have (Ministry of Tourism, Republic of Indonesia, 2024; UPK Kota Tua, 2021, pp. 2, 12; World Bank, n.d.).⁵¹ This was because currently as the coordinating body for Kota Tua, UPK Kota Tua's authority is at a lower level than the government agencies they are coordinating with for different regulations and public works in the area. This has made UPK Kota Tua's wide-ranging responsibilities challenging, as the authority to carry out works and enforce the various regulations remains with each government department and hierarchical procedures. Such a situation has resulted in disorder when too many government bodies were involved in an uncoordinated manner, according to a UPK Kota Tua officer. The former is exemplified in the disparate signages in the Kota Tua area in Chapter 4 which showed different few government agencies operating in the same area.

⁵¹ One local government officer from UPK Kota Tua noted how it has been in process for three to five years since the 2021 academic study titled "Institutional Strengthening Plan for the Kota Tua Management Unit" (*Rancangan Penguatan Kelembagaan Unit Pengelola Kawasan (UPK) Kotatua*) that identified the issues and proposed plans to strengthen the institution of the UPK Kota Tua, but results have yet to be seen.

Closely linked to shifting priorities of the government is participation in the international heritage regime, which is viewed by various government and community actors as important, but for different reasons. One local government officer remarked that he was aware a UNESCO recognition does not necessarily provide direct and immediate material benefits such as funding, and that at the global level, it is increasingly politicised, with decision-making swayed by vested interests of state parties in the relevant committees (Meskell, 2014). Yet some community actors who have tried engaging with government or local (Indonesian) organisations often experienced from them what one community historian described as “No Action Talk Only – NATO”, tending to place more hope in “world organisations” which are deemed as more “genuine”. The community historian also explained that “organisations at the international level involve experts which are not local – they have Germans, French, Dutch – who would try to work out a system for the area”. “System” is used to refer to a well-thought and holistic plan that considers various technical, economic, environmental and social aspects of the heritage site, an assumption afforded to foreigners and external organisations like UNESCO, as compared to the seemingly unsystematic and sporadic efforts by local government and organisations. The downsides of UNESCO designation on the local social, cultural, economic, and environmental life as a result of increased tourism and restrictions do not feature as much in such discussions (Caust & Vecco, 2017).

These two perspectives capture the differences in assumptions, expectations, and purposes of engaging with international heritage regimes that are not mutually exclusive. For state actors, international participation means having a powerful way to shape local agendas and govern urban and rural spaces for national purposes (Coombe & Weiss, 2015, p. 43). As seen in the case of Kota Tua, the World Heritage nomination process gave the government and a group of private companies the leverage to alter the physical, social, and branding aspects of the area according to their plans, though they have not been successful thus far.

Top-down ways of seeing and producing the city have shaped societal expectations of where solutions should come from, with public discussions viewed as a waste of time, and national heritage focus on ancient and colonial cultural heritage taking precedence over more localised concerns. At the same time, top-down practices have a short lifespan subservient to the

disconnected priorities of the government of the day, which have resulted in less than successful heritage projects, even by its own standards.

6.2.2 Private sector enterprise and state support

The apparent ability of the private sector in Jakarta to realise large urban infrastructure projects bring into sharp relief the gaps and neoliberal interventions of the state. In speaking with an interviewee from the managing team at Pantai Indah Kapuk (PIK), the “floating city” mentioned in Chapter 4, what was striking was the speed, scale, and nature of the creation of a mixed-use development on the reclaimed land of North Jakarta. He largely attributed it to the wholly private enterprise of the project – from the reclamation, to the buildings, to the conception of the area which boasts different foreign theme-based sites to cater to (upper) middle class domestic and foreign consumers.⁵² Everything looked planned and formalised, there was no itinerant street vendor or performer around, and everything had a higher price tag than what one might find in an ordinary neighbourhood in North Jakarta. There were also various housing advertisement guarantees that it would not flood in PIK for “1000 years” or that PIK is flood-free due to the proven polder system, stating evidence that when “Jakarta was flooded, PIK1 did not flood at all” (PIK2, n.d.). The crafting of the “new Jakarta City”⁵³ highlights the shortcomings of the Jakarta city government in meeting the needs and desires of its residents, particularly those from the middle to upper strata of society.

A recent development in April 2024 was the inclusion of PIK2 into the list of National Strategic Projects (*Proyek Strategis Nasional* - PSN) of the central government.⁵⁴ PIK2 is promoted on its website and social media as the “newest, most popular, most modern, and most viral independent city” (*kawasan kota mandiri terbaru, ter-hits, ter-modern, dan ter-viral*)⁵⁵ (PIK2, 2024). This has undoubtedly raised questions amongst the public because PIK2 was one of the two “privately developed township megaprojects” most recently included as a national strategic

⁵² SP; Tatler Indonesia (2022) featured an article “The New Smart City in the Bay of Jakarta” on Pantai Indah Kapuk (PIK).

⁵³ Tagline of PIK2 (<https://www.pik2.com/>), but was also used in the early beginnings of the reclaimed area (see Wade, 2023).

⁵⁴ PIK2 is the extension of the earlier PIK development (Antara News, 2024a), and they are often referred to as just “PIK”.

⁵⁵ “Viral”, a zeitgeist word of the social media age, is used to refer to the PIK2 area’s popularity on the internet, particularly spreading quickly on social media platforms where people are sharing about their visits and the attractions there.

project while it was already in progress, and that it did not meet the criteria for PSNs such as reducing socioeconomic inequality and Java-centric development, according to several commentators (Nadeak, 2024; Saeran, 2024). In another government discourse, the “New Jakarta City” is latched onto the national tourism strategic area (*Kawasan Strategic Pariwisata Nasional* - KSPN) of the Thousand Islands and Kota Tua-Sunda Kelapa, which as I have mentioned has its own set of challenges since it is a KSPN without a dedicated institution to manage it. By being associated with Kota Tua KSPN, the “New Jakarta City” as a national strategic project (PSN) attempts to create more belief in the economic benefits for businesses, investors, and communities (Kuswaraharja, 2024) and increase confidence in the appointment of these two areas as nationally important projects. The relation between Kota Tua and PIK in this manner presents further evidence of the colonial-capitalist connection in top-down heritage-making processes geared towards tourism, as explained in Chapter 4 where the inclusion of Batavia PIK in their formal jurisdiction was met with apprehension by North Jakartan residents.

Both the private sector and the state stand to gain from the inclusion of private development in the national repertoire of projects, to the detriment of the public and urban poor communities. A major observation in the press has been that the same Indonesian developers of PIK are involved in a consortium which is funding the development of the new capital, Nusantara (*Ibu Kota Nusantara* - IKN), against the low uptake of foreign investors (Saeran, 2024). A likely consequence is that the government could then just choose to focus on national projects which are already in progress to boost its record (Nadeak, 2024). The private developers could also make further use of the advantages of being a PSN, such as “accelerating development, because any obstacles, both regulations and permits, must be resolved by the relevant ministers, governors and regents, through accelerated time for land provision, and guaranteed political security” (Verico et al., 2023, p. 37). These indicate potential displacement which would exacerbate the housing security of the most vulnerable.

Having the backing of the state on private projects which may have some economic benefits for society in terms of job creation and tourism further entrenches neoliberal features (commodification, financialisation, and individualisation) embedded by producing an urban development catering to affluent groups while being open to the public. This privatisation approach also ignores the multifaceted harmful effects on surrounding areas of North Jakarta.

These effects include direct physical and economic displacement due to land reclamation along the coastal areas (Adharani et al., 2019; Betteridge & Webber, 2019), and affective displacement through the various modern, planned, and hegemonic representations of the “New Jakarta City” which exclude the urban poor residents. The presentation of private developments such as PIK as part of national programmes amidst courting more private investors for Kota Tua is an attempt to shore up the authority and influence of the state while redistributing its responsibilities and risks.

In the pursuit of international recognition and revitalising Kota Tua, urban imaginaries such as green and pedestrianised spaces are employed by the state and private actors, while excluding the marginalised from using these spaces in different ways. Such project-based and decontextualised interventions do not take into account their lasting impact on the lives of everyday urban citizens who are left to deal with the haphazard nature and failure of such interventions. One local government officer lamented the unreliable nature of private-led enterprises that involve the government such as the Jakarta Old Town Revitalization Corporation (JOTRC), which appear at the “moment’s need, when it [referring to the government of the day] is in power. But later... we hope it is still there but maybe only its tombstone (*batu nisan*) will be left.”

The tombstone metaphor speaks to the failure of the state-supported private sector revitalisation of Kota Tua for international heritage recognition which has left local authorities and communities to deal with its remnants and new issues. One such remnant is the floating walkways and platforms of the revitalised *Kali Besar* as seen in Figure 6.2, the main canal which was redeveloped after Seoul’s Cheonggyecheon stream (Mariani, 2016a). The walkways and platforms have remained closed off to the public and the river has become stagnant, with algae growth at some parts as shown in Figure 6.3. Private sector developments may demonstrate the power of capital to ‘get things done’ in Jakarta, accentuating government inadequacies in comparison. However, the private sector is rarely held accountable for the detrimental effects of their projects on the environment and communities, a situation which is exacerbated when they are supported or co-opted by the government.



Figure 6.2 View of Kali Besar towards the north from the wide bridge across the canal (Source: Author, November 2022)



Figure 6.3 Part of Kali Besar towards the south showing some algae growth (Source: Author, November 2022)

6.2.3 Bottom-up challenges and agency

The various layers and gaps of top-down and neoliberal approaches on heritage and housing in Jakarta often mean that not only do citizens have to fill in the void left by those with power and money, but they are also increasingly being asked to step up for their communities and contribute to the city's heritage projects and housing solutions. As Coombe and Weiss (2015, p. 43) argue, “under conditions of neoliberalism, ...[T]he enactment of government policy relies increasingly upon the self-empowerment of capacitated citizens and self-organized communities in marketized relationships which position cultural heritage as a resource.” In the case of Kota Tua's kampungs, communities are expected to preserve their heritage, and those which can be commercialised are of special interest in the heritage economy dominated by the state and private sector. This is often amidst less-than-ideal housing conditions which depend on citizens' mutual aid (*gotong royong*) and resourcefulness to overcome economic deprivation. As seen in the previous two chapters, there are conflicting priorities between heritage conservation and housing pressures for residents facing various forms of displacement. Communities often must make challenging choices when dealing with housing pressures, as seen in the modifications and poor maintenance of heritage buildings discussed earlier. But they also seek to alter discourse and refuse top-down approaches, exercising their agency in sometimes unexpected ways.

Looking at housing issues through the lens of heritage and vice versa allows for a refraction that reveals the forms of displacement led by gentrification. Other than allowing for different analytical angles to be seen, on a practical level, heritage-making enables communities to see and engage with each other in a way that brings their shared struggles to the fore, providing opportunities to overcome the otherwise fragmented urban spaces, whether by bureaucracy, territorial jurisdiction, social differences, or individual interests. When people realise how other sites, communities or kampungs have similar stories or claims, or when they hear about how other heritage religious buildings face similar issues in lack of funding and uneven support from the government, they compare and learn from each other, and, in some cases, form communities that not only care about heritage but mobilise on other issues in the neighbourhoods to support each other. For example, Sunda Kelapa Heritage (SKH) and Sohig Langgar Tinggi (SLT), two community organisations focusing on heritage had come together for Langgar Tinggi mosque's rejuvenation, a cultural heritage building which was deteriorating (see Chapter 4). When Covid-19 hit Jakarta, they worked together with one of Pekojan's youth organisations (*Karang Taruna – Katar*) to provide free disinfectant spraying to the Pekojan community to alleviate the shared challenges of preventing the spread of the virus (Pewarta Tambora, 2020).

Such complex situations also brought forth the question of whose heritage and housing are prioritised within and outside the neighbourhoods, which dwells heavily on the construction of difference. I recall a conversation with a neighbourhood leader about housing issues such as dealing with the increasing number of rental properties in kampungs. He said that it was not too difficult for him to reproach someone in his kampung if they were aggressively renting out and creating poor living conditions inside the house and within its surroundings. He attributed this to the fact most residents have a lot in common due to their origins and nature of occupations, unlike kampungs such as Pekojan and Luar Batang which are more diverse. Hence in a sense sharing similar backgrounds generates more pressure to conform to expected social norms and conduct, as compared to when there is more difference among residents.

AbdouMaliq Simone (2014, p. 116) writes about how differences (in the form of jobs, ethnicity, or residential history) might allow some degree of liberation from cultural scripts in the context of households in central Jakarta:

It appears that if a sense of basic difference is maintained, there is not only an attenuation of mutual obligations but also a sense of being able to use the act of paying attention to each other as a means to think about new opportunities and to gain access to new sources of information and impressions.

Reflecting on this in the context of Luar Batang and Pekojan, where their trajectories have been shaped by historical, cultural, social, political, and spatial complexities, differences constructed through heritage-making correspond with the nuanced displacement that residents experience. In the previous chapters on heritage-making and housing issues, I posit that religious heritage-making plays an important role in how kampung actors and communities engage with and transcend the politics of the city that I have delineated thus far. In Pekojan, heritage-making takes on a decentralised nature, with multiple sites of heritage-making and with a higher degree of difference maintained among residents (in terms of jobs, ethnic background, residential history).

In Luar Batang, given past and ongoing displacement attempts on various fronts, heritage-making has become more concentrated around the *masjid keramat*, with the constructions of difference (between locals and newcomers or outsiders) corresponding to the higher level of housing insecurity faced by its residents. The constructions of difference which have emerged from subaltern heritage-making also form a crucial part of the resistance, in the sense that they go against merely “becoming a heritage subject” of the state and non-state actors whose aims are to make “visible and tangible” heritage resources (Coombe & Weiss, 2015, p. 46) to manage and control them. This is not to say, however, that all differences are benign or can remain so, as I will elaborate in the next section.

Through the processes of heritage-making from above and below, the scalar politics between and among the different state, private sector, and resident actors show the overlaps, gaps, and contestations in seeing and producing the city. As we came to the end of the interview at the old temple in Pekojan that has a place for each deity and saint important to its varied visitors, Ibu Yu said that “there is a place for every deity” (*setiap dewa ada tempatnya*). Does this also mean that there is a place for everyone? I now turn to the questions of who is “everyone”, who gets to decide, and how, in the context of heritage-making.

6.2.4 Defining a heritage “community”: experts, private actors, and subalterns

In official global and national heritage discourses, community participation is often stated as an objective (Fitri et al., 2015; Li et al., 2020) and attempts have been made by various government actors to involve non-government actors as discussed in Chapter 4. However, the definition of “community” in practice has been unstable and contested. First, in the case of Jakarta, the role of heritage experts and private interests continue to be dominant in the heritage-making of Kota Tua. The role of experts has been crucial in identifying the various heritage elements of buildings, objects, and traditions, and advising on how these should be preserved and maintained. For instance, Candrian Attahiyyat, as one of the previous elected governor’s advisors, and together with fellow archaeologists, had urged that the only remaining 400-year-old colonial fortified walls in Kota Tua be properly conserved with a heritage status as soon as possible (CNA, 2020). River normalisation plans and urban development, in addition to the ongoing land subsidence, were threatening to destroy it. Their domain expertise has been critical in pushing for more public awareness and protection of disappearing heritage. However they are also bound by what the anachronistic regulations and guidelines say they can do. For instance, as explained in Chapter 4, kampungs fall outside their purview of heritage protection, according to a government appointed heritage expert. They are also bound by their profession’s code of conduct and priorities that until recently did not directly involve community members or multidisciplinary perspectives (see Syahid et al., 2020).

The role of experts has been dominant and comes with its own challenges. The experts’ role is also often time-bound, within the remit of their appointments (such as three years for the Cultural Heritage Expert Team (*Tim Ahli Cagar Budaya* – TACB) and Heritage Review Board (*Tim Sidang Pemugaran* – TSP) under the governor).⁵⁶ Further examination is also needed on what happens when experts move across roles which may require different approaches to heritage (e.g. from identifying and recommending buildings to preserve in TACB, to approving what changes can be made to heritage objects in TSP). Even within expert groups, with their different positionalities as informed by their disciplinary approaches (e.g. archaeology, architecture, urban history) and other considerations, they clash over meanings, values (e.g. ideological), and priorities (e.g. chronological). In such cases, they often have to defer to

⁵⁶ The Heritage Review Board (TSP) was started in the 1990s (Wijayanto, 2022), while the Cultural Heritage Expert Team (TACB) was started in 2014.

hierarchical arrangements, shaped by the legacies of dominant disciplines such as archaeology for the resolution, according to a heritage expert.

Corporate interests continue to be important because although the ownership of many buildings in Kota Tua remains unknown, most of the known ones are not owned by the government (Sastramidjaja, 2014). They are owned by private companies and individuals who are concerned with profit margins and the viability of their businesses vis-à-vis caring for the heritage building as required by law. One café owner who has been in Kota Tua for a decade mentioned that they had to go to court a few times to renovate and maintain their building in the heritage area. While it is expensive and tedious to upkeep old buildings, especially without a supporting budget from the government, they compared private owners like themselves who “love” (*sayang*) the old buildings and would continue overcoming challenges for their love of heritage, to street vendors who have moved into some of the refurbished old buildings following revitalisation efforts to clear the area but “don’t really care about the buildings”.⁵⁷ The Jakarta Old Town Revitalization Corporation (JOTRC), a consortium of private and state-owned enterprises, has been partly credited with helping to revitalise Kota Tua, as part of the UNESCO bid, by partnering with building owners. One heritage expert explained that JOTRC’s formation was partly driven by the meeting of the private actors’ desire to further exploit Kota Tua in the future, and of then governor Joko Widodo’s desire for “action” in Kota Tua which already had various plans and proposals.⁵⁸ However it is not a new *modus operandi* for the state to rely on the private sector as a strategy for governance, or more accurately deferring governance, of current challenging issues by using the private sector to plug “the gaps between the present and the telos of urban development” (Wade, 2023, p. 160) in exchange for maximising profit-seeking advantages.

Second, while there has been an increase in efforts by state and private actors to involve more community stakeholders in the heritage-making of Kota Tua, it has been limited to certain groups. These groups have been perceived by subaltern actors and *kampung* residents to be involved in the production of heritage in its various forms as a means for economic gains. The UNESCO World Heritage nomination attempt reflected not only the growth and reconfiguration of the role of experts and private interests (Nugteren, 2020; Padawangi et al.,

⁵⁷ Personal communication, June 2023.

⁵⁸ For more on the role of private sector in Kota Tua’s World Heritage nomination bid, see Nugteren (2020).

2016; Robertson et al., 2014), but also the parallel heritage-making efforts by select communities, which excluded other less visible community or resident groups that were just as impacted by such efforts. The top-down heritage-making efforts, not just surrounding the UNESCO nomination, but prior to and after, focused on the main areas of attraction within Kota Tua, as demonstrated in Chapter 4. These efforts have given rise to increased justifications for the urban ‘renewal’, ‘regeneration’, or ‘cleaning up’ of the main areas by authorities to achieve the image of a ‘world class’ heritage area.

These efforts suited private interests, but not always the communities which live, work, and play in the Kota Tua area that did not adhere to specific ways of using or being in the heritage and historic area. Post-Covid-19, various commercial walking tour groups have returned to Kota Tua, and the Kota Tua authorities themselves have resumed walking tours and activities in the area, as mentioned in Chapter 4. These tours, a sign that at least some of the areas have arrived at acceptable standards according to urban authorities (in terms of cleanliness, safety, and aesthetics), also alter the spaces. For example, the sites and shops they stop at and collaborate with provide more traffic for these establishments but also the accumulated credentials as spaces which belong (or do not) to the area.⁵⁹ One heritage activist lamented that most of the organisations or community groups which operate within the heritage sector “organise touring events of all sorts, which in the end is about making money. It’s not wrong, but only our group is very radical... If I am looking to earn, I won’t be a radical person, I won’t be someone who dares to have a different voice from whether it’s the government, academic or business circles.” The importance of a not-for-profit principle in using heritage for urban struggles against displacement is a poignant point, given that subaltern actors often do not have sufficient funds and other forms of support to carry out their aims.

In instances where official or commercial Kota Tua activities have ventured into the kampungs surrounding the area, these initiatives often only included the more established or well-known heritage communities which were not based in the kampungs. For the Pokdarwis youth group, since their inception in 2019, they have faced various challenges in being involved in both official and community activities. Its leadership bemoaned how as a formal group formed by

⁵⁹ One tour guide had asked me what I thought about Luar Batang because unlike the other two old kampungs within the Kota Tua area, his impression of Luar Batang was that it was not welcoming to visitors who are not pilgrim groups, that it was not “tourist-ready”, referring to the lack of amenities and easy access to the neighbourhood.

the Ministry of Tourism and Creative Economy in each locality to help advance its tourism, it technically has direct links with government authorities and privileges to organise more effectively than more informal groups. But so far it has been sidelined in any major events taking place in Kota Tua.

In one instance of claiming their space both as residents and member organisation of Kota Tua, Salomah as the spokesperson of the group had told the security guard overseeing one of the entrances along the riverside of Kota Tua that their group was “part” of UPK Kota Tua (Kota Tua Management Unit) and wanted to use the outdoor seating area for a discussion. The guard hesitated but allowed them in as access to the main Kota Tua area was usually closed after 9 pm. In that moment Salomah expressed her frustration at the futility of formal groups and channels in getting resources and things done, and that things moved more quickly if one had insider networks, clout, or was a foreigner. UPK Kota Tua had also resumed free walking tours in the Kota Tua area in early 2024 (Upk Kotatua [@kotatua.jkt], n.d.) which included Kampung Pekojan as one of the routes. One of the Pekojan residents who was usually involved in social or cultural activities in Kota Tua said that the UPK involved the heritage community groups in Jakarta but that the Pekojan community were not actively part of the tours, except perhaps as hosts.⁶⁰

However, it is not only kampung communities that are often excluded from official or commercial Kota Tua activities which take place within their neighbourhood. There are further exclusions among kampung communities where some kampungs are not included in ‘bottom-up’ heritage efforts. A resident whose kampung near *Pasar Ikan* (Fish Market) was evicted a few years ago and rebuilt on the same site in a new vertical housing form mentioned that his kampung tended to be excluded from collective heritage-making even though it sits on a historically important site which no longer has visible remnants. He complained how experts such as archaeologists, government agencies, and even heritage communities in Jakarta tended to focus on historical buildings and remnants, more than the people who lived in the area.

Following on from the above discussion on the role and constitution of ‘community’ in heritage-making processes, I return to the idea of the “subaltern” in this thesis as a category

⁶⁰ Personal communication, February 2024.

which is complex and dynamic in its power relations. As explored in Chapter 4, what is characteristic about subalterns here is the medium of storytelling (*cerita*). While subjected to power dynamics within and outside a community that lead to various forms of displacement, the medium of storytelling is unique as compared to its material heritage counterparts in that it allows anyone to tell a story based on their experiences, beliefs and interpretations to counter narrative displacements (Ahmad, 2022). Others with more power may tell the stories for them (such as through official signages, maps, historical documents, and buildings), but everyone has their own story to tell, a piece in the heritage mosaic to claim, even though some stories may conflict, be buried, or not even heard. It is through these stories that the subaltern voice can come through, as they detail erasures, displacements, disempowerment, othering but also their agency that is often missing from dominant ways of heritage-making.

A youth leader from Pekojan spoke with a sense of pride about the rebellious spirit of the previous generations of leaders who lived in the neighbourhood, which he learnt from the stories passed down from the generations before him. Such oral traditions are crucial, as these stories have not been immortalised in the form of monuments, buildings or signages, given the physical changes in the urban neighbourhood over time.⁶¹ The advent of smartphones and social media has contributed to this source of power to collect, document, and produce knowledge. It takes the struggle for recognition in the physical realm into the non-physical realm of social media, which has allowed various actors to use digital tools and extensions in telling stories, especially those whose stories are rarely centred in heritage-making from above and below. One such example is Ibu Yu, a Chinese woman in her 70s, who is the de facto in-charge of an old temple in Pekojan after her husband's passing. During our interview, she had encouraged me to "go on YouTube" to find out more about the history and components of the temple, which was already out there in the world, a product of her participation in documenting and sharing her knowledge prior to my presence in the field. The intangible claims by such non-elite actors supersede the various boundaries drawn by more powerful actors around not only what is 'heritage' but also who can tell stories as part of heritage-making. Even though subalterns' power to tell stories has been arguably democratised and augmented beyond the local contexts to reach a wider audience, it is still limited as stories are no guarantee against

⁶¹ This is as compared to preserved or repurposed houses or other types of buildings in Jakarta.

displacement, and the complex dynamics within the category of the ‘subaltern’ complicate its impact, which I now turn to.

6.3. Heritage-making as politics from below

Heritage-making has been portrayed in literature and practice as “weapons of the weak”, a much cited phrase from James C. Scott’s seminal book of the same name, a limited form of political participation in authoritarian contexts (Arkaraprasertkul, 2016) as discussed in Chapter 2. More recent works centre the question of what is political “beyond traditional political strategies” such as lobbying, elections, and protest, that take the question of heritage seriously without romanticising urban resistance through heritage approaches which obscure its problematic and contentious politics (El-Kazaz, 2023, pp. 7, 219). Other works have also underscored the importance of paying attention to the “re-politicization of heritage... as empowering emancipatory politics” (Hammami et al., 2022, p. 17) as it presents various openings to contest and negotiate power through a spectrum of politics. In looking at heritage-making as politics and heritage as inherently political, the question of power – its production, forms, and impact – looms large.

In Jakarta, top-down and neoliberal heritage-making through focusing on the built environment, and dominant unifying and internationalising discourses demonstrate that the powerful use heritage-making too, imperfectly, for their own agendas to manage and control users of the space and capitalise on the political, economic and social values of heritage. As the following findings from this research illustrate, among subaltern actors, power is produced when values are (re)created, discourses and boundaries (re)defined, and contested. The political processes of heritage-making from below in the context of housing struggles open up new or latent contestations about difference and inequality in kampungs as a microcosm of society. These contestations not only contribute towards challenging the current order but also affords opportunities for building solidarities and new political formations among subaltern actors.

6.3.1 Ethno-religious and class dynamics

Religious heritage-making, which is a focus in Pekojan and Luar Batang, brings to the surface relations of identity, housing, and politics within the communities which are otherwise hidden or novel. In the example of the Chinese temple where each deity and saint across different

religious backgrounds has its place, heritage-making is not only about housing the gods but also housing the people. Making “*tempat*” (place) on religious grounds helps provide a better sense of housing security for residents, as explored in Chapter 5. Metaphysically, this means that everyone has a right to belong, and morally it is a sacred place that cannot be dealt with haphazardly, therefore having its own power which is unseen, non-linear, and beyond-the-human. In a similar vein, such inclusive discourses and co-existence narratives not only make space for others, but they function to demonstrate a wider base of support for the existence of the religious building beyond their own adherents.

An oft-cited example is about how generations of Chinese residents in Pekojan have made substantial contributions to the restoration and extension of the Kampung Baru Jami mosque (Syahid et al., 2020). In the history section of an internal report, there is mention of how Al Anshor mosque provided shelter to the Chinese who were escaping persecution during the Dutch colonial period, and how some of their descendants then became Muslims and settled there (Muhammad, 1992). Such stories formed the basis of harmonious co-existence in Pekojan for a long time which scholars have noted is in contrast to other parts of Jakarta where Chinese communities reside (Ellisa, 2007; Nas & Pratiwo, 2003). This is until more recent urban changes which recast the ethnic dimension in Pekojan in a different light, which I will return to later in this section.

Other aspects of politics have been become quotidian heritage practices over time, but the political significance has not entirely disappeared. Visiting shrines (*keramat*) and the practice of pilgrimage (*ziarah*), are a constant feature during important political moments such as elections. In various conversations with religious leaders or shrine caretakers, they made it clear that politicians are not allowed to capitalise on their visits for political purposes, whether by bringing their entourage or supporters (they can only make personal visits) or making political speeches in any public event. As one of the Habib’s kinsmen in Luar Batang explained:

At big events, when politicians want to give a sermon (*ceramah*), we don’t allow it. Events are neutral, for worship. In sermons, we talk about sainthood, prophethood, and so on. But usually the politician will want to engage in politics and campaign about himself – that, we do not want.

In Pekojan, a religious leader reiterated that in their religious institutions “there is no space for political lectures, only preaching (*berdakwah*) and education”. However, it is crucial to recognise that when political leaders make it a point to seek blessings, it matters less that it is a personal religious act than the fact that it is a visible public act signalling their religious conviction to garner public approval. By paying homage to predecessors who were not only important religious leaders but also political (and in some cases anti-colonial) figures of their time, political leaders align themselves with heroic, and at times spectacular, legacies and narratives.

There are also more mundane, everyday details of religious heritage which are not necessarily arenas of overt politicisation but are evidence that the everyday is political; the political is in the everyday. For instance, Figure 6.4 shows a sticker at the entrance of a small mosque where a pro-independence social and educational organisation (Jamiat Kheir) was founded, on which a common prayer for entering a house is printed with a black-and-white photo of Anies Baswedan wearing traditional headgear (*songkok* or *peci*). He was the previous elected governor of Jakarta (2017-2022) who later became one of the two candidates during the 14 February 2024 Indonesian presidential election but subsequently lost. In a related example just six months before the election, there was a traditional flower board (*bunga papan*), a large board made up of flowers conveying a message for the occasion, which was displayed at the entrance of an Arab Muslim wedding in Pekojan and which was signed off by then former governor Anies who is of Arab descent himself. While religious leaders at the neighbourhood level may want to leave overt politics out of the picture, the political is in the everyday production of heritage in ordinary spaces and occasions that impact on the sense of belonging or displacement.



Figure 6.4 Politics in the everyday spaces (Source: Author, July 2023)

The role of religion manifests itself in conflicting ways when it comes to issues of class. In studies of gentrification in other parts of Jakarta (see Abaza, 2004; Hew, 2019), religion (in this case Islam) has been used to create distinctions between middle and lower classes in the former's pursuit of a more 'Islamic' environment and lifestyle impacting on processes of heritage making. Gated housing complexes and exclusive communities seem at odds with the idea of shared religious spaces and heritage such as mosques. A consequence of this phenomenon is divergent housing concerns and dynamics between different socioeconomic groups-in-the-making, some of whose concerns I discussed in the previous chapter, such as the differences between *kampungs* and apartment complexes.

However, in Luar Batang, the various collective and individual exhortations not to sell their land and houses to private developers or the state, as well as increasing apprehension about the individual practices of renting out, demonstrate a concern for their gentrifying effects. Such reactions against displacement, by not participating in the lucrative real estate market, hold potential for stemming some of the gentrification effects that may result from the reproduction of religious heritage in the neighbourhood. This is because there is recognition among various actors on the importance of preserving the integrity of the *kampung* (especially its social, spatial, and economic arrangements) to the survival of the heritage building, practices, and narratives.

In Pekojan, as one resident argued, “it is their religious understanding that will prevent people from segregating themselves as a class, which is different from people who only have economic power.” The inverse correlation he makes between religious consciousness and class segregation shapes the kampung’s heritage making (of which he is a part) that centres religion as a way to correct the current trajectory of societal fissures and gentrification-led displacement in his neighbourhood. These fissures include developing class tensions as people emigrate, and the proliferation of vices such as drugs, street fights, unlicensed moneylending, and online prostitution, according to a neighbourhood leader. Remedies for such societal challenges manifest in the form of renewing efforts in religious education and instruction and improving the social and economic life of the residents.

Returning to the ethnic dimension, one of the ways in which ethnic identity has been recast is through heritage-making efforts as responses towards the changes people perceived taking place in their neighbourhood. In Pekojan, comments such as “houses are becoming so expensive that only the Chinese can afford to buy” from both non-Chinese and Chinese residents point to an increased attention on ethnicity as a source of tension associated with the influx of capital. This may run counter to the multicultural unity narrative that has characterised Pekojan for so long, as explored in Chapter 5.

However, the increased attention towards ethnicity is not only of the “other” but also of oneself. For one Pekojan youth, he used to dislike being called an “Arab” in school because he felt that “it sounded like you are not from here [Indonesia]”, that the name-calling was meant to exclude him as an “indigenous” (*pribumi*). He explained how Arabs have always been known as people who did not like to be managed, rebellious, and have been called “*kadrun*” (*Kadal Gurun* – Desert Lizard) in divisive identity politics during elections to portray Indonesian Arabs and their allies as representing radical Islam (specifically in reference to their Middle Eastern origins). The process of learning about his own community through being involved in heritage-making enabled him over time to accept being called an “Arab”, taking pride in their history and contributions as part of “Nusantara” (referring to maritime Southeast Asia), as he explained. I also read this reclaiming of one’s ethnic identity through heritage constructions as a counterbalance to repeated reports of the Arab community’s dwindling population as the number of newcomers from other parts of Jakarta and wider Indonesia increase.

The religious and ethnic dynamics that feature in the heritage-making process reflect the changing geographies of inequality in terms of education, jobs, and housing prices in Kota Tua's neighbourhoods that attract or push away certain types of residents and visitors. In the past these neighbourhoods were seen as spaces of affordable and accessible, albeit informal, housing for low-income groups and migrants alike, as expressed by two young people in their 30s who grew up in Luar Batang. With heritage-making from above and below, there seems to be a greater sense of inequality. Residents in the coastal kampungs, feeling like the city is closing in on them from various directions (the "new Jakarta city" in the north, and Kota Tua revitalisation in the south) look back to the past when informality was allowed, even encouraged, to thrive in Kota Tua. Although far from perfect, people felt that there were more opportunities for the lower middle- and low-income groups to earn a living in Kota Tua before revitalisation attempts, as expressed by a Kota Tua resident. There was trust in the informal "*calo-calo*" (intermediaries, brokers) to whom people paid money to secure their vending or performing spots. This is as compared to the more institutionalised rent-based arrangements nowadays, as street businesses are seasonal and variable while the rental schemes are usually based on linear timescales.

Religious heritage-making in the past has featured the harmonious co-existence among residents of diverse ethnic and religious backgrounds, with overly political elements discouraged from being discussed or pursued. However, in the face of increasing gentrification-led displacement with the changes brought about by the commodification of space, the complex profile of ethnic and class issues has been raised, against the initial inclusive nature of religious heritage-making which has itself become more contentious. The multifaceted gentrification-led displacement is changing the way people relate to and differentiate each other in terms of ethnicity and class, as well as the more latent gendered and generational dynamics which surface within the neighbourhoods.

6.3.2 Gendered and generational dynamics

The role of women in heritage-making is complex because they are under-represented in decision-making and 'expert' roles in both government and non-government organisations, while their knowledge, labour, and time are needed to keep businesses and households running. Several important points highlighting the complexity of challenging top-down processes

surfaced in deeper discussions in the neighbourhood. A few of the female residents interviewed, even those in positions of leadership, often default to deference towards (male) official authorities as key holders of knowledge and ideas about the neighbourhood or city, underplaying their own lived experiences.

It was not lost on Salomah, a Pokdarwis youth leader, that she was the only one among her female peers in their mid-20s who was not married and could spare the time to be involved in activities beyond her immediate family and community. Being the sole female member in her team of five to ten members (which varies depending on changing levels of commitment and priorities), male counterparts often underestimated her leadership capabilities which made her feel more alone in the various dilemmas she faced as a young female leader. Salomah felt that the older mentors who helped found the youth group viewed them in a negative light, expecting them to continue their predecessors' approaches of heritage advocacy for kampungs in Kota Tua yet at the same time chart new paths: "It was like we were left on our own. From one perspective, it was as if they thought the young people don't want to be guided or told what to do... And they also did not want to accept our suggestions." Later on, due to her conviction and leadership capabilities to organise and galvanise not only her group but in collaboration with other youth associations in the region, she was approached by a few political candidates who wanted her to join their campaign leading up to the 2024 general elections. She faced another dilemma of pursuing individual opportunities versus staying the course to lead her group who depended heavily on her to keep them together and move forward – she chose the latter.

In some cases, it was after the passing of the head of family that the role of women in the upkeep of heritage can be seen more clearly. From the current generation of women in their early 70s, Ibu Yu and Ibu Ti have carried on and made their own the roles of taking care of a temple and of a family perfume business respectively. They both spoke of learning the ropes in the background while their spouses were still alive but then had to take the lead after their passing as a matter of preserving traditions and livelihoods. This meant learning how to manage the technical aspects (such as sourcing, production, accounting, marketing, logistics, and maintenance) while navigating sociocultural norms about gender and age, as well as ethnicity (particularly when it differs from their late husband's families) in doing so.

The scenarios above point to a vertical hierarchy that permeates mainstream Indonesian society, particularly at the intersections of age and gender. Different generations have differing values and cultural norms, and varying experiences of societal structures that have informed their approaches towards heritage-making and urban development. They also face different challenges when it comes to heritage-making. The pressures of heritage preservation amidst dealing with everyday urban life are intense for the younger generation who are being thrust into responding to both the present and future at the same time. They are urged to move forward, with high expectations of carrying on legacies while shouldering burdens from the past, as the experiences of Salomah and Khairuddin, among the various youth I spoke to, illustrate.

In one of the vernacular longhouses of Pekojan, the front yard has a family food stall offering traditional specialty dishes which has high traffic during lunch hours from residents and nearby workers. The specialty dishes they offer are increasingly a rare find in the kampung as the older generation of cooks pass on – something that the newly opened food stall at the side of the main mosque in Pekojan aims to remedy, as elaborated in Chapter 4. The son of the current owners, a youth in his 30s, spoke about the challenges of continuing to live in such old longhouses. They cost a lot to maintain and are increasingly anachronistic to contemporary living conditions. He would have liked to renovate the house as his neighbours had done – to have separate areas for business and home, with a modern, minimalist design – but it was too expensive and the older generation preferred to keep the heritage of the building intact. Moving out and selling the house was not really an option at that moment, as young people like him feel compelled to stay together as long as their parents and elderly family members are around.

On one occasion the Pokdarwis group conducted a heritage activity for children from the Luar Batang neighbourhood in the mosque's multipurpose hall during the holy month of Ramadan. It involved answering quiz questions and working in groups of varying ages on puzzles about the history and heritage of their immediate neighbourhood and Kota Tua. In the middle of the session, an older male resident in his 50s who was a regular mosque volunteer came into the hall presumably to observe the activity, but he started offering nominal rupiah (Indonesian currency) notes to the children, saying that the children did not know anything, and that money would better motivate them. His intervention disrupted the activity, and it took a while for the youth organisers to reinstate order, as children were chasing after him to get hold of the rupiahs.

The organisers later expressed their disappointment that the incident took place, as it reflected a money-centric custom and a dismissiveness about young people's capabilities that they were trying to steer away from.

Just as Salomah earlier, Khairuddin, a youth leader from Pekojan, expressed similar sentiments about challenges on moving forward but feeling held back in his community. He described that "in Pekojan, amongst the Arabs, they are challenging to manage... Work wise, it's difficult because they do not like to be told what to do, to follow normal working hours, to be coordinated... Amongst my parents' generation, there are still many who are like that... in my generation, thanks to God, it has started to lessen." At the same time, Khairuddin highlighted another source of tension between the older and younger generation. This is both in the former's attitude towards young people taking action in the *kampung*, and the different stances they might hold towards working with authorities: "There are old folks here who think the young people don't have any business here... This happens a lot. When we want to do something here, surely we would communicate with the government right, such as the sub-district office. That's the thing. It is difficult."

The similar challenges the young people face within their communities when it comes to heritage enabled them a shared process of exchanging information, documenting, learning, and potentially collaborating by establishing horizontal relations that cut across territorial jurisdictions and fragmented urban spaces. This is partly an unexpected outcome of structured organisations like Pokdarwis which facilitate a platform for young people from different parts of Jakarta to participate in the government's plan for them to promote tourism in their respective areas, of which one consequence was competition for resources.⁶² Such engagement also led them to look for mentors who are outside of their respective jurisdictions and communities for advice, guidance and support that might help them overcome the barriers within the community.

I return to the role of the *tokoh* (a community leader or an authoritative figure, not always a formal position), introduced in Chapter 4 as an important source of heritage-making for producing and legitimising narratives, with questions raised about its current forms, roles, and

⁶² Various interviews and observation of events.

limitations. It is widely accepted that the conventional way to approach communities such as those in *kampungs* is through their *tokoh*, and these figureheads' access to the community, power and authority are acknowledged by government officers. Therefore the reputation, fear, trust, and reliability of a *tokoh* present a counterbalance in negotiations with government or private entities, but it can also be a hindrance in other ways. A *tokoh* may find it hard to step away, make space for alternative views, or pass the baton, as the next generation is often expected to uphold the same standards under different circumstances. This can be seen in the above examples showing young people facing structural and social barriers as they navigate a patriarchal environment to alter existing structures, break out of generational patterns, explore new ways of doing things, and reimagine a different future.

Scholars of Indonesia have argued that its patrimonial system, or “*bapak-ism*,”⁶³ is key to understanding the politics of Indonesia. This system “values and highly favors a strong leadership and dominant personality as father figure over a sociopolitically organized system and mechanism” (Wiryomartono, 2020, p. 1). Further, Wiryomartono (2020, p. 6) explains the duality of Indonesia’s societal structure between the “ruling elites – *pemerintah* and *tokoh-tokoh* – and the ruled commoners – *masyarakat* or *rakyat*”. However, wide variations exist within each category, and neither power (or lack thereof) is absolute. As previously mentioned in Chapter 4 by a community leader in Luar Batang that “a *tokoh* is born out of the times,” what happens when the times are different, such as now when gentrification threats loom? This has led to issues of recognition and contestation of the patrimonial system, at least at the neighbourhood level.

First, recognition can be withheld when the prerequisite ‘monumental event’ does not happen. One community’s *tokoh* may not be automatically recognised by another in different localities and at different periods of time. The community leader from Luar Batang commented on how Pekojan might not yet have a *tokoh* because “After independence, [in Pekojan] there is no such event... everything runs normally... There hasn’t been a big company which has come to buy their land. Maybe if that happens, a *tokoh* might be born.” However, the walls of assorted photo frames of respected religious figures, men in robes and traditional headgears in the verandas of some Pekojan houses (such as the one in Figure 6.5) seem to suggest otherwise, as well as a

⁶³ *Bapak* translates literally to father and is used both in formal and social contexts (sometimes *Pak*) when addressing male individuals who are older and/or in positions of authority.

recent book manuscript on the various Arab and non-Arab *tokohs* of Pekojan (Usman, 2019). What this complexity within the patrimonial system (here specifically in reference to *tokohs*) means is that the threat of gentrification-led displacement has arguably challenged, if not redefined, the criteria of being a *tokoh* in these times of contested urbanisms in the eyes of some.



Figure 6.5 Wall of important religious figures honoured in a Pekojan household (Source: Author, July 2023)

Second, when a person expected to be a *tokoh* is not the usual (male) one. In the unpublished manuscript which was produced by a resident community historian, there were at least 40 community figures identified, comprising Arabs and non-Arabs, but all were male. Contemporary heritage-making efforts by women and youth have thrown into sharp relief the way *tokoh*-ship has been framed and practised in Kota Tua and its neighbourhoods, creating a window of opportunity to capture and recognise the other ways (and persons) in which such leadership and knowledge qualities are present. This sets the stage for current and future heritage actors, especially considering the worry expressed by several community leaders and residents about the declining numbers of “*sesepuh*” (wise elders but usually used in reference to men).

Here I return to the story of Ibu Yu, the caretaker of the old temple in Pekojan. She is the knowledge keeper who explains to visitors and researchers about each of the various objects and occasions in the temple; she tries her best to preserve tradition by ensuring that the way it

has always been done by the different beliefs represented continues to be respected; she creates and maintains relations outside of the neighbourhood such as her yearly philanthropic journeys to orphanages and homes to give out essential food items – while she still can. As she said, “I can still climb the truck now. When my legs are no longer strong, I can’t climb up the tall truck”. Women in these roles are continuing respected traditions, but they are also maintaining heritage and creating networks in times of change, leaving a legacy which would otherwise remain hidden as was and continues to be the case. Gendered and generational contestations under patriarchal norms have surfaced through the cracks in heritage-making from below, demonstrating the unequal and exclusionary practices in kampungs that are being redefined by subaltern actors from within.

6.4. Conclusion

Returning to the quote at the beginning of this chapter about competing kampung and state chronologies, this chapter examined the impact of heritage-making processes on state-society politics by different state and private actors at the neighbourhood, city, and national scales, within the context of housing. I argue that contested ideas about urban development are observable in the various urbanisms that perceive and produce the city, enacted via the processes of heritage-making from above and below. The spatio-temporal connections and disjunctures between different authorities through which they manage, control and neglect the less powerful have been made more apparent through detailing the city-state relations, levels of government and political cycles, local-international dynamics, and private-state collaborations.

Heritage-making efforts in Kota Tua reflect different actors’ abilities to voice and act through the openings and cracks between the levels of authority which demonstrate neoliberal tendencies, producing new power formations and politics contesting or entrenching existing conditions. Subaltern possibilities in overcoming the fragmented urban space are demonstrated as actors document, collaborate, and learn from each other, cutting through authorities’ deferment of urgent governance needs. They also reconfigure “community” amidst increased rhetoric and practice of “community participation”, with place-making and constructing difference as resistance and opportunity. However, the forging of horizontal solidarities remains a fraught process as power asymmetries exist within the heritage field that is

inseparable from larger societal structures, in addition to the bottom-up challenges faced by kampung communities and their advocates in the contestation of differences. The category of the 'subaltern' is complicated by gender, age, and ethnic power relations that unsettle the top-down/subaltern binary. Political processes through heritage-making in the context of housing struggles open up new or latent contestations about difference and exclusion in kampungs, reflecting the changing geographies of inequality in Kota Tua and its neighbourhoods. Following from kampung as heritage and kampung as housing strands in the previous two chapters, paradoxically, the displacement pressures and the increased attention on kampungs have contributed to a stronger sense of a kampung as a political identity vis-à-vis the state.

Chapter 7. Conclusion

7.1. Introduction

In this thesis I sought to understand whether heritage-making projects resist or advance gentrification in the context of neoliberal urbanism in Jakarta. Specifically, I wanted to examine the political process of claiming a place in the city, in opposition to gentrification-led displacement that undermines housing security, by centring subaltern experiences and voices. To do so, I delved into three main questions in the context of Kota Tua and its neighbourhoods: how has heritage been constructed by the various stakeholders? What has been the outcome of heritage-making on housing security, as opposed to displacement, for kampung residents? What are the broader impacts of heritage-making processes on state-society politics in Kota Tua and beyond?

I argue that dominant heritage constructions by state and elite actors in Kota Tua demonstrate a top-down logic that centres the built environment and old (colonial) buildings that impact on the surrounding kampungs in various ways. The findings show that the top-down heritage-making tends to drive gentrification through the commodification of space by prioritising capital and material values without much public consultation, not least the residents inhabiting the area. Kampung residents and their advocates also employ heritage-making from below in various forms to reclaim their place in the city in the face of displacement. Through using old and new ways of heritage-making, these actors work to maintain their kampungs as spaces of living heritage, which both reinforces collective spaces and community relations, and introduces unanticipated consequences. Some residents expressed a heightened sense of precarity and social differences such as ethnicity, class, age, and gender that come to the fore in complex and uneven ways. Ultimately, the processes of state-led and people-led heritage-making reveal the ways in which urban development is contested, and the connections and disjunctures between different levels of authorities which subaltern actors experience and use to contest or entrench existing conditions.

These findings build on the current literature on gentrification, heritage, and urban studies, at the intersections of urban geography and politics. Gentrification studies in Indonesia is still relatively new, and even though the markers of gentrification have been identified by various

scholars, there remains much about its political dimensions and impacts that is unexplored in postcolonial contexts of development such as Jakarta. More attention has been given to living heritage and heritage-making from below in heritage studies, but the relations between top-down and bottom-up efforts remain underexamined, reinforcing the binary. Lastly, while modalities of displacement have been recognised as a more comprehensive approach to understanding housing (in)security for marginalised groups, such an undertaking in urban villages of the Global South is wanting, especially considering the (unintended) impacts of current counter-displacement strategies.

These findings contribute to the theorising of the politics of gentrification in heritage and urban studies, the documentation and analysis of Global South cases, particularly Indonesia, in comparative urban research, and ways of thinking about and producing knowledge that considers postcolonial dynamics in Southeast Asia. My research surfaced embedded inequalities in the neighbourhoods which shape and are reshaped by heritage-making processes, as well as housing dynamics which mediate gentrification effects in quite surprising ways. Contestations also take place among state actors that defy simple state-society binaries. Using kampungs as cases contribute to the repository of knowledge about Luar Batang and Pekojan, and the growing literature about ordinary neighbourhoods as sites of gentrification theories in the Global South. Together these multifaceted findings contribute to the knowledge production about heritage and housing dynamics which have implications for local urban policy, planning and governance. These findings are significant because they recast the “from above” and “from below” approaches, showing that while the dichotomy is a useful heuristic to think with, in reality actors located along the different scales of politics are enmeshed with or detached from each other in inconsistent ways across space and time. These unstable relations provide a window into not only the struggles of subaltern groups, but also their agency to shape their urban development.

In the second section, I summarise the main findings of this research, highlighting the most important insights from the data collected and analysed, according to the three main research questions on the process of heritage-making, from above and below, the outcome on housing and gentrification-led displacement, and the broader impact this has on state-society politics in the urban context. In the third section, I evaluate the contribution, significance and implications of the findings, reflecting on the theoretical and methodological framework of the thesis to

outline the strengths and limitations of the study, and recommendations for further research. Finally, I conclude with some final thoughts on the broader contributions of this research.

7.2. Research findings

7.2.1 Process of heritage construction

In providing the context to understand the role of heritage-making in advancing or resisting gentrification in Jakarta, in Chapter 4 I examine the constructions of heritage by various actors in Kota Tua and two of its urban kampungs, Luar Batang and Pekojan. Findings showed that heritage-making in Kota Tua is complex and contested, and that heritage-making in Kota Tua's kampungs is differentially shaped by external and internal factors.

Heritage conservation in Kota Tua is not new, with the first serious efforts attributed to Ali Sadikin during his governorship of Jakarta (1966-1977). However it is only in the past few years that various heritage-making efforts by local authorities, the private sector, and community groups in Kota Tua have increased and are gaining more public attention. This results from a recognition of the colonial heritage of the old town, its commercial and tourism prospects, and increased awareness of cultural features unique to this part of Jakarta. There have been various government, NGO, and private actors with complementary and competing agendas involved over the past few years, notably since the multi-party efforts to get Kota Tua included in the UNESCO World Heritage list. While the nomination efforts were eventually unsuccessful and Jakarta had withdrawn its dossier, heritage-making efforts in and around Kota Tua were impacted and continued to evolve. The initial expectations were dampened, but they nevertheless raised underlying issues of community participation, the role of local leaders, religious influences, and social networks that are part of the wider Kota Tua.

Even though different actors and community groups have been involved in heritage-making in Kota Tua, there were others which were excluded, whether directly or indirectly. Many street vendors, artists, performers, and members of the public have been either cleared from the main square (*Taman Fatahillah*) or relocated as part of the revitalisation efforts. Some of them have been allowed to ply their trades in a more formal arrangement with the local authorities if they suited the theme of the historic square. Local residents and community groups from the surrounding neighbourhoods or kampungs do not have much participation or say in Kota Tua,

even though their daily lives are affected and their labour in various forms are needed. The interplay between the formal economy within the confines of the main square, and the informal economy that exists on the periphery of the area has continued to mask many of the underlying grievances that affect the local communities of Kota Tua.

What happens in Kota Tua impacts on its surroundings and vice versa. Periodic ‘revitalisation’ efforts by the state focusing on the area within the inner walls have resulted in the neglect of other parts of Kota Tua heritage, such as the last remaining parts of the fortified city walls by the Dutch East India Company, and the mushrooming of street vendors along the alleys and roads just across the river. External factors such as capital flows, foreign influence and expertise, national interest and international heritage regimes also impact on heritage-making in Kota Tua. Private sector interests together with the city administration and the national agencies have sought to revitalise the historical centre. This approach of a private-public partnership with a sizeable financing requirement disenfranchises the micro-enterprises which are an integral part of the economic and social knitting of kampungs on the periphery of the old town. More so, this approach sows and deepens the dichotomy between the informal and the formal through regulations, restrictions, and higher cost burdens.

As part of urban revitalisation plans by the state and private sector, tourism has become a priority in the heritage-making of Kota Tua. There have been a wider range and number of activities, events, and marketing in Kota Tua organised by local authorities, private sector, and community groups. While domestic tourism remains dominant given the low barriers to entry, gradually it is becoming evident that as the area is being further revitalised to ‘world class standards’ that the types of businesses, attractions, and food offerings as well as spatial regulations increasingly cater to middle-class and foreign tourists. This is being further amplified by the increase in private apartments and entertainment districts on the edge of Kota Tua to attract regional tourists and investors from places such as Singapore and China. These efforts, while being in the national tourism and investor agenda, overlook the displacement of local communities from these areas where livelihoods and informal settlements have been the norm. In the old kampungs that remain, such as Luar Batang and Pekojan, these developments have had two countervailing effects: the creation of a sense of belonging to a specific community network within each kampung, and the raising of an invisible barrier between community and city administration.

As the main area of Kota Tua is being cleaned up, and top-down and often neoliberal heritage-making gathers momentum, the living heritage of the larger area is being lost or ignored. This happens as a direct result of the gentrifying effects of Kota Tua revitalisation that pushes people and communities out of the area, or indirect consequences of spatial and affective displacement due to changes in which they had no part. Home and heritage-making are integral parts of the development in Kota Tua. Its impact on housing within the context of recognising heritage has an important footprint as communities grapple with holding on to their homes and their religious and communal buildings. Many of these structures are old and worthy of preservation but not necessarily 'tourist'-worthy. The tussle between different forms heritage-making (from above and below), and gentrification on the periphery of Kota Tua is made more complex by diverse stakeholders demarcated by ethnicity, religion, age, and gender. Women play an important role in the informal economy in these kampungs and their livelihoods support children, education, public health and community-building efforts. Many of these gender roles appear during festive periods, the fasting month, weddings, and funerals. These are also fertile times for political interventions by elected officials, but they remain short-lived as allegiances shift or as religious demands overtake political agendas.

Heritage-making in the kampungs respond to external stimuli, in both reactive and anticipatory ways. External stimuli include eviction and displacement threats from state or private actors, government policies and inaction, ecological concerns such as flooding and land subsidence, and mainstream trends on mediums such as social media. When faced with threats of displacement, kampung communities consolidate around symbolic features of heritage such as buildings, narratives, and traditions. They also use popular mediums such as podcasts, walking tours, and video production on platforms like Instagram and YouTube. Religious heritage-making is dominant due to the presence of historical religious buildings, and government policies and programmes which support religious buildings. Kampung advocates also derive inspiration from success stories of other heritage urban villages that centre ethnic traditions, whether in Jakarta, such as the Portugese or Betawi villages, or elsewhere in Asia or Europe. Government inaction has seen heritage buildings within neighbourhoods renovated, repaired, or adapted for residential purposes through bottom-up efforts.

Heritage-making in different kampungs have their own dynamics and priorities. Together with external stimuli, internal factors too shape heritage-making efforts. As spaces which provide homes to migrants in a city with a shortage of affordable housing, kampungs are prone to varying demographic (ethnic, religious, and class) changes which impact on their social dynamics and internal cohesion. Heritage-making then reflects the communities' attempts to be inclusive or exclusive. Land use changes also take place in these strategically located Kota Tua neighbourhoods, where more houses are being converted into rental, commercial, and warehousing buildings. Heritage-making tends to take a backseat when presented with more lucrative opportunities to capitalise on the space in land-scarce Kota Tua. The role of private capital in influencing and promoting many of these programmes cannot be underestimated. The displacement between the formal and informal economies on the periphery of Kota Tua and these kampungs often forces residents to seek such opportunities to maintain livelihoods.

In Luar Batang, heritage-making has concentrated around the *masjid keramat* (shrine and mosque). Kampung life is marked by features such as the spatial, focused on the mosque complex and central location, and the temporal, driven by the rhythms of daily, weekly, monthly, and annual religious events, and night markets. The spatio-temporalities of its religious heritage-making are a shared experience for pilgrims, visitors, and residents, which spill out into the neighbourhood and beyond. Sizeable groups of people travel by private and public transportation from different parts of the city and even overseas towards the kampung on the estuary of Ciliwung river, facing the Sunda Kelapa port. Periodic renovations of the mosque complex take place to deal with flooding, land subsidence, wear and tear, and growing numbers of visitors, as well as a desire to return to 'original' forms, hence increasing its attraction as a site to visit. This is further reflected in the visits by politicians. However these renovations and political posturing by elected officials conceal the competing visions of and contestations among the many other actors such as the mosque committee, the *keramat* kinsmen, funders, architects, residents and other space users.

In Luar Batang, some older heritage has been lost or forgotten. Older residents and visitors spoke about the absence of souvenir shops selling sailing ship models that used to be found in the kampung, and the dwindling of boat rides departing from the edge of the kampung for the port and further islands, ever since the seawall was built to offset the effects of rising sea levels. The impact of climate and ecological changes is felt in the diminished economic opportunities

and erasures of once important skills of craft-making and trades of seamanship. These memories speak to the maritime nature of Luar Batang and its residents given its location on the estuary which is slowly fading as the demographic and ecological contours of the kampung change with uneven urbanisation, rising sea levels, and urban development.

There were also other heritage elements which have disappeared over time. There are a few Betawi-themed houses supported by the local government but all but one gave way to more profitable housing forms. Small-scale printing and weaving enterprises which were brought over and started by Bugis migrants just a generation or two ago have also disappeared. While these elements remain in the memories of a dwindling generation of residents and through old photos, the physical and social landscapes have drastically changed with time.

In Pekojan, heritage-making is becoming more organised but remains diversified. With the revival of branding and discourse of the ‘Arab Kampung’ as part of the three major Kota Tua neighbourhoods amidst rapid urban changes, attention on heritage in Pekojan is being renewed. Various actors (local leaders, youth groups, government agencies, tourist groups, architects and academics) are present in the multicultural neighbourhood at different times in varying capacities. This can be seen in the different heritage-making efforts spread across the neighbourhood’s various heritage buildings (mosques, temples, and houses), its religious and cultural traditions, and buried narratives of education, trade, and independence struggles. These efforts have also come about because of increasing awareness of demographic changes as the older generation pass away, Arab descendants emigrate, and newcomers take their place. This has also raised awareness of the dilution of heritage as the urban landscape has morphed into more current features and forms with vernacular houses being turned into modern ones or functionally changed to warehouses and workshops.

In Pekojan, ethnic dynamics are central to understanding heritage-making efforts. The label ‘Kampung Arab Pekojan’ reflects its history as a colonial quarter designated for Arabs and their Indian Muslim (Moors or Kojas) predecessors, but it also obfuscates others (Chinese and indigenous ethnic groups) that have been embedded within the evolution of the neighbourhood. On the ground, the label gives way to more nuanced ethnic relations and issues that intersect with generational and gender dynamics. Non-Arab residents are supportive and contribute towards the heritage-making efforts of the Arab community to preserve their traditions and

narratives as well as shared heritage such as mosques. However, they also engage in heritage-making which reflect their own aspirations and anxieties about their place amidst rapid urban change. For example, this can be seen in the incremental, bottom-up construction of a Betawi-style heritage and literacy centre under the flyover which separates Pekojan from the neighbouring 'Chinese quarter' (Pecinan). By centering a Betawi (ethnic group native to Jakarta) design as the one-stop information centre at a major roadway into Pekojan, it signals they belong to the city, and the city to them.

7.2.2 Impact of heritage-making on gentrification-led displacement

In Chapter 5, I interrogated the impact of heritage-making on housing conditions, particularly housing security for residents in terms of gentrification-led displacement. Findings showed that heritage-making can be a bulwark against displacement, and it brings more attention to Kota Tua's kampungs in ambivalent ways.

The knowledge and realisation of the heritage value of old kampungs such as Luar Batang and Pekojan have responded to diffuse eviction threats. This process from below of knowledge creation and realisation takes place through stories passed down from one generation to the next, gathering information from public and personal archives, and documenting them through various mediums. Under neoliberal regimes where protecting heritage has meant displacing residents, street vendors and other users of the space, such collective processes present a strong basis for their continued existence as a residential neighbourhood. However, the appreciation of the long-term heritage value is often superseded by the immediacy of economic gains which easily lends itself to commodification. This is a common tension faced by heritage activists and advocates who find it challenging to balance heritage promotion without commodifying it for mass consumption. This also remains as a constant challenge made even more urgent in the face of administrative designs to gentrify Kota Tua and its immediate environs.

Heritage-making thus requires care and organisation that counters displacement in various forms. To be concerned, to learn more, to raise awareness, to protect the kampung's heritage and their habitat through collective efforts help counter the emotional and symbolic displacement felt by residents due to various economic, social, and spatial changes taking place within and around the neighbourhood. Through such a collective process, residents gain and

demonstrate a sense of agency which does not render them as helpless victims to the circumstances. At another level, this process attends to community relations that could fuel resolve for alternatives to overcome the detrimental effects of direct and indirect displacement occurring because of economic and political pressures.

Heritage-making involves reclaiming knowledge production directed towards maintaining a place in the city. The historical role of *kampung* and its residents in building, sustaining, and enriching the city is being resurfaced through known and lesser-known narratives and traditions which have faded over time. The role and lineages of *tokohs* (eminent figures) as knowledge holders in the *kampung* are being highlighted, and their (contested) influence on community and national matters are now summoned to memory. This has the effect of demonstrating that the city owes its destiny to their predecessors who inhabited these neighbourhoods. There are some *kampung* residents who assert the *kampungs*' older and original position as the nucleus from which the city and urban habitat have drawn their inspiration for expansion, development, and economic well-being.

Heritage-making in Kota Tua also illustrated how the definition of heritage extends to living heritage which sustains the community, as Kouri (2022), and Muzaini and Minca (2018) have argued. This includes keeping some traditions alive and resurrecting lost ones in the form of local and traditional cuisines, cultural events, religious festivities, and special community gatherings. This approach, by focusing on living heritage that characterises the neighbourhood's rhythms, works to prevent further indirect displacement of communities by anchoring their heritage-making, the 'doing', in the everyday mundane spaces of their homes and streets. Religious heritage-making also means making space for the intangible, the unseen, which has helped deter haphazard displacement of *kampung* communities such as Luar Batang and Pekojan in a society where the spiritual and supernatural matter significantly.

Heritage-making brings out resident agency to improve their housing conditions beyond just the physical. Given the government's slow response or inaction unless a heritage regulation has been contravened, residents realise that it is up to them to strengthen mutual aid (*gotong royong*) to meet their needs and build community institutions. The idea of self-help is a deeply ingrained feature of Indonesian society, and it continues to exist in urban *kampungs* where migrants bring these values from their rural hometowns. When confronted with the challenges

of an urban administrative culture beset with rules and regulations, corruption, and political interference, residents of urban kampungs have thus sought to resolve issues themselves. This includes incrementally upgrading and fixing their religious buildings to continue to serve the local community, and investing in water, electrical, and health services. Residents also demonstrate their agency and resourcefulness through refusing heritage status for their residential buildings and appealing to alternative authorities for funding and support.

Heritage-making refocuses attention on the importance of the kampung as a particular kind of socio-spatial organisation. In a rapidly urbanising landscape under neoliberal housing policies, the place of the kampung in the city has been side-lined and, in many cases, viewed as an impediment to urban development and modernity. They have often been labelled as slums without reflecting on the wider historical and cultural contexts in which kampungs have evolved. Urban kampungs play an important role in providing labour to the urban economy, and in sustaining an informal network of services that have a bearing on communities within them. In this context, the important role of kampungs in housing a majority of the population whose labour is crucial to the workings of a highly unequal urban agglomeration such as Jakarta has been diminished at a time when housing shortages and prices remain far from resolution. Heritage-making has not only highlighted the heritage value of buildings, narrative, and traditions embedded in kampungs, but also the role of its built environment in shaping meaning and order and vice versa as a building block of urban Indonesia.

Heritage-making brings out the historical and contemporary political, economic and social relations of the kampung to Kota Tua which have been glossed over or neglected. Some mappings include the surrounding kampungs as part of Kota Tua, including the official delineation of the inner and outer Kota Tua, but the recognition of the kampungs as part of the area often ends there. There have been sporadic events and collaborations in the main square in Kota Tua which involve kampung representatives, and increasingly commercial walking tours are returning to the neighbourhoods, instead of just the main tourist areas as part of their itinerary. Some residents also do not see much relation between their neighbourhood and Kota Tua given how the landscape has changed significantly in uneven ways over time, and view the kampung as a self-sufficient, self-reliant, and organic entity upon which urban development has crept. However, the evolution of the kampung and city are often intertwined, even if asymmetrically, as has been shown thus far.

Heritage-making from above and below shapes and reshapes the urban village as a socio-political and economic entity in the city. Heritage-making in the context of administrative boundaries and hierarchical governance reinforces the political, economic, social, temporal and spatial contours of a neighbourhood. Yet the informal economic relations and urban governance within a neighbourhood transcend rigid boundaries. Heritage-making can also be an exclusive enterprise as selective remembering and forgetting take place, and the boundaries of a real or imagined community are constantly drawn and redrawn through such a process. The Arab community is gradually becoming a minority in Pekojan though they were the majority after their Indian predecessors emigrated, and they are concentrated in the heart of the kampung where the main mosque is situated. The heritage-making efforts in Pekojan aim to preserve and revive Arab legacies, narratives and traditions as a matter of survival. This is taking place even as some of these residents have adapted to the local contexts, as inter-ethnic marriages have become more common, and other heritage-making efforts continue to exist.

Heritage-making has become another way of differentiating between kampungs and slums. Even though the physical conditions of old historical kampungs such as Luar Batang and Pekojan vary within each kampung, with some parts looking more 'slum-like' than others, when compared to other less established or non-heritage kampungs, they are less likely to be instantly labelled as slums or informal settlements. This has created another distinction among kampungs of varied legal statuses and conditions, with others eager to engage in heritage-making efforts to gain more legitimacy and value for their kampung. It has also contributed to some tensions among neighbouring kampungs which may not have such unique offerings, adding to the already uneven geographies of urban kampungs in the city. In the case of Luar Batang and Pekojan, the parts of the kampung which are further away from the heritage buildings or spaces tend to also be denser, lacking in adequate infrastructure and services, poorly maintained with a negative reputation. This contributes to debates on spatial inequalities introduced by increasing attention to heritage projects (Herzfeld, 2015).

Heritage-making has brought more attention to the erosion of 'kampung spirit' and creeping individualism. Heritage activists and ordinary residents have faced major challenges in organising, documenting, and reaching out to residents to maintain the tangible and intangible aspects of kampung heritage. A frequent observation and a challenge raised by some kampung

residents in this context is the increasing individualistic behaviour of residents that transcends the generational divide. Whether as a third-generation resident or a new migrant to the neighbourhood, people acknowledge the perils of working for the urban neoliberal wage economy where a hierarchy of self-interests has coalesced. This has led to older residents lamenting the loss of traditional trades which set a different pace and tone in kampung life where barter trade and shared services could also co-exist with the cash economy. The recognition that kampung values are slowly dissipating further lends an urgency to the heritage-making efforts which seek to preserve these values.

7.2.3 Politics of heritage-making from above and below in Kota Tua

In Chapter 6, I build on the insights from the previous two chapters to grapple with the impact of heritage-making by various actors on political processes at various scales within the housing context. Findings show that ideas about the urban within heritage-making is contested from above and below, and that these contestations bring challenges and opportunities in countering gentrification-led displacement.

Ways of seeing and producing the city from above are contested by different actors. These contestations play out in the overlaps, gaps, and disjointed visions of the city, and the policies and programmes which accompany them. Jakarta exists as a “big kampung”, a postcolonial megacity, a special capital region, and a Global South city. These different facets of the urban conurbation do not layer up as neatly as it seems on paper. As a special capital region, it has a unique latitude for urban policymaking and development, but it cannot escape from the dictates of national priorities and ambitions which are not always aligned with the pressing issues and needs of the city. Observing the time-bound policies and programmes of each Jakarta governor – whether they align with the central government’s – would demonstrate this point because the gubernatorial position is often a stepping stone to presidency.

While there are more national projects in Jakarta than in other Indonesian cities, by virtue of its role as the cultural, political, economic and financial capital of the country, Jakarta faces certain issues when it comes to heritage-making. Local institutions such as the UPK Kota Tua do not have the required authority to carry out its responsibilities in an urban landscape where overlapping and hierarchical government agencies operate. In the pursuit for international

recognition such as the UNESCO World Heritage listing, the private sector's role in providing capital, investment and vision comes through clearly, even if their presence on an everyday level in Kota Tua and its neighbourhood remains obscure. Thus the imprint of various state and private actors on the city is uneven, contested, and leaves room for other less powerful actors to manoeuvre.

The bottom-up processes of heritage-making demonstrate that subaltern actors also have competing visions for the city. Kampung residents often have more immediate priorities and concerns to keep their families afloat in an increasingly neoliberal economy while dealing with various ecological issues that impact on their everyday life. In Jakarta these ecological concerns have a political bent as well, with different agencies and officials pronouncing conflicting programmes that have questionable results. These conditions have arguably fomented a change in the nature of the social compact, with residents in Luar Batang particularly lamenting the rise of individualism and the decline of kampung spirit. However, for kampung activists, part of their struggle is to transcend the dominant narratives which frame the issues of heritage making. They use heritage to reclaim their rights, and by re-defining the framework, question the dominant ways of doing and being in the city.

Using a heritage lens to examine the ways in which the city is seen and produced allows cracks and openings in contested urbanism to show, presenting opportunities for subaltern groups to redefine urban politics. The eclectic and contingent heritage-making and housing practices of kampung communities defy various top-down, neoliberal attempts to quantify and commodify both the tangible and intangible aspects of housing within heritage. This can be seen in the religious realm where the spatial and temporal politics of the city, as determined from above, are engaged with and transcended through the honouring of deities and saints, as well as in everyday life. Through working creatively with a wider range of actors other than those conventionally part of the heritage arena (such as the Ministry of Religious Affairs, overseas networks and resources), activists are able to preserve their heritage and sustain their communities through different means.

There are also contestations about whose view and production of the city matters. As community participation becomes an accepted norm and discourse in city-making, there is a need to examine who can participate and what is considered participation. In the heritage arena

of Kota Tua, the role of experts and private sector remains dominant because of the mainstream Authorised Heritage Discourse (AHD) approaches and market mechanisms which privilege those with the right economic and social capital. Amongst heritage communities, there are groups which are more established in terms of connections, outreach, reputation, and given more opportunities to collaborate in events and activities in Kota Tua. Meanwhile others that are more community-based tend to be engaged only sporadically or are often sidelined. The differentiation also comes down to which community's heritage is worth including in the city's repertoire without considering the uneven contexts in which they were produced. These contestations show the dynamic process of subaltern urbanism where the subaltern is not a fixed, stable entity, but rather an identity and social position which is relational.

Urbanism, as a developmental project, is beset with political demands from various participants - national government officials, city administrators, elected officials, private sector, and city dwellers. The urban kampung is seen as a less important component within the city dweller segment, yet its claims to heritage have deeper roots and a stronger resonance with how urbanism affects lives. For the urban kampung residents, housing and daily livelihoods are paramount concerns that are affected by the political machinations of urban renewal and heritage-making by different actors. This research has highlighted the importance of involving kampung residents if state actors want to reduce resistance to heritage projects especially in and around their neighbourhoods.

Yet the heritage-making process has facilitated possibilities for horizontal solidarities in a fragmented urban space. Although the youth groups in the two kampungs were navigating different kampung contexts, they realised that they faced similar challenges in the process. These included managing the expectations and legacies of the older generation, organising their fellow youth to develop more interest and care about their own community, and dealing with the hierarchical nature of authority and bureaucracy in Kota Tua's jurisdictions. They shared their experiences, exchanged information, and discussed strategies to deal with the challenges. Heritage activists also worked across kampungs, sharing their knowledge and experiences, as well as rising to the occasion when they receive a call for help. In the case of various heritage mosques in Pekojan, other heritage and community organisations came down to help restore, renovate, and raise awareness about the heritage buildings and traditions in the kampung. These

relations extended to times of crises such as the Covid-19 pandemic, fire accidents, and flooding.

Heritage-making processes have also impacted on identities in different ways. Even though in both Pekojan and Luar Batang religious heritage-making is the focus of the community, the process has brought to light the complex intersections of religion, ethnicity, class, age and gender. In Pekojan, religious heritage-making serves as an inclusive endeavour that accommodates the various religions and beliefs present, beyond the Islamic core at the heart of the kampung. This is happening at the same time as the anxiety that generational residents (be they Arabs, Chinese, or indigenous ethnic groups) increasingly have about newcomers who are not familiar with the way of life in the kampung (e.g. that of mutual aid, neighbourliness, multicultural coexistence). The presence of newcomers has been perceived as altering the physical architecture of the kampung, as residents spoke about more gated compounds, and more commercial functions overtaking residential compounds. In both kampungs, inter-communal and generational tensions came through when speaking to older and younger residents about their perceptions of the other, and the understated role of women in not only managing the household and economic production, but also in heritage-making processes.

Contestation of existing societal dynamics when seen through the heritage lens has illuminated political processes which have the potential to enact change. One of the longstanding vertical power structures as noted by some scholars of Indonesia is the patrimonial system, or “*bapak-ism*” where respect and authority is given to men, usually elder, whether in formal or informal settings. As discussed in previous chapters, youth groups are working with, against, and through existing power structures and relations to introduce new ways of conceptualising, preserving and engaging with heritage, such as using digital technologies and platforms. In the field, I came across various instances where women, particularly older women, have carried the mantle of organising, managing, and maintaining heritage-related enterprises at various levels or have been doing so in a more unassuming manner that is hardly noticed. At a moment when knowledge is being produced by kampung communities to document their histories and heritage amidst urban change, it is also a chance to take notice of these moments which are challenging the existing order in limited ways, as argued by Arkaraprasertkul (2016).

The heritage-making process has also seen some aspects of politics de-emphasised but emerge or remain present in more mundane ways. In Luar Batang, the growing dominance of the *masjid keramat* and its accompanying rituals and rites, at a time when the kampung faces various social, political, economic and ecological pressures, has galvanised the community around its heritage-making. The accompanying informalities commonly associated with famous religious sites have also reappeared with some vengeance after the mosque compound's latest renovations, as older women with young children are seen aggressively asking for money, and young men collecting money for parking or arranging visitors' slippers outside the prayer hall. In both kampungs, religious and mosque leaders are strict about not allowing politicians to use *keramat* visits or the pulpit for political mileage or campaigns. Yet in obvious and less conspicuous spaces and surfaces in the kampungs, one can sometimes see a candidate's banner between the alleys, a wedding or funeral flower board from a politician, or a prayer sticker with a politician's face on a gate.

7.3. Evaluation of research

7.3.1 Contribution, significance, and implications of findings

This thesis contributes to the theorising of heritage and housing as urban politics, documentation and analysis of Global South cases in comparative urban research, and ways of thinking about and producing knowledge that considers postcolonial dynamics in a Southeast Asian city. From the literature review, I distilled that gentrification is under-theorised in Southeast Asian contexts where the conditions of class formation, urbanisation process, and postcolonial society are varied, and where questions of heritage preservation are often intertwined with rapid urban development. Through my research, the understudied political intersections of heritage and housing processes surfaced embedded inequalities along ethno-religious, class, age, and gender lines in the context of Jakarta's Kota Tua and its kampungs.

Various gentrification debates have suggested that the state is a central actor in neoliberal urbanism (Lees et al., 2016; Ley & Teo, 2020), but it is often treated as a unitary and unchanging actor. My findings show that the state-driven urbanism is not so straightforward. The question of who makes up the state and its agents, where their powers lie, and variations across time (e.g. electoral cycles, office terms) and scale (e.g. neighbourhood, city, national) needed further examination. My findings support the argument that the state, together with the

private sector and transnational actors which it courts, is causing gentrification beyond gentrifiers from the middle classes (Koh, 2019). My findings further show that the contestations among and within state and society actors defy simple binaries, and that the politics within each category has been impacted by heritage-making processes. In particular, the overall complexity within the category of ‘subaltern’ (ethnicity, gender, age, power relations) complicate the powerful-subaltern binary.

On heritage-making, to address the puzzle of whether heritage-making contributes to gentrification processes in Kota Tua, the findings show that there is more nuance beyond the binary implied by the question. This is due to the dynamics of intersecting ethnic, religious, gender and age factors that influence the conditions, mechanisms, and outcomes of counter-displacement strategies in the kampungs. The heritage-making lens helps uncover the competing processes of knowledge production and valorisation that shape the city as a political site to be reclaimed from dominant gentrification agendas, contributing to the growing critical scholarship on “global urbanism from below” (Leitner & Sheppard, 2021) and “heritage from below” (Muzaini & Minca, 2018).

By inquiring into the constructions of heritage, centering the knowledge and concerns of the different actors, the heritage-gentrification relationship is examined. The nuances of heritage-making processes imply that successful resistance against gentrification may not be immediately obvious or achievable, and hence gentrification is not a foregone conclusion. For instance as mentioned in Chapter 2, religious gentrification in Jakarta has been argued to be a driving factor for the increasing socio-spatial distinctions between middle and lower classes as the former pursue a more ‘Islamic’ environment and lifestyle that impact on heritage-making (Abaza, 2004; Hew, 2019). However, the cases of Luar Batang and Pekojan show that it is not quite that simple. In Luar Batang, the concerted efforts to dissuade people from selling their land and houses to private developers or the state, as well as increasing apprehension about the individual practices of renting out, demonstrate a concern for their gentrifying effects. Such reactions against displacement hold potential for attenuating some of the gentrification effects from the reproduction of religious heritage in the neighbourhood. In Pekojan, religious heritage and traditions are being reinforced or reintroduced to counter spatial and affective displacement as a result of changes in the built environment, demography, and increasing tendencies of

people who are doing better economically to separate themselves from the rest of the community.

Gentrification studies in Southeast Asian contexts have focused on superblock development and gated communities which have been on the rise, and examining kampungs as urban villages have brought to bear even more clearly the uneven processes of gentrification. This has been done in this thesis through understanding the kampung as a political entity with its own identity that is not necessarily fixed but always being internally and externally challenged. Further, building on Zukin's (2007, p. 47) observation that urban villages as neighbourhoods "cannot be studied in isolation, as specimens of a social class or an ethnic group, without understanding their hierarchical relation to other areas of the city", examining heritage-making of and by kampungs in the Kota Tua area further brought out the kampung as a site of contested urbanisms present in the city. This scalar approach to understanding heritage-making allowed the various forms of displacement experienced by residents to be articulated and the broader political processes behind heritage-making and housing issues in the city to be drawn out. The implication is that kampungs cannot be easily reduced to certain heritage labels or projects without examining the historical and current dynamics and relations as these affect housing security of subaltern communities.

Examining the two neighbourhoods in Kota Tua has contributed significant empirical evidence for each of the case studies, and for piecing the dynamic mosaics of the neighbourhoods as the different actors reconstruct their past in the present at a critical time of change. Prior to this, there have been various single case studies focusing on particular architectural, historical, morphological, and religious features in the kampungs, or a general overview. Through studying the two kampungs, the richness of their social, economic, and political life as well as the problems subaltern groups face and their agency can be documented.

This study fills the gap on how these various aspects come together in the wider context of Kota Tua and in conversation with each other, at this moment in their histories. In both Luar Batang and Pekojaan, the communities are at a crossroads where there are various external and internal changes taking place. The heritage approach has been an avenue in which these changes are observed and contain potentialities for uniting the community around a common project, as well as creating divisions.

Using Jakarta and its neighbourhoods to think about and produce knowledge that is grounded in postcolonial considerations led to several methodological insights. Building on critical scholarship on neighbourhood as method and key site for social change, the variations across and within neighbourhoods are given more attention (Leitner & Sheppard, 2021; Padawangi et al., 2022; Steele, 2018). The varied notions of heritage, housing, and gentrification-led displacement that surfaced in the findings led to a thinking of their relations in the Jakartan and wider Indonesian contexts, as well as with other cases elsewhere. This was also achieved through individual and collective efforts to translate and interpret complex concepts and lived realities for various audiences such as the research participants and readers, in the present and future. The process of inter-referencing between people, neighbourhoods, cities, and countries added to the direct exchange, learning about similar issues and the conditions of others in a way that drew out the connections, self-reflections, and appeals for mutual aid.

7.3.2 Limitations and recommendations

While this study has contributed to understanding the relationship between heritage-making and gentrification, there are inevitably limitations, either due to contextual decisions made by the researcher or uncontrollable factors. The time and labour constraints of a doctoral research which is not detached from personal, local, and global events also shaped the contours of the study. This thesis focused on the sociopolitical dimensions of heritage-making and displacement to build on existing works which underscored a need for such analyses as noted in Chapter 2. Due to the qualitative nature of the research which is based on the premise that knowledge is partial and situated, there are a several limitations that need to be addressed, most of which have been covered in Chapter 3.

The contemporary nature of the study limits the extent to which change can be observed and the conclusions reached about the research questions cannot be generalised. Since the heritage value and construction of something changes over time (Smith 2011), the arc of change may not have been sufficiently captured in this thesis. Furthermore, since the research question is also addressing outcomes and impacts of heritage-making up till date, the study is limited to what can be known now, through the methods chosen. This is especially considering the

novelty of the heritage-making processes taking place in response to the changing contexts within and without the kampungs in Kota Tua.

Returning to the comparative approach where a comparison can be about “thinking with variation and repetition” towards innovative theory building (Robinson, 2016), future research could include newer and less established kampungs to examine how the heritage-gentrification relationship plays out. This would open up the theorising about kampungs as sites of contested urbanism – how heritage is being contested, by whom, its impact on displacement and politics from above and below. Comparing with neighbourhoods in other old towns across Indonesia or the region which are at varying levels of development could also contribute to understanding the dynamics between heritage-making, housing and displacement in historic parts of the city.

Future research could also follow the trajectory of these processes to observe the longer-term effects that may not be currently apparent, considering that the recent redrawing of the boundaries of Kota Tua, and in 2024, the presidential, parliamentary, and regional head elections, as well as the formal move of the capital from Jakarta to Nusantara in East Kalimantan.

7.4. Conclusion

In this chapter, I return to the initial puzzle which motivated this thesis – whether heritage-making projects resist or advance gentrification. I sought to address the question: how do heritage-making projects of and by urban villages affect housing conditions in Jakarta, with reference to gentrification-led displacement? In this thesis, I organised my findings along three lines of inquiry on process, outcome, and impact.

Heritage-making as a process of meaning-making different actors pursue for different ends in the context of rapidly urbanising Jakarta with rural-like settlements in its midst showed that it is a process which is complex and contested, and that is shaped by external and internal factors. Dominant heritage constructions in Kota Tua demonstrate a top-down logic that emphasises the built environment, with a strong private sector presence. The increasing commodification of space, where capital and material values are prioritised with little consideration for the residential neighbourhoods and livelihoods, lends evidence to the imprint of neoliberal

urbanism in gentrification-led displacement. The push towards becoming an international tourist destination is contested by residents and their advocates who employ heritage-making from below in various forms, at times reappropriating or subverting dominant discourses, with their own dynamics and unintended consequences.

Heritage-making as a collective process of agency, care and organisation can be a bulwark against the various forms of displacement residents face, and it has brought more attention to Kota Tua's kampungs as the enduring nucleus of the city that are also experiencing changing geographies of socio-political and economic inequalities. Heritage-making by various actors show that urban development is contested from above and below as seen through overlapping and disjointed ways of seeing and producing the city. The connections and disjunctures between different authorities provide avenues for subaltern actors to contest or entrench existing conditions. The varied and often pragmatic heritage and housing practices of kampung communities elude top-down and neoliberal attempts to commodify both the tangible and intangible aspects of the kampungs, and in various cases foster horizontal solidarities which transcend the fragmented urban spaces. Internal differentiations and contestation of identities are part of the heritage-making process and while they surfaced some tensions in neighbourhood relations (e.g. generational, ethno-religious, political), they also illuminate understated aspects (e.g. gender) that could pave the way for change.

By bringing these questions and cases to bear upon the Anglophone literature, I contribute to diversifying the discourse and deepening the theorisation of gentrification, heritage, and housing issues in urban politics. More specifically, the comparative case approach centering on Kota Tua and its two neighbourhoods which brought into dialogue urban cases from elsewhere in Indonesia and Southeast Asia produced unique opportunities and challenges of inter-referencing - only some of which have been covered in this thesis.

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Appendix 1. Summary of interview participants

Case	Participant (role, occupation)	Age	Gender
Luar Batang	1) resident, student educator	20s	F
	2) resident	30s	F
	3) resident, local women's organisation	40s	F
	4) resident	50s	F
	5) resident, small food business owner	50s	F
	6) resident, small food business owner	60s	F
	7) resident, runs a home kiosk	60s	F
	8) resident	60s	F
	9) resident	70s	F
	10) resident, Pokdarwis member	30s	M
	11) resident, youth leader	30s	M
	12) resident, creative	30s	M
	13) resident	30s	M
	14) resident, educator	40s	M
	15) resident, runs a mosque souvenir kiosk	50s	M
	16) former resident, Habib's kin	50s	M
	17) resident, neighbourhood leader	50s	M
	18) resident, mosque management, community leader	50s	M
	19) former resident, community activist	50s	M
	20) resident, small food business owner	60s	M
Pekojan	1) resident, educator	40s	F
	2) resident, neighbourhood leader	60s	F
	3) resident, runs small family business	60s	F
	4) resident, temple caretaker	70s	F
	5) resident, youth leader	20s	M
	6) resident, neighbourhood leader	40s	M
	7) resident, mosque leader	40s	M
	8) resident, neighbourhood leader	40s	M
	9) resident, community historian	50s	M

	10) resident, mosque caretaker	50s	M
	11) resident, mosque leader	60s	M
	12) resident, family business owner	60s	M
	13) resident	60s	M
	14) non-resident, religious leader	60s	M
	15) resident, neighbourhood leader, religious leader	60s	M
Kota Tua/Jakarta	1) resident, Pokdarwis member	20s	F
	2) resident, researcher (Pilot, online)	20s	F
	3) resident, researcher (Pilot, online)	30s	F
	4) resident, heritage expert (Pilot, online)	30s	F
	5) resident, civil servant (Pilot, online)	30s	F
	6) resident, heritage activist (Pilot, online)	40s	F
	7) resident	40s	F
	8) former resident, runs a roadside stall	60s	F
	9) educator, heritage consultant (Pilot, online)	30s	M
	10) resident, Pokdarwis member	30s	M
	11) resident, community architect (Pilot, online)	30s	M
	12) resident, community architect (Pilot, online)	30s	M
	13) government appointed heritage expert	40s	M
	14) resident, PIK employee	40s	M
	15) local government officer (UPK Kota Tua)	50s	M
	16) local government officer (Conservation office)	50s	M
	17) former resident, roadside stall owner	60s	M
Total	52 interviewees		

Appendix 2. Semi-structured interview questions (English and Indonesian)

Housing conditions in Jakarta:

- What do you think about the housing conditions/situation in the city?
- What do you think is the place of kampungs in providing housing in the city?
- Are there any factors which may affect housing in the future?

Kondisi perumahan di Jakarta:

- *Bagaimana kondisi perumahan/permukiman di kota?*
- *Menurut Anda apa tempat/peran kampung dalam menyediakan perumahan/tempat tinggal di kota?*
- *Apakah ada faktor-faktor yang dapat mempengaruhi perumahan/kampung di masa depan?*

Heritage-making projects in Jakarta:

- What is your understanding of heritage?
- What do you think are other understandings of heritage? (local government, national government, heritage bodies, other residents of different social backgrounds such as class, age, ethnicity) and what are your thoughts on them?
- Are all kampungs considered a heritage or only some? Why?
- What is the focus of heritage-making in this kampung? Has it changed, and if so, how and why?
- What knowledge, (digital) tools and platforms are used in heritage-making?

Proyek kontruksi heritage di Jakarta:

- *Apa pemahaman Anda tentang heritage? Apa itu heritage/cagar budaya/pusaka/warisan/budaya/peninggalan?*
- *Adakah pemahaman lain tentang heritage? (pemerintah daerah, pemerintah nasional, lembaga warisan, penduduk lain dari latar belakang sosial yang berbeda seperti kelas, usia, etnis) Dan apa pendapat Anda tentang mereka?*
- *Apakah semua kampung patut dianggap sebagai heritage? Mengapa?*
- *Apa fokus pembuatan/kontruksi heritage di kampung ini? Apakah itu berubah dari dahulu, dan jika demikian, bagaimana dan kenapa?*
- *Pengetahuan, alat (digital) dan platform apa yang digunakan?*

Outcomes and impacts of heritage-making:

- Is your kampung/kampung community more or less secure than they used to be with the increase in attention (e.g., since around the time Jakarta made the UNESCO world heritage bid in 2015)? Why?
- What are the wider impacts of heritage-making in the kampungs on politics?
- Are there any factors which may affect heritage-making practices in the future?

Hasil dan dampak konstruksi heritage:

- *Apakah komunitas kampung/kampung Anda lebih atau kurang aman/kehidupan dipersulitkan dari sebelumnya, dengan peningkatan perhatian (misalnya, sejak Jakarta mengajukan tawaran warisan dunia UNESCO)? Mengapa?*

- *Apa dampak terhadap politik/hubungan/relasi antara warga dan pemerintah?*
- *Apakah factor-faktor yang akan mempengaruhi pelestarian heritage di masa depan?*

Appendix 3. Consent Form

Consent form (English version)

Title of Study: Heritage politics and the urban village in Jakarta

Name of researcher: Irna Nurlina Binte Masron

I have been informed about the nature of this study and willingly consent to take part in it.

I agree to the following data collection and processing approaches being used for my data:

- 1) Recorded interview
- 2) Visual and other materials provided by me
- 3) Transcription and analysis by the researcher
- 4) Sharing of the research in academic and policy channels

I understand that I will not be identifiable in any presentation of this research without my further, written, consent.

I understand that if deemed appropriate, specific permission will be sought from me for the reproduction of any visual materials in public outputs.

I understand that I may withdraw my data at any time (up to 6 months after the interview date) before it has been anonymised and combined with other data for analysis.

I am over 16 years of age.

Name

Signed

Date

There should be two signed copies, one for participant, one for researcher.

Lembar persetujuan (Indonesian version)

Judul Penelitian: Warisan dan perumahan di urban kampung Jakarta

Nama peneliti: Irna Nurlina Binte Masron

Saya telah diberitahu tentang sifat penelitian ini dan bersedia untuk mengambil bagian di dalamnya.

Saya setuju dengan pendekatan pengumpulan dan pemrosesan data berikut yang digunakan untuk data saya:

- 1) Wawancara yang direkam
- 2) Visual dan materi lain yang disediakan oleh saya
- 3) Transkripsi dan analisis oleh peneliti
- 4) Berbagi penelitian di jalur akademik dan kebijakan

Saya mengerti bahwa saya tidak akan dapat diidentifikasi dalam presentasi apapun dari penelitian ini tanpa persetujuan tertulis saya lebih lanjut.

Saya memahami bahwa jika dianggap tepat, izin khusus akan diminta dari saya untuk reproduksi materi visual apa pun dalam keluaran publik.

Saya memahami bahwa saya dapat menarik data saya kapan saja (hingga 6 bulan setelah tanggal wawancara) sebelum data tersebut dianonimkan dan digabungkan dengan data lain untuk dianalisis.

Saya berusia lebih dari 16 tahun.

Nama

Tanda tangan

Tanggal

Harus ada dua salinan yang ditandatangani, satu untuk peserta, satu untuk peneliti.